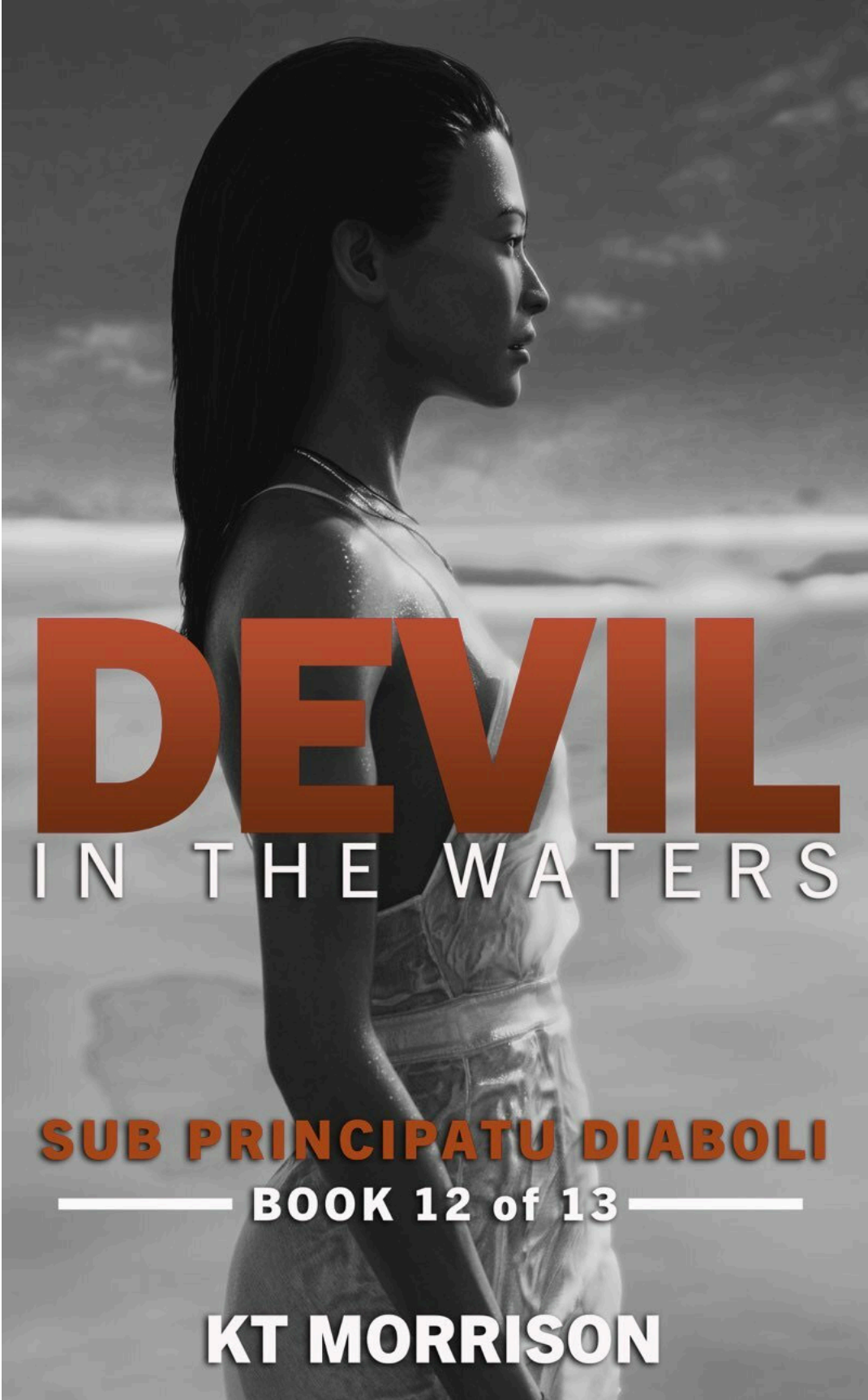




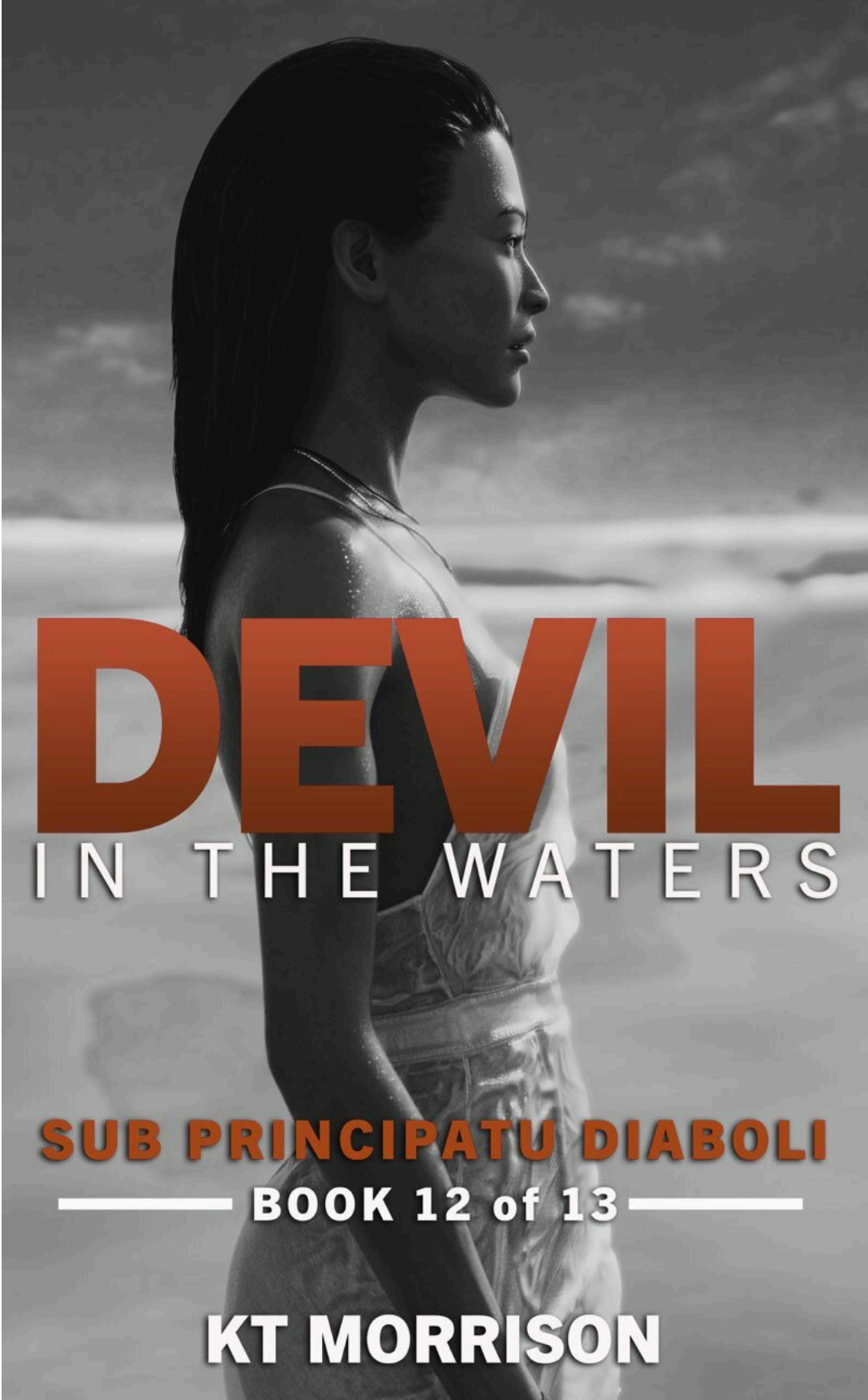
DEVIL

IN THE WATERS

SUB PRINCIPATU DIABOLI

— BOOK 12 of 13 —

KT MORRISON



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BOOK 12

KT MORRISON

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

SUB PRINCIPATU DIABOLI

A DEVIL IN THE WATERS Novel

41,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

FOREWORD

I know I said there were only going to be 12 books, but please consider 13 the Devil's Dozen. There will be one more book to wrap up all the lingering questions and closing all the loose threads.

The 13th book, The Unity of Opposites, is already under way on my Patreon and on my Ream and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

ktmorrison.com

On my Patreon and on my Ream you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ONE

RESPITE

Things looked to be moving fast for Meyer. Arranged around Meyer's sink basin were toiletry items not intended for a thirty-year-old man, nor for that man's six-year-old daughter. A pink razor. Sophie wasn't shaving yet, surely. Lady Speedstick, an adult size toothbrush in pink. A well-traveled L'Oréal giveaway toiletry bag that looked older than Sophie. Josh washed his face and brushed his teeth, then zipped up his toiletries inside his own well-traveled kit. Everything surrounding him existed in a foreign juxtaposition, and, though he'd had no way of knowing ahead of time, the decision to crash Meyer's place was a clear mistake. Last night, it had seemed like his only option.

Now showered and dressed for work, he emerged to join Meyer in the kitchen, a man out of place. When he'd arrived last night, bag in hand, he hadn't expected Meyer to have a lady visitor. He totally forgot his cousin was a man out of place as well, and a man who wanted to situate himself in something that had meaning. Meyer intended to find meaning with Quinn, Samara's friend, who'd come along into their lives by chance, and Meyer had seized the opportunity the way a bold man would do. He'd like to commend his cousin, yet Quinn's presence had him mute. He wasn't able to discuss anything last night, could barely even insinuate why he might have shown up unannounced on Meyer's doorstep in the middle of the night. He'd demurred, tried to back out of staying, but neither Quinn nor Meyer would hear of it, probably reading the toil and pain on his face and realizing he looked like a man who shouldn't be alone on a night like this. There was no need to say to them it was marital trouble. What else would it be? And the worst thing: as he sequestered himself away from Quinn and Meyer, letting them get back to their apparent Netflix-and-Chill session, he'd lain in Sophie's bed and let his mind wander. Quinn had been at the Dragon that day Devlin had showed up to gift Kimmy a trip to Cayman. It had been so

obvious to all but him. Quinn must have taken one look at Kimmy's tall and handsome and rich boss and known right away Kimmy was fucking him. It sickened his stomach. Devlin fucked women like Kimmy. He didn't drop by and give them gifts in front of their husbands because he was a nice guy. He wanted Josh and all of Josh's friends to know he was giving Kimmy the big dick when Josh had his back turned. He'd been a fool all this time. He'd told himself over and over how Kimmy wouldn't do that, how it was Devlin's manipulations making him think that way, how there was a dark half he had that was aroused by the sick thrill of his wife's infidelity, and his wife had learned to tease it. If he'd just stepped back and looked. Really looked. If he'd got drunk with a woman like Quinn, he bet she would have given it to him straight right then and there: Dude, that fucking guy that came here?—he's definitely banging your wife.

He heard the hushed tones of two people talking and not wanting to be overheard, and it amplified his humiliation. Meyer knew it now, too. A woman like Quinn would positively put it straight with his cousin, who loved Kimmy and had remained dubious this whole while. Meyer would have told Quinn how Josh had asked him to watch Kimmy when he was in Rome. His heart sank into his stomach when they abruptly ceased their quiet chatter when they heard him coming. It felt like a mouse had died behind his drywall and began to rot and fester now in the pit of his stomach.

"There he is," Meyer said as Josh joined them in the kitchen. "How'd you sleep last night, buddy?" Meyer's pandering sympathy showed how Quinn had convinced him last night of the trouble Josh found himself in. His cousin hadn't believed Josh, but he believed Quinn.

He plastered a happy facade on his face. "Great. That's an awesome bed. Sophie must get lost in it."

"She'll grow into it, cuz. Grab a glass, I'll pour you an OJ."

Quinn said, "There's coffee. Let me grab you a cup. How do you take it?"

"Don't fuss over me, guys. I'll just grab something on my way into the office."

“You should stay for breakfast,” Quinn said. She looked cute without her makeup, dressed in PJ shorts and a big sweatshirt.

“I really want to get out of your guys’s hair.”

“Don’t be crazy, man. Fuckin’ come back here tonight if you want. We’ll stay up and Xbox, order a pizza. Seriously.”

Josh ruffled his hair. “I don’t know what I’m going to do yet.”

“You’re welcome here anytime, buddy.”

“Thanks, Meyer. Thanks. What time are you going to work?”

“I’m off today,” Meyer said.

Quinn said, “I’m not on shift till three.”

Josh nodded, tucking his mouth to one side. He’d really wrecked their fun by showing up last night. They should still be having sex right now. “What hospital are you at? Here in Ajax?”

“Yeah. Lakeridge.”

More nodding, more not knowing what to say, more wanting to get the hell out of here. When he’d received the text response from Devlin indicating Devlin and Kimmy were together last night, it was like someone had snatched the veil from his vision. Everything clarified at once. And what he saw shocked the shit out of him. What Kimmy had done to him last night, discovering him parked outside Hyun’s apartment, taunting and belittling him, was mean and dominant. It was bullying. She scared him so much that Devlin had become the lesser of two evils. But Devlin’s quick response showed him something. Devlin lived to torment him. Devlin sucked the life from him. And so did Kimmy. The two were one. He could trust each of them the same. His wife was his bully now. And Kimmy bullied him, telling him he wanted the bullying. That he asked for it. And he couldn’t deny that in some manner he had asked for it. So he had to question himself: Do you want this? If you want this, what way do you want it?

“Okay,” he said at last with a sigh. “I’m going to hit the road.”

“You’re coming back here tonight,” Meyer said.

“Oh, I don’t know yet.”

Meyer came closer, moving around Quinn, seated on a stool. “No, Josh, I’m telling you you’re coming here tonight. I want to talk to you.”

His feet were stuck to the floor. That sudden surrender he’d suffered last night, the one that brought him to his cousin’s door, had turned a page in the sexual melodrama Devlin had turned his life into. There was no escaping the truth anymore. No more lies to tell, even the ones he told himself.

“Thanks, guys, thanks for taking me in.”

Quinn said, “Any time, Josh.”

His eyes swelled. Swelled with the support he felt. For the first time since this horror had begun, someone else besides Kimmy was enjoined. It made him feel further apart from her. For so long she was his lifeline in this stormy seas. But his eyes swelled with more than just the compassion he felt from his cousin and his cousin’s new girlfriend. It was guilt. Guilt and shame. Guilt and shame in the face of family. He’d done wrong. He’d done much wrong. He’d done wrong even last night with Devlin. Meyer and Quinn made him feel like the choices he made didn’t need to be so dark. Didn’t need to be so dire. But, no. It was too late for that. Too late to be saved. He was sunk deep into this hurting mire. Gone headfirst down a deep and narrowing spiral. There was no turning back. There was only one direction he could go. The time for help was long gone.

“Okay,” he said. “I’ll bring pizza. Pizza for three?”

“I’m at work,” Quinn said.

“She just had the sitter for one night.”

“Oh, man,” Josh groaned. “I’m so sorry, guys.”

Quinn lightly swatted Meyer's shoulder. "Why would you say that? . . . Josh, it's totally fine. Family comes first, and I can get a sitter any time I want. I'm at work till eleven tonight. Harley's with my sister. You guys have fun, catch up, eat your pizza. Talk. . . . For what it's worth, your wife is so nice. And she's, like, so beautiful."

"Thanks, Quinn. I think she is, too." Then: "Who says this has anything to do with her?" He showed a feeble smile, and Quinn showed him a glum one in return.

Meyer said, "Let me walk you out, Joshy boy," and took him by the arm. When Josh moved to retrieve his overnight bag, Meyer stopped him. "Leave it here. Pick it up tonight."

In the hall, Meyer closed the door behind him with a quiet click. He turned and said, "So, this is pretty bad, huh?"

Josh nodded. "It's workable. We're not fighting. I just needed a place to be alone, you know? I need some time to think."

"You said that. Look, I know you've been under a lot of stress and maybe I wasn't the most supportive—"

"Don't worry about it, buddy." He clapped his hand on Meyer's shoulder. "I don't even know if this is a real thing I'm mad about here."

Meyer shook his head and scowled, unimpressed. "You're more full of shit than I am."

"And you're pretty full of shit."

Meyer stroked a hand over his hair. "Ah, fuck. This is a shame, but you're going to get through it. Don't worry, okay?"

Josh massaged Meyer's shoulder, saying nothing in return.

It was good to see Meyer and Quinn and how happy they were. Or at least how hopeful they seemed, each looking for promise in the other. There was a time Meyer and Hyun had been tight as twine. But that hadn't worked out.

It seemed so plain to move on, to leave your woes behind and forge a new path with a fresh face. But that seemed also like mere temptation. A lure. An escape. And it also seemed so scary. Scarier than Kimmy's bullying. Too easy. Too ignoble. Surrender. Defeat. Second place.

Meyer said, "I'll help you get through this."

Josh smiled, looking for some platitude to ease his cousin's worry. Said instead a non sequitur that had been sitting on his park bench waiting to speak. "Do you know anyone who has hired a private detective? I mean, for real. Do people do that, are there detectives you can call?"

Meyer didn't laugh, only eyed him in return. He said, "Quinn's brother does it. For an insurance company." He thumbed over his shoulder. "You want me to ask her?"

Josh shook his head. "I was only kind of kidding."

Meyer looked more pained than he had before. Like Josh was acting crazy or something.

Josh squeezed his shoulder one more time. "I am kidding. I'm not hiring a detective. And I didn't mean Kimmy, anyway."

Now Meyer looked pained and puzzled.

Josh laughed and said, "I'll bring pizza tonight."



His phone dinged in the elevator and he knew it would be Kimmy, wanting to know if he was okay, wanting to know why the hell he wasn't home when she came home. Because I'm not going to lie in bed with a hard-on waiting for you to come home and do something with it. Because you might

or you might not. You might tell me something that sends me to the heavens. But you might say something that casts me to hell, too.

Most of all, he was tired of his demons binding him in impossible chains.

His heart thudded when he checked his phone. The text wasn't from Kimmy. It was from Devlin.

Devlin: have you asked her yet?

Josh responded.

Josh: Fuck off

TWO

DOVE

She found Josh's note on the kitchen counter, his gentle scrawl describing an inner turmoil across an oblong tear-off sheet pulled from the pad magnetized to the fridge. Across the top, a cartoon dog sled team raced from left to right, dog tongues happily flopping. Underneath read the pun: Things I Mush Do. And below the delightful drawing, Josh's calligraphic confession.

Kimmy, I can't do this anymore. I don't even know who I am right now. I don't know what to think; I don't know what to say. I don't even know how to talk to you. I do know that when you talk to me it leaves me more mixed up than when you say nothing. I need some time. I need peace. I will call you later. And I love you.

Josh

Good old kind-hearted Josh signing off with the important caveat: you're torturing me, but I love you. So worried his honest note might harm her. Afraid, too, that his note might be considered an act of aggression. Kind Josh, a man afraid of conflict, showing his neck in case his perceived first-blow brought a return of equal or greater amplitude. Josh was good. Josh was fragile. Josh deserved care and protection.

It eluded her why it had come to this. Not Josh's reaction. Josh's reaction was now and always magnanimous. He gave her more respect and trust than she deserved. Why had she surrendered to temptation? How had there been such weakness in her resolve? Such useless, pointless betrayal. What had licensed such carelessness with the only person in her life she loved and trusted?

It couldn't be answered with anything but theory and speculation.

One thing was for sure: She would not lose Josh. She would do anything to preserve him.

So with the note folded into an unreadable blank square and re-magnetized to the fridge, she dressed in a sharp suit, stopping in the hall to send Josh one more text.

Kimmy: Ok. I found your note. Call me when you can.

Then, minutes later, sitting in her car waiting for it to warm, she texted him again.

Kimmy: I'm sorry.

Josh didn't call until eleven in the morning, her stomach sour and tight. When she saw his name lit on her phone, she rose from her chair, held the phone to her chest, paced her office before sitting in one of the two chairs

across from her desk. She ran her lower teeth across her upper lip, took a breath, then answered.

The simple sound of his voice brought her breath in sobbing chugs, and she had to steady herself with a loose fist over her heart, rubbing in circles.

“I’m sorry you didn’t find my note first. I didn’t know where to leave it.”

“It’s all right. Are you okay?”

Josh sighed. “I don’t know, Kimmy. I really don’t know. I feel like I got hit by a truck and woke up at the hospital and I don’t know who I am.”

She chewed her cheek. “It’s okay. I know who you are.” In her periphery she could see Tami watching from the lobby, pretending to work, but surveying why the new lawyer would do something so weird. She swiveled the chair away.

“Well, at least someone does,” Josh said, sounding exhausted.

“Josh, I want nothing but your happiness. Tell me what’s wrong.”

“I don’t even know where to start, Kimmy. It’s like everything is wrong.”

Her lips slimmed. “Don’t say that, Josh. Everything isn’t wrong. If you tell yourself it is, then...”

“I just don’t know why you were so aggressive last night.”

“At the car? Josh, I was playing. You know I was playing.”

“It’s just so mean. So scary.”

There was silence, just the sounds of their breathing. She swiveled the chair further. “You know he wasn’t there. You know that, right? That would be crazy, Josh. Like, what were you thinking?”

“Is he there today?”

She sighed again, a burden weighing on her heart. Her stomach reminded her it was sour. “No, Josh. He’s not here today.”

“Maybe later today,” Josh said. “Maybe the next day. Some day he will. Some day soon.”

“We talked about this. I told you to let me handle it.”

She listened to him breathe awhile. He said, “I need some time for myself.”

She nodded, thinking about it. “Where are you?”

“I’d rather not say.”

“Are you at Meyer’s?”

“Kimmy...”

She frowned. “Steve’s? You’re at Meyer’s. You can tell me. . . . I know you’re at Meyer’s.”

“Can I please have some space?”

“I’ll give you space. Josh, I’ll give you space at home. You can come home.”

“No. No, I can’t.”

“Josh, please...”

“Kimmy, I can’t.”

“You can’t be in the apartment with me?”

“Devlin jerked off in front of you. He put his dick on your fucking leg. How can these things occur without— . . . Tell me you didn’t fuck him.”

She exhaled a burst of quiet air, her stomach flinching. The attack had come stronger than she’d expected. “Josh, come on...”

“Tell me you didn’t fuck him, Kimmy.”

The back of her neck went hot and damp. She rubbed it. “Is that what you want to hear?”

“Tell me.”

She closed her eyes. “Josh, I didn’t fuck him.”

“Bull shit.”

“That’s so unfair.”

“You’ve never fucked him?”

“Come on, Josh...”

Josh made a frustrated sound of pure rage she’d never heard from him, and she was sure he would explode and rifle his phone into the wall. But after a moment, he returned, angrier than ever, but restraining himself through gritted teeth. “Can’t you hear this? Can’t you hear what this sounds like? How can I come home? How can I come home, Kimmy, when I don’t even know which way is up? You’re fucking messing with my head. I know there’s so much more, but I don’t want to fucking know it, and yet every time I turn my head it’s there demanding my attention; every time I look in the mirror I see a guy who is too afraid to ask his wife something so god damn simple because he... He...”

“Because he what?”

Very quiet: “Because he fucking knows the answer already.”

“Josh— Josh, listen to me. I love you. I love you more than anything else. That is something so true that I love to say it. I love you. You’re everything.”

“I’m everything, but...” He left the end hanging, his voice trembling with unadulterated defeat. He knew she’d cheated, but he didn’t want to hear it.

With the sunny late-September city view beyond her window wall, she closed her eyes and rubbed her brow. “I’m just under so much pressure.”

“It’s not anything you can’t walk away from, Kimmy.

“I’m not walking away, Josh.”

“Of course you’re not. But you love me, right?”

“Of course I love you, Josh. Is that the measure of my love, whether you can make me quit my job?”

“Yeah, like that’s what I want.”

“You’re asking me to.”

“It’s not the job, Kimmy. You know what it is. Don’t try to manipulate my words. It’s not the job I want you to quit, it’s what?”

“It’s not simple, Josh. I told you to let me handle this.”

“You’re asking me to hold more than I can hold.”

She didn’t answer, not knowing what to say, staring at her fingernails and wishing the path wasn’t so bumpy and filled with potholes. “I asked you to trust me. Don’t you trust me?”

Josh didn’t answer, just took a deep breath and let it out. Then: “Kimmy, I need some time. Don’t you see it?”

“I don’t mind, Josh. Okay. Take some time. . . . Tell me where you’re staying.”

“No.”

“Why not? You think I’m going to come and find you?”

“Would you or wouldn’t you?”

She rolled her head around. "I don't know how to answer that."

"Why not?"

"Of course I would want to find you, but if I say that, then you won't tell me. If I say I wouldn't, then you'll say it's because I don't care."

"I'm keeping us both safe by not telling you."

"Keeping us both safe from what?"

"From you, Kimmy. From you."

The answer was ridiculous and got her scowling. "That's terrible. Why would you say that?"

"Because it's true. . . . You told me last night I'm my own worst enemy. You don't think you rank?"

"I'm not your enemy, Josh."

"Just pretend I don't exist for a night. How about that? Maybe that's what I want."

"That's chilling."

"You think I'm being dramatic?"

"No, but you have to admit, it's like you want me to suffer. You're punishing me. You're shutting me out to hurt me."

"I'm not doing that. Are you saying you didn't do anything that deserves punishment?"

"Are you saying I did?" It was a reflexive response, but now she worried how his response could hurt her.

It was slow coming, but at last he said, "You tell me."

“Josh, don’t hang up angry,” she said, seeing how this would be a point won, a place for him to step away, having landed a good blow. “Don’t be alone when you’re mad at me. I can’t live like that. Tell me you love me.”

He said, “You know I love you.”

“Say it. Say it for me.”

He grumbled first, before saying, “I love you. I love, I do. That’s why I’m not coming home. That’s why I want to be alone. When I’m with you, I’m lost. I’ll do whatever you say, believe whatever you say. You know how to control me.”

“No, I don’t.”

“I have to go,” he said, wounded. “I’m at work.”

“Will you call me tonight?”

“I don’t know. Yeah, I guess.”

She said, “I know you’re at Meyer’s. Just tell me you’re there.”

“Please leave it alone.”

“Okay. Call me.”

“Yeah, all right. Bye. Okay?”

“Bye, Josh. I love you.”

The pause afterward dragged on for eternity. Then: “I love you, too.”

Josh hung up, and she kept the phone pressed to her ear for a long time without moving, watching the amorphous cloud shadows cross the sunlit geometric urban sprawl. The leaves had begun to fall and she could see them collecting in the gutters and the corners in shaggy yellow bundles.

Maybe he wasn't at Meyer's. If he was telling the truth about where he wasn't hiding, then where was he? She squeezed her forehead, trying to quell the rising pressure behind her eyes.

Then she was up and moving, checking her Find My Phone one more time. Still no location for her wounded husband. She opened her glass door and popped her head out to say to Tami, "Where's Devlin today?"

Tami cocked her head, thinking. "He's in Kingston."

"Is he coming to Toronto?"

"I don't know. It's Friday. He might. He likes to go out on the weekend."

He could be at Steve's, but Steve wasn't the friend Meyer was, and Steve provided no further value to Josh's current dilemma other than as a confidante. Meyer was a much better confidante, but what if Josh wanted more than a shoulder to cry on? What if he wanted to know the truth?

Her hands began to tremble with the spinning, depthless horror that Josh could go to Devlin to untie the knot she had tied him into.

THREE

INTERREGNUM

Friday night, alone in the apartment with a glass of wine, Kimmy called Hyun. Hyun answered right away.

“I was just thinking about you.”

“You’re psychic.”

Hyun snuffled a laugh against the phone’s mic. “Maybe I am.”

“How are you?”

“Good. You?”

“What are you doing right now?”

“Right now? Cleaning the kitchen. Sophie and I just had dinner.”

“Aw, Sophie’s back from Chloe’s. Did she have fun?”

“She really did. . . . Sophie says hello.”

Her heart swelled, feeling acknowledged by something so good and innocent. “Say hi back for me.”

Away from the phone, Hyun said, “Aunt Kimmy says hi.” Sophie said something in return, but Kimmy couldn’t make it out.

“Did she eat lots of ice cream?”

“Mr. Wu promised me they monitored the sugar intake.”

They laughed about that, then the conversation got awkward. What they'd shared last night had huge implications, and now that the passion had simmered and they were separated, they walked the aftermath like stepping on glass. After some more strained but friendly patter, Kimmy asked, "When does Sophie go back to Meyer?"

"Sunday afternoon."

"Do you take her?"

"Yeah," Hyun said, laughing lightly. "Of course I do."

Kimmy laughed too, picturing Sophie telling an Uber driver to take her to her dad's place. "Right up to his apartment?"

"We meet in the lobby."

"Can you go up to his apartment?"

"Why?"

"Oh, just curious." Her words sounded lame and grew lamer in the quiet after she'd said it.

The apartment felt cold and dim without Josh in it. She'd been alone a thousand times in the apartment before, but even with Josh absent, his presence felt close. His impending. He'd always be home soon. When he went to Rome, he'd abandoned her, left her trapped in some gloomy cloak. And that's where she found herself now; swaddled in uncomfortable moper. And the whole time she treaded in this mire, she fought the terrifying notion he was active behind her back. Snooping through her secrets from afar; determined to hound out her sins. He'd asked her today, point blank: did you fuck him? He'd gone to Devlin. She was sure of it. That fucking slick bastard, that wretched betrayer, would love to fill Josh's innocent head with all sorts of villainous prompts. And without her to temper them, Josh would be wounded. Devlin would injure Josh.

Voice quieter, more questioning, Hyun asked her what she was doing tonight.

“Josh isn’t here. He’s not coming home tonight. Why don’t you come over? You and Sophie. And we’ll watch movies and make popcorn.”

“Really? Oh... Oh, shoot. Kimmy.”

“What?”

“I’m taking Sophie to figure skating tonight. You can come with us. I’d like that.”

There was hope in Hyun’s voice, the nervous kind, not wanting to stoke a fiery expectation only to have her secret maybe-lover to douse it with a bucket of frigid water. Kimmy set the wineglass on the coffee table and palmed her forehead, leaning forward.

The idea Hyun and Sophie could rescue her from loneliness and anxiety tempted her enough she almost smiled. “I... I’m already on my second glass of wine. I shouldn’t drive.”

“We could pick you up. How about it? Sophie would love that.”

Sophie squealed sounds of encouragement somewhere in that kitchen where Hyun had served her breakfast this morning. After your shower. After you spent the night in bed with her.

“I don’t know...” But now the smile came, and with it a swelling of wet in her eyes that she blinked away, before rubbing them with the heel of her free hand.

Going to the arena with Hyun and Sophie would keep her mind off Josh, and keep her from doing something crazy, like going to Devlin’s apartment to see if Josh was there and then dragging him out of that devil’s domain by his ear.

“Okay,” she said. “I’ll go.”



Seven slices of a Little Caesar Meat Lovers pizza and two cans of Brio had Josh sideways on the couch with his knees drawn up to protect his stuffed and swollen belly. Meyer played Forza on the big screen.

Without looking over, eyes on the screen, Meyer said, “Any time you want to talk, you know I’m sitting right here.”

Josh said he knew, watching Myer’s Corvette race through the Circuit de Barcelona-Catalunya. He’d wanted to talk with Meyer tonight, especially since he felt guilty for kind of wrecking Meyer’s date night with Quinn. He’d pictured bringing the pizza over, and they’d crash and start talking, and maybe he would confess some of the sins for which he was guilty. Maybe there could be light at the end of the tunnel. But once they’d started eating, his urge to confess had fizzled to ether. And now the idea he might expose some of his most sensitive vulnerabilities seemed ludicrous. He said, “I know.”

“You don’t want to talk about it?”

It was an easy out and he took it. “Not really.”

“Can you tell me why you’re here instead of at home—did you guys fight?”

“No. No, we didn’t. I just need some space.”

Meyer paused the game and looked over. Josh angled his head so they faced.

“This isn’t in your head anymore,” Meyer said.

“What do you mean?”

“You’re always thinking the worst, but this time you know something.”

Josh shrugged and looked away and Meyer said, “Just talk to me.”

“When I’m ready.”

“That’s fine. Totally fine, Josh. You want to finish this race while I run to the can?”

“No, just keep it paused.”

Meyer said nothing and Josh listened to him heave out of the couch and head down the hall to the bathroom. Josh sat up and rubbed his face, picked up the pizza box and brought it into the kitchen, shoving it as best he could into the crammed fridge. Meyer met him coming out to the family room again. They exchanged an awkward look and then returned to their couches.

“Whatever is going on, I hope to god you guys can work it out. You’re the best couple.”

“Thanks.”

“Don’t you think?”

He thought of it in ways Meyer couldn’t even comprehend. The ways he thought of him and Kimmy together, the way their puzzle pieces connected, weighed heavily on him, his brow lowering as if he was angry. But he wasn’t angry; all he felt was emptiness. “I miss her,” he admitted. “But I need some time to think.”

“I actually think that’s really healthy, Josh.”

“You do?”

“Getting needed space and reflecting? Fuck, yeah.”

Josh sat up again and rubbed his face, groaned and said into his hands, “Buddy, I think I’m going to go to bed.”

“What? It’s Friday night, Josh. Play some games with me? Or why don’t we go see a movie? If we skedaddle, we can make a nine-thirty show.”

“I’m not up for it. We can do that tomorrow. Unless you’re going out with Quinn.”

“She works this weekend.”

“I’m just exhausted. I feel so worn out.”

Meyer’s lips pursed, and he nodded—like he couldn’t argue with Josh’s enervated visage. “Okay,” he said. Then, “Hey, I talked to Quinn about her cousin.”

“The private eye?”

“Insurance investigator. He said he’d help if you want. Quinn can get you the family discount.”

“I’ll think about it,” Josh said and stood.

“Promise me it’s not for Kimmy.”

“It’s not.”

Meyer studied him. “If it is, Quinn will know.”

“It’s not. I’m not spying on her.”

Meyer accepted the answer. “I wouldn’t feel right about that. I don’t know why, I just wouldn’t.”



Josh lay in his little niece’s oversized bed and stared at the ceiling, waiting for passing headlights to send shadows chasing away in a slow sweep before the darkness swallowed the light again. He drifted to sleep and when he woke a while later, he was shocked he’d managed to find any slumber at

all, given the dreadful circumstances. He checked his phone on Sophie's night table, surprised and disheartened to see it was 12:34. Now he couldn't go make coffee and watch TV as the sun came up. He'd have to try to chase sleep again. And he had a fucking aching hard-on. Absolutely throbbing.

He tossed and turned, but couldn't escape the thoughts his strange arousal brought along.

The strong arousal rode in on a greenish wave of shame. Absolute and pure shame. His temples throbbed in time with the racing pulse in his erection. His heart pounded lust for debasement, for humiliation, for sheer, depraved indignity. That's what aroused him. It was in him, and it was in Kimmy, too. Fucking Meyer pointing out how they were good together. Yeah, but why Meyer? Because we're both degenerates who present like unsuspecting normies? He rolled to his back and folded hands under his head, his cock bowing out the quilt.

How could he ever broach this subject with his cousin without looking like a weakling or a pervert or a fucking loser? The only way he could broach it would be to cast all the aspersion, or at least the majority of it, onto Kimmy. To paint her as the devil, when deep down he feared it might be him.

At least he'd had the courage today to utter the words that had clouded his mind all these weeks, but had never before found the courage to convene on his tongue. As soon as he'd asked it, he regretted it. And was glad Kimmy had obviously repeated what he'd asked her to say. There was no convincing truth in her claim: "Josh, I didn't fuck him."

You did. I know you did.

And...

I don't know how I feel about it. I only know how I should feel about it.

The only thing that mattered was clear. I'm not a chump. I'm not a loser.

But if that was all that mattered, then where did his sorrow bloom from?

Kimmy thinks you want that. Kimmy thinks that turns you on. Devlin has convinced the woman you love—the woman you married—that you are helpless, hapless; a victim. And Kimmy wants to victimize you because she loves you.

“Bull shit,” he whispered to Sophie’s pink and childish room; his common refrain these days. “I’m not a victim. Devlin is a victimizer, but that doesn’t have to make me a victim.”

He raised his knees, sliding his feet soles on the mattress and squeezing his thighs together. This throbbing iron wasn’t going to go away.

In the moments his inner voice subsided and left him alone, all that kept him company were images stoking the fire in his loins. A photo of his wife with her legs open and showing Devlin Stone her glistening pussy. Things he hadn’t seen. Devlin standing with a hard-on as hard as his own current horn, rubbing it and clicking away pic after pic while Kimmy Chang writhed in horny conflagration on a pallet of agricultural supplies. Her hot and aroused pussy smell mixing with chemical fertilizer; nitrates and potassium and earth minerals. Did she moan? Did she squirm? Did she squeal when he fingered her?

Did it hurt when she took his huge cock?

Or did she like it?

If she liked it, did she now crave it?

“Fuck sake,” he said, dropping his legs down and hand-heeling his boner to the side. There was nothing he could do about it. He would never in a million years defile Sophie’s bed with his evil, even if no one ever, ever found out. He wouldn’t go to the bathroom and take matters elsewhere, either.

No. He would lie and suffer all night.

That’s what he deserved.

For over an hour, he lay with his eyes open and stared at the ceiling, no more sweeping headlights to keep him company. In that time, temples throbbing, eyes dry and aching, he thought he saw something that made sense. At least something that restored his essence. He could never do it—but at least he could picture it. And in picturing it, imagine his own restoration.

The only way out was through. It was only once he was through that he could look back and see where he was. See who he was. Who he'd been. And in that cold and unforgiving illumination, he might discover whatever good existed that had been spoiled.

FOUR

VERGLAS

Josh called on Saturday morning and she asked him if he felt any better.

“A little,” he said.

It was good to hear his voice, and, though she probably imagined it, he sounded lighter. “Are you coming home?”

“Soon.”

“This afternoon?”

Now he sounded harassed. “I don’t know, Kimmy. I need more time.”

The stress in his voice conjured the bad images again. Devlin showing him manufactured spreadsheets and photos and concocting a story worse than the truth, smiling the whole time as Josh fell for it because Josh wanted the worst. Craved the worst.

It was pointless, though, wasn’t it? The truth was bad enough for Josh to hate her for a lifetime.

She changed the subject, eager to portray her night of innocent and dutiful leisure. “We took Sophie skating last night.”

“You and Hyun?”

“Yeah. God, Sophie’s so cute. She has little pink and white skates.”

“That is cute,” Josh said, and lovely hope bloomed. Josh was too good to abandon her.

“She’s so good for her age,” she said, watching her fingers nervously pluck at the bulky weave of her warm house-sweater. Josh asked what arena they went to, how many kids were in the class, and it felt so good to have him on her line, loving the tension, hoping she had the skill and dexterity to bring him onto her boat. He asked about Hyun, and she responded with keen camaraderie, telling him how they went out for hot chocolate after skating, then browsed the book aisles at Chapters, pointing out how Sophie is reading about four years above her age bracket. She left out the parts that were uncomfortable. The times alone with Hyun, not knowing what to say, watching Sophie pulling down books and flipping through them. Even though it had been awkward, it was still better than being alone in the apartment. Hyun had asked her if it was okay for her to be drinking while she was pregnant, and she’d shrugged and said it was early on and it was just a glass and a half, and her mother had drank wine when she was pregnant with both girls. But her mother hadn’t done that. Not that she knew of. The truth was darker than that, and she’d rather not have the truth anywhere near where she or anyone else could see it.

“I better get going,” Josh said, bringing the amber glow to a close.

“Okay.”

Josh went quiet, and she let him feel uncomfortable. Silence might show him how unfair he was treating her. He said, “I’m going to go have lunch with Meyer.”

“You’re not staying at Meyer’s?”

“Kimmy... I told you... Look, it doesn’t matter where I am. It’s not a big deal, just please stop asking me.”

“Okay,” she said, resigned. “I won’t ask.”

“It’s not a big deal, but I just... You know? Okay. . . . Okay, I gotta get going.”

“All right, Josh. I’ll let you go.”

More quiet, then he said, “I’ll talk to you later.”

“Josh?”

“Yeah?”

“I miss you.”



One o’clock lunch at the Durham Centre, killing time before a 3:30 movie. They ate at the Burgers On Fleek. Josh ordered the dark meat chicken burger with fries, and Meyer ordered a classic hamburger with sweet potato fries. Josh tested out Meyer’s sweet potato fries and Meyer regarded him like Josh had delivered an incredible indignity, snatching them without asking.

Josh laughed, chewed the fries, shrugging and mouthing, “What?” Challenging Meyer, gesturing to his own plain ol’ regular fries, offering them up like they were nothing, and Meyer was being a selfish baby.

Meyer selected three similar-sized plain fries from Josh’s plate and dropped them on his own; a fair hostage negotiation Josh couldn’t complain about.

Meyer prompted him. “Anyway, you were saying...?”

Josh spread out his napkin on his lap and took a sip of the fountain Coke before answering. “It was like I sent her there. I sent her past the gates of hell.”

Meyer rolled his eyes, sipping his root beer. “It’s not the gates of hell.”

“You know what I mean. Listen, it was... I don’t know. . . . Exciting.”

“What was?”

“Having your wife find the value she’d always looked for. The acknowledgment. It did great things for her. And, she... transformed.”

“I saw it.”

“And, like, it felt amazing to know she was my wife. Do you know what I mean? Like she could walk into boardrooms with Chinese billionaires or whatever and hold the line. And she was my wife. It was Kimmy. It felt amazing to see her in that world. It brought out something in her.”

“Like a demon.”

He steadied a look of comical disdain at his cousin, but the remark did sting.

Meyer smirked. “What? I’m sticking with the gates of hell thing you started.”

“She’s not a demon.” He stabbed some french fries and went to shovel them in his mouth, then paused. “Maybe she is. She was my demon.”

Meyer chuckled, but then his features shrank into lines of concern. “Isn’t she anymore?”

“No, she is. I love her more than anything. I just feel like I’ve been pushed aside. Like I’m not part of that world, and she is, and I’m diminished.”

“Like she left you behind?”

“Sure.”

“You’re doing great, though, Josh. What about them sending you to Rome?”

“I know. I know I am. The only reason is I’m competitive with Kimmy.”

“You bring out the best and the worst in each other.”

Josh paused for a second, brow lowering. “Wow. Did you ever hit a bullseye.”

Meyer laughed and showed pride for his astute scrutiny. They both laughed and took a break, eating in silence while the busy restaurant moved around them.

Meyer wiped his mouth and shrugged. “If that’s it, though, Josh, I don’t know what to say. It doesn’t sound good.”

“How so?”

“It sounds like resentment. On your part.”

“It’s not that. It’s more than that.”

Meyer shook his head like he was exasperated. “It’s this Devlin guy. I know it is. If you were honest about it, maybe we could talk for real.”

“Of course it’s this Devlin guy, Meyer.”

Meyer was adamant this time, gesturing with an angry hand toward Josh, saying, “Is something going on or not? Between him and Kimmy.”



Curled up in Sophie’s bed, Josh trembled in awful suppuration, suffering in inescapable sickness. Kimmy’s sweet voice whispered in his mind’s ear: “I miss you.”

What more could he want to hear?

But if he returned home, she would torture him. She would torture him and he would love it. What the hell had happened to their relationship; how had such an enormous power imbalance occurred?

His greatest fear was that if he uttered to his cousin the admission of Kimmy's infidelity, there would be no return. Not a return to the sanctity of his marriage, not to some semblance of a normal familial relationship. He feared he could never return to the dark pleasure her infidelity delivered.

Why did such horror draw him?

Once he made the claim that something had happened between Devlin and Kimmy, no one who cared for him would tolerate anything but Kimmy's absolute condemnation. How would Meyer ever understand how it came to be, without the revelation that Josh had been a party to it?

Sometimes he could imagine the warmth and comfort that support from his cousin—from his family—might bring. To have rallied support around him in his time of need. It would soothe him. Console him. But consoling was mere consolation. It was defeat. If he surrendered to the comfort of a familial embrace, wasn't he a coward? Wasn't he afraid to stand on his own two feet and confront the monster of his own creation? Because that's what it was. His situation was an electrified golem construct of his own desire. He could pretend that the desire had been sown in his soil by nefarious forces. Some conspiracy, a murder of dark crows working against him in furtive shadows. Plotting his demise for their own pleasure. Amy. Devlin. Amy and Kimmy together. Kimmy and Devlin. All three of them. All three of them like a council of witches around their coven's table, torturing a woodland stick-figure bound with magical twine; his own vulnerable effigy. It didn't matter who'd sown it; he'd reaped it.

When his mind wasn't lost at sea, when he wasn't alone on a rickety life raft in foggy uncharted waters, he was sometimes the roiling sea itself, crashing and roaring in primordial, maritime rage. Revenge twisted his skin. Evil thoughts of destruction; a malevolent desire to return the venom the coven's ceremonial dagger delivered when they sliced his skin.



Sleeplessness led her on this witless quest. One in the morning, sitting in the Leaf, parked outside the ritzy apartment building in North Toronto where she would sometimes have met Devlin for a lunchtime fuck. Sitting like her own hapless husband had, peering up at darkened apartment windows, looking for...

Looking for what?

What was it Josh had searched for, parked outside Hyun's building? What did he want to see? What did he want not to see? Were they the same thing?

While she hated the thought of Josh's silhouette passing the light of Devlin's window, she would also love to see Josh's profile in Devlin's window. Josh coming to the window to look out in wounded reverie at the city skyline, lost in thought. It would be worth it because it would bring this travesty to a rapid close. It would be worth it because she could unleash the hatred she held for the man who'd concocted this scenario. Even though it was made of flames she'd stoked herself.

Then she was out of the car and crossing the parking lot, heels clicking on the spotless pavement, shining wet in the cold night. She'd worn heels; she'd worn lingerie and a suit. Some sort of ritual that felt right when she was coming to this devil's domain. But she was here unequivocally for Josh.

The visitor's lot was only half full. No Qashqai.

Instead of the lobby, she turned left at the doors and headed across the walkway that took her to the parking garage's side door. On her key ring, she found the lobby key—the same key that would open the front door would open this one, too. Once inside the short passageway beyond the outer door, she opened the inner and walked the florescent-lit line of the parking garage's visitor lineup. Three empty spots, five cars in the rest. One Qashqai.

A Qashqai in black.

Not Josh.

She rolled her eyes. It was insane to think he was here in the first place.

She shook her head and gritted her teeth.

No, it wasn't insane. It was a possibility. A slim and unlikely one, but a possibility just the same. And one that would have destructive consequences.

Josh had to be at Meyer's. He had to be.

Maybe Josh and Devlin went out for dinner together and they took the Qashqai.

Yeah, right. Like Devlin would be caught dead in that sensible car.

Then what?

She could walk down to the next level and see if Devlin's car was parked in his spot.

And if it wasn't?

Devlin was in Kingston and Josh was at Meyer's.

Was that correct?

She looked up to the ceiling with its sprinkler system and gray-painted columns. Or she could go up and knock on Devlin's door and find out for sure. She smoothed her hands on her suit jacket. At least she'd dressed for the part.

FIVE

REQUITAL

Kimmy watched Hyun escort Sophie to the lobby doors of Meyer's building, sitting in Hyun's passenger seat, the sunshade dropped to obscure herself from Meyer—and Josh, if Josh came down with Meyer to meet Soph. But there was nothing she was guilty of; only a worried woman wanting to confirm her husband's location. Hardly a crime. Anything to confirm Devlin Stone hadn't corrupted Josh's mind somehow. One thing came into clear focus during Josh's multi-day punishment: she would have to confess the truth to him before he heard it somewhere else. No longer could she string him along; she'd extended and extended and further extended the time she would walk the line, riding out the nefarious fun they were both having with mute abandon—until now. The path she'd traveled had narrowed and narrowed, and these last two days showed for sure she was walking a tightrope over a deathly descent.

Sophie carried her pink plastic travel bag with her, and Hyun carried an extra. They mounted the steps and, at last, the lobby doors opened, the parking lot's reflection disappearing from its mirrored face, and in the slash of dark stood Meyer. No Josh. She moved her head side to side, eyes narrowed, trying to see if Josh lurked in the background, hanging back. Josh and Meyer could live like vampires when they were together, filling themselves with junk food and enduring epic Xbox and action movie binges without ever coming out for sunlight. Maybe Josh hung back because the light stung his skin.

But she didn't see him, not even a shadow hanging out in the back.

Now Meyer and Hyun were talking, all smiles and friendly chatter, Hyun passing over the extra bag to Meyer. Hyun seemed even robuster than usual, talking fast and using her hands. Probably explaining to Meyer how she and

Kimmy were going out for dinner tonight. How they were going into the city. There: Sophie turned and waved to her Aunt Kimmy, and Meyer and Hyun looked over and waved as well. She waved back, flicking the visor up, no more need to hide.

Transition over, more waves, and then Hyun was returning to the car. When she got in, Kimmy said, “Everything good?”

“All good,” Hyun said, fixing her hair in the rearview.

“Any sign of Josh?”

Hyun screwed her mouth up and looked over. “No. No sign of him.”

“And you didn’t mention him, right?”

“No. I said nothing.”

“Okay,” Kimmy said, small and quiet, rubbing her knees. “Call Sophie later tonight. She’ll tell you if he’s there or not.”



Two girls—no, two women—out for a fun night in the city.

After dropping Sophie off with her father, they’d stopped at the apartment. Tonight, they would go to an excellent restaurant. They would eat fine food. They would dress up. So Kimmy put on a jacket and pants and high-heeled shoes and Hyun tried things on from Kimmy’s closet that might fit her. When they couldn’t get a good match—and Hyun showed signs of dismay because of it—Kimmy had said they would go shopping first. For both of them.

They traveled into the city in casual wear, stopping at Bayview Village, where Kimmy had once bought a jacket she’d loved. That would have been

back in the days before she worked for Devlin; but the coat had been a fine purchase and a favored item in her closet. The boutique was called Cyrano, and she and Hyun poked through every item they had. And they had fun doing it.

They tried many things on and waited for the other to show it off. From the beginning, Kimmy had said the shopping and dinner would be her treat. Hyun was on a tight budget; she was a single mom working part-time and going to school. Kimmy didn't want her to worry. The only thing was, Hyun kept trying on things that were closer to her own budget, and Kimmy had to push finer things into her gentle hands, press her to try them on. Then she would show Hyun the pleasure from her viewpoint, complimenting her on her fit, on the way her body looked. It had been more fun than she'd anticipated. Kimmy chose for Hyun a steel-colored satin blouse, a long wool cardigan in caramel-chocolate, trousers in gray flannel. For herself: black tapered trousers that ended above the ankle and an unstructured blazer in black; a white poplin shirt and patented black leather Oxfords set on a chunky sole. Hyun got the same shoes in a luxurious oxblood. Hyun's cheeks reddened at the total when Kimmy paid, and when they were out in the shopping center's galley, she held Hyun's neck and kissed her mouth. She'd said, "I wanted to see you in them. I think you're so beautiful."

And now they were all dressed up (and attracting attention), having dinner in the city, enjoying twenty-dollar cocktails at the Auberge du Pommier. Kimmy's was made with non-alcoholic gin and strawberry and lemon and basil; Hyun had the Papillon: gin and lavender and lemon, and blueberries in with the ice. It was thrilling to introduce Hyun to these finer things. Hyun appreciated them. Appreciated them in the way one would when they'd coveted them for a long time.

Together, they looked elegant. Accomplished. Kimmy ordered the butter-poached halibut and Hyun ordered the Hudson Valley duck breast with Swiss chard and caramelized onion jus. She'd called ahead and used the Stone Brokerage name to get an emergency table. She told Hyun she had to pretend she was a Korean mining executive, and Hyun said she had no idea

what that might look like. Kimmy told her to look rich, and they giggled as Hyun tried out all sorts of facial expressions, looking for the right one.

They ordered dessert. Kimmy said, “I’m getting you a glass of champagne. I love the pink on your cheeks when you drink.”

Over a shared Crème brûlée, Hyun with a flute of bubbly Taittinger Brut Réserve, they smiled at each other in strange and surrendering manners, and they laughed at the strange circumstance that they found themselves in.

Kimmy checked her watch. “Shoot,” she said, setting her fork down. “Hyun, it’s eight.”

Hyun looked puzzled.

“It’s eight. Call Sophie. Call Sophie and ask her.”

Hyun gave one curt nod, wiped her mouth with her napkin in a small dainty move, then set her chair back. She produced her phone and called Meyer.

Kimmy listened to them make small talk, an uncomfortable wedge forming near her esophagus, hearing the words of a failed marriage, of a union parted. Their patter filled her with dread. But still she waited. Urging Hyun with a steady gaze, her eyes commanding her to ask the question. Get Sophie on the phone. Josh wouldn’t engage Sophie in games of subterfuge; Josh wouldn’t ask Sophie to say he wasn’t at Meyer’s.

Then Hyun was talking to Sophie. “Are you ready for bed? . . . That’s good. What did you have for dinner? . . . Aw, you love that. And what did...? . . . Uh-huh. . . . Oh, he is? Oh, that’s good.” Her eyes flicked up, and she nodded, a sly smile on her innocent face. She moved her face from the phone to mouth the confirming phrase: “He’s there.”

“Yes,” Kimmy sighed, and then bowed her head. She sank back in the comfortable chair while Hyun talked with Sophie.

All that worry for nothing. The guilt had weighed on her like a Mack truck.

The enormous weight lifted now, and she felt lighter than she had in days.

“I’m having dinner with your Aunt Kimmy.”

Kimmy moved to the table again. “Say hi for me.”

Hyun told her Sophie said hi back, both of them smiling. The relief had her fingers tingling and a lightness in her stomach the champagne couldn’t have provided.

When Hyun finished the call with Sophie, Kimmy reached across the table to hold her hand. “We have to get out of here,” she said.

“We do?” Hyun looked as light and happy as Kimmy felt.

“Yeah, we do,” she said. “I want to show you off.”



They drove not too far away, to a place near her office. She parked the car three shops down from the destination, worried if she parked out front, she would never get Hyun out of the vehicle. As luck would have it, Hyun was talking a lot and talking fast, and Kimmy took her hand while they walked the shopfronts in the old drive-up plaza on Yonge Street. Hyun paused at last, realizing something was up. Kimmy nodded her head to the side, indicating the threshold they would cross.

“Oh, no, Kimmy,” Hyun said, her happiness shrinking toward terror.

“Oh, yes, Hyun,” she said, taking Hyun’s hand in both of hers now, warm and comforting, her face showing amusement.

“Kimmy, it’s... It’s...” Hyun’s face showed fear still, but her eyes sparkled with curiosity.

“It’s where we have to go,” Kimmy said. “To find the things we need. . . . Where did you get yours?”

“Online,” Hyun said. “Like a normal person.” Her eyes roamed the storefront over Kimmy’s shoulder.

“Are you going to be brave for me?”

She knew Hyun would submit, but for now let her go through the act. Hyun looked aside and found her excuse: two Persian men watching them from a shiny black pickup truck parked outside the shawarma place two storefronts down.

“Okay, let’s get inside,” she said.



It was a riot watching Hyun from afar as Hyun walked with timid interest up and down the aisles of the sex shop Kimmy had bought her extra-large dildo at. Hyun looked better than Kimmy had ever seen her, and she wondered if Hyun had always looked like this and she’d just never seen it, or perhaps the wonder she felt was inspired within. Maybe it was the way she wanted to see Hyun now.

Hyun kept her hands in her pockets like a good kid who would never want to be accused of shoplifting, moving from display to display. Her posture eased after a few minutes. There was a pure beauty in her innocence. The clothes Kimmy had gifted her brought something out in Hyun. She was stunning in her own way. Of average height, of average build, but the beauty was in her perfect face, her irreproachable charm, the bottomless marveling in her dark eyes. Soon, Hyun’s hands came out of her pockets and touched things that interested her.

And now, more perfection to this corrupting moment: at first she’d been disappointed to see only one person behind the cash at the store; an unfamiliar face. Not the previous women who’d slighted her when she’d been here last. Not the manager and the trainee. Some blue-haired, heavysset

college girl. But then, the front door opened and someone came in, and not a customer. It was the manager, holding in one hand a cardboard drink tray and two sugary drinks from the bubble tea shop, paper straws sticking out the top.

And tonight Kimmy was six-feet-plus in her chunky and expensive Oxfords; she wore red lipstick, she wore a black suit. She made steady eye contact with the manager and smiled. The manager nodded in return, moving past her to the cash counter, looking back once with an unsureness that Kimmy hoped would lead to an eventual remembering.

“Hey,” Hyun said behind her in a mouselike call, and Kimmy turned to find her standing close, bringing something for Kimmy to look at.

Whatever it was, Hyun had brought a display model, and the sealed package, passing over the display model. Kimmy took it. It looked like underwear with straps; a wide, soft leather belt that one would tighten with velcro, straps that would go around the legs, and a thong back and black triangle front. Hyun held up the sealed package that showed a photo of the item in use. A strap-on harness that supported an inserted dildo.

“Wow,” Kimmy said, not acting shocked or surprised, but with calm assessment. She held it to her own waist like she was testing out a pair of shorts before heading to the fitting room. “Yeah, I like it. You want this?”

“What do you think?”

Kimmy held the harness up again, looking it over. “I think we should get two.”

“You do?”

“Well, we don’t want to keep exchanging the same one back and forth in the middle of fun.”

Hyun sucked her lips between her teeth, then let them plop out again, speaking now more breathlessly. “Okay, yeah, that’s a good idea.”

Kimmy ran her fingers over the display model's crotch, where there were two sections with cut-outs meant for other attachments besides the fake dick that would push through the circular cut-out in the black triangle's front.

Hyun's brow lowered. "What's that for?"

Kimmy said, "I think you can put a vibrator in here probably, you know, for yourself. Front and back."

"Back?" Hyun took a second to comprehend, then put a hand on her own hot cheek. "Oh, my gosh."

"Let's get two," she said, passing the display back to Hyun.

Hyun took it, thinking ahead and saying, "We can use the big one you like."

Kimmy smiled devilishly. "You mean Devlin's?"

Hyun turned up her nose. "I don't like it being his."

Kimmy saw the point and smiled warmly, putting a hand on Hyun's neck. "It's not. He's not in my life anymore. I mean it."

"Are you sure?"

"I'm sure, Hyun."

"You have to name it something else."

Kimmy said, "I'll throw that one out."

Hyun looked surprised. "You will?"

"Yeah, consider it done, Hyun. I don't want you to think about that."

"So, do you want to get two?"

"You know what I like about them?"

“What?”

“You can kiss me while we use it, and I can put my arms around you.”

Hyun’s eyes widened and the pinky color on her pale cheeks brightened. Kimmy smiled and bit her lower lip, cocking her head. Hyun swooned.

“You can go pick out a dildo for both of us. How about that? They have to fit the harness.”

“Okay,” Hyun said, face serious, having been assigned a very important task. Kimmy touched her cheek. “Get anything you want.”

“Okay. Okay,” Hyun said, eyes lost in thought. Then: “You want a really big one, right?”

“I’ll like whatever you pick.”

Hyun nodded. “I’ll get you a really big one. Oh...”

“Oh, what?”

Hyun scrunched her cute nose up. “I don’t like it to be flesh-colored or with, you know, veins and stuff.”

Kimmy chuckled, her heart soaring with adoration. “I told you to get whatever you want. Whatever it is that makes your motor purr, baby.”

Hyun’s eyes shone, and she took a deep breath, soaking in Kimmy’s affection. And then she was heading back to the section that would host suitable toys that would work with the harness, now Hyun’s timidity gone and replaced with a subdued yet fervent purpose.

Hyun was wonderful. She was wonderful, and Kimmy couldn’t wait to kiss her right in front of the manager.

SIX

EPIMETHEUS

Devlin was behind her, coming into the luxury suite at the Yorkville hotel, five minutes late. Standing by the bedside, between the bed and the window, she said toward the foyer, “I don’t know how long you think you can keep moving Benny Chan’s appointments around before he tells you to go fuck yourself.”

When she turned, her heart pounded and her mind careened in crazy chicanes. It wasn’t Devlin. It was Josh.

Josh stood in the sitting room of the reserved suite at The Hazelton, hands in his pockets, shoulders slumped yet his head held high. He looked amazing in the seven-thousand dollar suit she’d bought him.

Her legs failed her, and she sat on the bed before she collapsed. Hands on her knees, she forced herself to stand, wobbly but determined to stay upright.

It was a quarter after twelve on Monday. Devlin had told her he’d moved the Benny Chan appointment closer by a day; Monday instead of Tuesday. This was a workday. She was downtown in her killer suit and heels, her hair pulled back and shining, her lips painted red, her eyes black and fierce.

She hadn’t seen Josh in three-and-a-half days. Not a long time, unless it was spent in exile; in unknowing purgatory.

“Josh, what the— What are you doing here?” Her voice cracked. What sounded at first like disbelief, upturned in pitch to a sound of joy. Yet everything about Josh’s out-of-place presence screamed danger. She went to him, eager to touch him.

And worried he'd reject her. Worried enough, she stalled before she reached him, standing on the threshold between the bedroom and the sitting room. She couldn't help smiling, couldn't help the happiness. Before she touched him, she asked him, "Are you okay?"

He nodded, face serious and unfriendly—the demeanor chilling her.

She said, "What are you doing here?"

"I know it's unexpected," Josh said, hands still in his pockets.

This was somehow Devlin's doing. It had to be. "Did you... Did you come here for me?"

Josh nodded again, biting his own lip, suffering under an unknown angst that emanated from him like a live wire.

She told him now, "I'm going to hug you."

He said nothing and that hurt, but it was better than rejection. She stepped into his space, taller than him in her heels, putting her arms around him, whispering in his ear, "I missed you so much."

He said, "I missed you, too, Kimmy."

"You were at Meyer's, weren't you?"

His arms went around her and she breathed deep, feeling like hope had just illuminated the dim room.

"Yeah. I was. Of course I was."

She stepped back, her hands on his arms. "Did you get what you need?"

His hands went back into his pockets and his upturned face dipped down, lost in thought for a moment. "I don't know. . . . No, I didn't." He shook his head side to side.

"Oh, I— Can you... Can you come home?"

Josh drew a slow inhale, then let it out. His head came up again and his eyes roamed the room. He stepped past her, entering the bedroom, going around the opposite side of the bed, admiring the place, looking into the tiled bathroom, all in black. He held the attitude of a potential buyer, like he was touring the place and she was his real estate agent. He turned her way. "Is this where it happened?"

"What happened?"

"What you said to me." He jabbed his head sideways toward the bathroom. "How you told Devlin to jerk off, and how he jerked off in the bathroom and when he came out, he put his dick against your leg." Now he looked down at the bed, about right where she'd stood when that exact thing happened.

"Josh, what are you doing?"

"You can't answer that? Are you ashamed?"

"Why are you doing this here and now? Why did you come here? I'm at work." Her pulse flitted in her neck and her heart galloped. She wanted to dominate, but Josh's absence seemed to have diminished her edge. "Why aren't you at work?"

"I took a mental health day," he said and strolled from the opposite bedside to the foot. She met him there.

"I really did miss you," she said.

His smile was weak, but she was glad to see it. "I missed you, too." His hands went to her jacket lapels, and she covered her hands over his.

"Come home tonight, Josh."

His eyes were on their hands. "We'll see."

One hand slipped out from under hers and he touched her neck. He began to unbutton her shirt collar. Her hand moved over top of his but didn't stop him, merely rode on top for a moment to see what he wanted to do. His

finger slipped under the opened shirt and drew down to the next button. He undid that one. She squeezed his hand.

“Josh, we can’t. Not here. I’m... I’m at work. I’m expecting a meeting. Look at that table.” She shot her hand toward the table in the sitting room, set for four executives, with leather chairs and polished glass and all her paperwork at the ready. “Look, I have all the paperwork set up. I’m presenting, or helping, you know, Devlin present—”

“I know. I know.” Josh stepped away and returned his hands to his pockets.

“Josh, I’ll blow this meeting off,” she said. “If you want to, let’s get out of here. Let’s get our own hotel room. You can undress me. I’ll let you do anything you want to me. Anything. Say the word.”

“You’d do that?”

“I want that.”

“Because you want to get out of here, or because you want me?”

She frowned and shook her head, tried to answer a few times, but no words came. Then: “You’re manipulating me. You’re pushing me around and twisting my words.”

“It’s not too much fun, is it?”

“What does that mean?”

“I want you to unbutton your shirt.”

She narrowed her eyes, not seeing what her husband intended or what he wanted to do. “I’m at work. I can’t.”

“One more button, Kimmy. Just one more button.”

“Why?”

When she didn't move to action, Josh stepped forward again, removed his hands from his pockets and undid the next button. She allowed him to do it, asking him again, "What are you doing?"

He smiled at the sight of her naked collar and his hand smoothed her skin. His hand was warm and welcome, but this wasn't the time or place. He pushed aside her jacket and shirt and cupped her breast. Her nipple hardened.

He said, "What a wonderful bra you're wearing."

She looked down to where his hand slipped under her shirt. "So?"

He thumbed the nipple bulge. "I bet your panties match."

She showed him a look of incomprehension.

"Maybe even garters and stockings."

"Not with a suit, Josh."

Josh's cheeks puffed out, and he stepped away, turned and faced into the bedroom suite, looking at the bed, unbuttoning his jacket and putting his hands on his hips.

"You're mad at me for that?"

He turned slowly, regarding her fully, up and down. "You're wearing lingerie because you're going to fuck him. You're in this room to meet Devlin."

She scoffed. "No, I'm not."

"To me you are. And that's all I care about. I just care about me right now." His voice had risen, and he'd jabbed his thumb to his chest in an angry manner. "You see, you're my wife. You're my wife and you're meeting a man you've been having an affair with in this sweet ass hotel room. And you're wearing lingerie."

“I’m not having an affair, Josh.”

Josh chuckled, not a sound of amusement, more like one of hurt and suffering. “What if I told you in fifteen minutes that door was going to open again and this time Devlin would be coming in?”

“Yeah? I’m expecting him.”

“I know you are. You dressed for him.”

She shook her head in admonishment, tempered by sympathy. “I’m not dressed for him, Josh. I’m dressed for me. I told you what I like. I told you.”

“Did you shave it? Did you shave your pussy last night? Did you perfume it?” Josh’s eyes trembled and showed the shine of rising emotion.

She twisted her face into a mask of disdain, seeing her husband’s boldness crumbling. “Vulgarity doesn’t suit you, Josh.” She buttoned her shirt closed, taking her time with it. “And I swear on my life”—shirt buttoned, she fixed her gaze on him—“the very, very last thing I was thinking about today was sleeping with Devlin fucking Stone. You abandoned me. Punished me—for no good reason—you hurt me. All I thought about was you. I hoped you were okay. I hoped you were safe. I hoped you weren’t hurting. And I wanted you back. I wanted you home.”

Josh wiped his pinky eyes with the heel of a hand and looked away. The Yorkville sky painted his face in divulging gray light.

She said, “Talk to me, Josh. Let’s get out of here and talk to each other.”

“You have a meeting,” he muttered.

“Fuck it. Fuck Devlin.”

Josh looked at her and he hoped he didn’t misconstrue her phrasing.

He returned his gaze to the light coming in from the suite windows, saying, “I’ve been sleepless for days now—”

“Me too, Josh, me too,” she said consolingly. He did look so tired. If he hadn’t worn the suit she’d bought him, he would look like a zombie.

“I’ve been lying awake in Sophie’s bed every night, imagining all the ways I think you might have lied to me.”

A chill crossed her, and she shivered. She worked her stiff fingers, feeling a sense of impending. She looked to her left, the opposite of Josh, looking at the suite’s main door. “I’ve lied, Josh. I’ve lied, but I love you more than anything in this world.” Though he had a new contender, a life forming inside her. She rested a hand over her belt line, wishing she had the time and wherewithal to announce their pregnancy.

“I think it’s all been a lie. All of it.”

“Josh,” she said, sternly, stern enough he faced her again. “I love you. I would do anything for you.”

He said, “No matter the cost.”

She rolled her eyes and slumped her shoulders, shaking her head. Her gaze cast to the side again, falling on the suite’s main door. She stared at its black face for a long moment.

Something nasty occurred to her, and she faced him again, Josh with his chin raised again at a defiant angle. “You slept in Sophie’s bed?”

“She has a normal bed.”

“You didn’t sleep on the couch.”

Josh shook his head no.

“Sophie went back to Meyer’s yesterday afternoon. I dropped her off. . . . Where did you sleep last night?”

Josh said nothing, and she turned to that blank, black door once more.

SEVEN

CANTO XXVII

Josh didn't answer, instead turning away and following his gaze, moving to the window to look down on the street.

Kimmy hung her head, realizing a scenario. "Devlin moved the meeting up. There is no meeting today. Is there?"

Josh didn't answer, playing the forlorn fool, lost in spiritual reverie at the window.

She repeated herself. "Is there, Josh?"

"Damned if I know, Kimmy. I'm here."

"You are," she said. "Where you shouldn't be."

Now he turned, his face aggravated. "Why? Because this is your world? This is your world of high finance and foreign business dealings, and billion dollar clients, and fine wines and magnificent lunches?" He scowled, but before she could answer, he continued. "Your world of extravagant suites and Cayman vacations, and seven-thousand fucking dollar suits?" He grabbed his suit lapel and flashed the jacket at her. "I'm not allowed in this world. At least you don't think so."

"Bull shit," she said. "You think I like this world?"

"I think you fucking love it, Kimmy. Are you crazy? Look at you. You're in absolute glory."

She put a fist to her cheek, staring aside toward the fine carpet. "You think I'm leaving you behind? Is that it?"

“Aren’t you? Aren’t you just stringing me along, placating me until something better comes along?”

She dropped her hand to her side, scoffing, showing him an expression of pure offense. “Josh. What is wrong with you? Why would you say something like that?”

“How is it not true, Kimmy?”

“Have I let you down? Haven’t I included you the whole way? I see you every night. I lay by your side in bed. I play games with you, the games you like. I brought you to Cayman, I... I’ve never stopped loving you.”

Josh’s head inclined, his eyes showing unsureness, his features betraying the wounds she’d caused but now defended.

She steadied herself, stood straighter. “If you spent the night with Devlin, how is that not betraying me?”

“How would it betray you?”

“Did you spend the night with him?”

“Why would you ask me that?”

“I don’t see you sleeping on Meyer’s couch with Sophie home. How would you explain that? And you weren’t in her bed. You didn’t come home. Where were you? Where did you sleep?”

“Were you at home?”

She said, “And the fact that you’re here. How did you know where to come? Who could have told you?”

“You wonder what else he told me.”

She chuckled in pure disbelief. “Why would you believe anything he told you?”

Josh shrugged, and she didn't like his arrogant gesture or tone. "Why would I believe anything you tell me?"

Her brow lowered. "Because I know the truth, Josh. Devlin doesn't. Devlin couldn't."

Josh raised his eyebrows and shook his head. "What is truth, anyway?"

"The truth is, you've ambushed me here where I'm supposed to be working, and your head's been filled with who-knows-what by a guy who's always treated you like shit."

Josh's mouth moved around, but he didn't respond. She knew he was flirting with saying she treated him the same way. She stared at him, daring him to say such an untrue and hurtful thing.

After a long moment of saying nothing, she spoke. "You and your buddy Devlin brought me here to bully me, to push me around. You're his lackey."

Josh rubbed his chin, walked away and turned to the window again, rolling his head around on his neck. He said, "That's not it at all."

"He's coming through that door, isn't he? You're his emcee, he's the main act? And then what? What are you going to do to me then?"

Josh rubbed his face with both hands, then ran fingers through his hair. He turned to face her, his posture more open now, more submissive. "This isn't some kind of intervention, if that's what you're thinking. That's not what I'm here for."

"If Devlin comes through that door, Josh, I swear to god..."

"Kimmy..." He paused before continuing, closing his eyes to gather his fleeting thoughts. "Whatever it is you've been doing, have you been doing it to hurt me?"

She steel-eyed him. "I don't ever want to hurt you, Josh."

"And that's why you lie?"

She clucked her tongue, dismissed his argument with a wave, and turned to the table, beginning to pack up the things she'd laid out for the Benny Chan meeting. "This is so unfair, Josh. You sandbagging me like this. It's not how you treat someone. This has Devlin written all over it."

Behind her, quiet: "Stop, Kimmy. Stop."

She ceased her chaotic packing and stood straight, crossing her arms, still showing Josh her back.

"Tell me you don't want to hurt me."

She faced him, uncrossing her arms. "I would never hurt you on purpose, Josh. I love you. I would do anything for you. I'm doing everything for you. I mean, I'm working toward something. Something for us. You said you trusted me."

"You asked me to trust you."

"And you don't trust me?"

"You lie to me."

"We're back to where we started now, Josh." She looked at the door again. "Is Devlin coming or not?"

Josh moved into the bedroom again and sat on the foot of the bed, twining his fingers together, hands clasped between his knees. He looked worn out and tired; the confident defiance he'd showed took a lot out of him. "Can you tell me why you did this to me?"

"What did I do to you?"

He chuckled and bit his lower lip—like he was biting his tongue, stopping himself from saying what he really wanted to say. "Pretend I know every lie you told me. Now, why did you do it?"

She crossed her arms. "You're talking down to me."

“I’m not,” he said, patting the bed next to him. “Sit with me and talk. You wanted to talk. Let’s talk.”

The seeking of companionship was a hopeful sign, and she responded. She joined him at the foot of the bed, both of them facing the table with Benny Chan’s contracts. They were quiet for a while.

Josh said, “I sandbagged you. I did. If I didn’t, you’d have a thousand lies ready for me.”

“What an awful characterization.”

“Isn’t it true?”

She sensed him looking at her and regarded him. “Are you trying to hurt me?”

His face softened. “No, Kimmy. I don’t want that. I want this to end.”

She was perplexed, reading too much into his words and worried he meant the marriage. “What is it you want ended?” She lost her nerve to keep their gazes connected, looking away in case she revealed the power he held.

“What you’re doing to me. Lying, deceiving, sneaking. Getting what you want and telling me it’s what I want.”

She regarded him again, studying him, assessing him, forcing her anger-pulled features to relax. “You think I’m selfish?”

“You’re not?”

“How about you, Josh? Would you like my psychoanalysis? Would you like me to break you down and ask you all the questions about how all the pieces fit together? I wouldn’t do that to you because I respect you. I respect your amazing gifts and I respect your flaws, too. I love all of you.”

“You think I’m wrong to question your flaws? To bring them out so we can look at them? I know you know they’re there. I can’t talk about them?” He

gestured with both hands to the space in front of them. “They’re like the proverbial elephant in the room.”

She set her jaw. “Name my flaw.”

Josh didn’t hesitate. “You’re a manipulator.”

She palmed her forehead, not believing what she was hearing. “Wow, Josh. So, what? You hate me?”

“No. I let you do it. I let you manipulate me.”

“That’s your flaw? I’m a manipulator and you’re the victim? You’re presenting that as your flaw?”

“I have more than one flaw.”

She sighed and patted her slicked back hair and her bun. “You know, you came in here with your hands in your pockets and I was so happy to see you. I had no idea you were here to beat me up. It was strange at first, seeing you trying to be strong, putting your chin up like you weren’t afraid.”

“Because you don’t think I’m strong?”

“You’re not strong, Josh. You’re not. I’m strong. I’m the backbone of our marriage. You’re the heart.”

“You don’t think I’m strong? So I’m weak?”

“I think you’re perfect, Josh. You’re everything I want.” Her tone had become pleading.

“But I need to know my place?”

“That’s not what I’m saying, Josh,” she said, stood up and walked away, stopping to brace herself, hands on the back of one of the executive chairs. “I don’t want to fight with you. I love you.”

She listened to Josh stand and sigh. He came near her.

She said, "I don't want to lie. I want to tell you the truth."

"That's not what I want."

She turned to face him, leaning on the chair back. "It's not?"

He looked away. "I couldn't bear it. I'm afraid of what it might be."

"Then how do you know they were lies at all?"

"You said I'm the heart. You're the backbone and I'm the heart. That's how I know."

She chanced touching him again, and he didn't stop her, but as she placed her hand on his cheek, his head turned, as though she'd delivered a slap in slow motion.

"If I love you, Josh, and you love me, and you don't want to hear the truth, then where does that leave us?"

"Here in this hotel room," he said, taking her hand from his cheek and holding it. "Trying to find out how we move forward."

"I told you to trust me, but you don't. And that's okay. How do I prove it to you? How do I make you feel secure?"

He waited a few heartbeats, eyes flitting. Then: "Show me."

"Show you I'm trustworthy?"

"Sure," he said.

"I can do that. I want to do that."

"And show me how you do it."

"I don't understand."

“Everything you did you did for me, is that right?”

“That’s right.”

“Then why hide it?”

Her eyes darted as she sought meaning in his cryptic words. She found meaning, but didn’t want to believe it. “What are you saying?” She feared she knew.

He dropped her hand and looked like he would walk away again, but his feet stayed planted. “I— I think you broke me. You know that? You know what I mean by broken?”

“Tell me.”

“Nothing works. I don’t know one thing from another anymore. You lie and I believe it. You tell the truth and I believe it. I’m your biggest defender, even when I know better. I’m like an eager public defender assigned the most guilty client and all I do is flood my perspective with their virtue. How else can I get up every day and appear in court with them unless I put on the world’s darkest sunglasses to blot out what’s right in front of me?”

“I’m not a criminal.”

“Are you guilty?”

She raised her chin. “I’ve lied.”

“You lied for my benefit. Do you hear how that sounds?”

“Yeah, Josh. Do you?”

“If it was for my benefit, where’s the benefit? Where’s my gold, where’s my treasure?”

“What more do you want?”

“I want what you owe me. You took so much from me, mortgaged little pieces of my trust again and again, and now I’m here for what you owe me.”

She closed her eyes and shook her head.

“I want relief, Kimmy. I want reprieve. I want all the pain that hounds me when I close my eyes to leave me alone. I want all the bad things you’ve done made right. I want your lies to make the truth real. Make it mine. Make it for me.”

She bowed her head, struggling to see the paths that led away from this point, believing—knowing—another man set this point in motion. These couldn’t be Josh’s words. “He doesn’t care about you, Josh. Did he make you think he did?”

Josh stayed firm. “Make it real.”

Now she imitated Josh’s own wounded chuckling, turning away from Josh and taking a step, head still bowed, rubbing her brow. “Not with him, Josh. Not with him. Anyone but him.”

“It would be meaningless.”

She turned again. “Are you really asking me this? Why on earth do you think you can ask me that?”

Still, Josh stayed firm, his eyes showing strength again, narrowed like what he would say carried significant weight. “You knew I wanted it before I wanted it. . . . Don’t you see your absolution?”

EIGHT

ORPHEUS

Kimmy said, “I can’t be absolved for sins I haven’t committed.”

And Josh made no expression of surprise or objection, staying stone-faced. He said, “Consider the sin your repentance.”

The meaning seemed obvious, and yet she wouldn’t allow her acknowledgment. Salvation had always been something she would have to concoct; a scheme she would lead Josh into for his own sake, a path lined with cushions and bumpers. “I’m not sure I understand, Josh, but... Things with Devlin have become too complicated. I can’t do what I think you’re suggesting. You see, this is why I asked you to trust me. That was only a few days ago. What happened to you?”

He shrugged his defeated shoulders. “I wiped the cobwebs away. I see things differently.”

“I’m a spider to you?”

“You spin webs, Kimmy. Without the cobwebs in the way, I can see who spun them.”

“You’re the one spinning webs right now, these aspersions coming off your tongue.” She narrowed her lips in an expression of grave personal injury. “You think I’m trying to get away with something, but all of this is for you.”

“All of it’s for me,” Josh said somberly, “piece by piece, minute by minute, all until it’s too late and I’m immersed, or trapped, or—”

“I’m not trapping you. I don’t want anything for you but good things. Things you want. . . . Devlin wants to hurt you, Josh. I want to save you. I want you at peace and cared for.”

Josh said, “I want the bad made good.”

“What bad, Josh? Holy fuck.”

Josh did that hurting chuckle again, closing his eyes, and she knew what he would say before he said it, unsure how she would respond if he did. He opened his eyes again. “Kimmy, I know you fucked him.”

She blinked and stared as a bottomless chasm cracked open under her footing. She stood stunned and unsure; steady but swayed and wary. The room swam around her stillness.

Was it a trick? If she didn’t fight back, if she didn’t object, would Josh confirm her sins without having to listen to her lies? Was this Josh’s way of ferreting out the truth? Could Josh be so diabolical?

An unexpected calm eased her while what she dreaded most faced her down. They stared at each other like Hong Kong gunfighters. The statement hung in the air, a challenge; a binary blade of time that stretched on and on, yes or no, yes or no, but no answer was good enough. Confirmation or denial were lies or confirmed treachery. And yet the casual ability to obfuscate or to misdirect was played out and worn thin. The available options had attenuated to a single-file path where only truth could remain.

She said, “Did Devlin tell you that?”

Josh acted like he hadn’t heard her. “If you don’t hide it, then it’s for me. If you keep it hidden, it was always for you.”

“This isn’t a game anymore.”

Josh shook his head, and she saw a glimmer of contempt she wished she hadn’t. “I’m not sure it ever really was.”

“Then what was it?”

“I don’t know,” he said, frustrated, gesturing with harsh hand movements.
“A charade, a, a play, or...”

“It’s all a game, Josh. We’re playing it.”

Josh looked at her, studying her. She didn’t shrink. “You love it, don’t you?
That’s got to be it.”

“I love what?”

“Cruelty, torment. Humiliation.”

“I wouldn’t love it, Josh, if you didn’t love it, too.”

“You said you love it. You like the humiliation.”

“You grant it to me. Right? I don’t do it without your permission.”

“And that’s why we’re here. Mid workday, in a ritzy hotel-suite Devlin booked for some big-shot businessman. A place where you told me the terrible things that happened like they were no big deal. I’m granting you more and more. I grant you everything.”

“And I manifest everything,” she said, more harshly than she’d intended. She softened, touched her neck and looked away from Josh.

He said, “If I told you I love it, then do it for me. We both love it.”

She muttered, “Then there would be no sin at all,” and stared at the floor, seeing all she’d ever hoped for appear before her like in a dream; an escape route. It was all too good to be true, and she couldn’t believe Josh had offered it. Such a devilish temptation. An apple in supernal Eden. A trap.

She looked up and steadied her eyes on his. “This sounds like Devlin, not you.”

“Kimmy,” Josh said, extending his hands to her, looking tired. Like all this talking had run him ragged. “He’s not here. It’s just you and me. You and me alone in this hotel room we’ll never see again.”

“A hotel room you’re not even supposed to know about, Josh. How can you come in here and present all this to me?...”

“Kimmy,” he said again, still standing with his arms held out, encouraging her to come to him. “I want you back. I want you returned. I don’t like where we are.”

There was nothing in his eyes but honest need. Something happened then, a rolling wave enfolding her, Josh’s invitation doing something tremendous to her emotions. The way he stood, the stigmatic pose, the agonal gaze. His eyes throbbed with hurt, and he pleaded for salvation.

Her own eyes swelled with emotion, probably going just as pink as Josh’s were. She strode to him and plunged into his embrace. Josh folded his arms around her.

His voice was low and strained by emotion. “I want everything to be like it was. I want you back.”

Her chin was on his shoulder, eyes staring into the bedroom, at a bed she might sleep with Devlin on. Even though it was the last thing on her mind today, Josh wanted it. Needed it.

And she needed it, too.

Not the indulgent sexual pleasure Devlin provided, but some sort of perverted rapprochement for the man she loved. And had betrayed.

She said, “It can’t be the way it was, Josh.”

“Why not?” His voice now had thinned to a reedy croak.

She stepped back, dabbing at her eyes with the pads of her ring finger. “It’s not there anymore, Josh. We can’t be there anymore.” But before he interpreted her words as a cancellation, she continued, “I want us together. I want us tighter than ever. We’ve been dancing around each other. I’ve been afraid to tell you things and you’ve been afraid to tell me, too. Afraid to admit what you crave. Fully crave. Tell me your secrets. I’ll grant them. I’ll

grant them in trade for your love. I want nothing more than for us to buy a house, for us to have a family”—she lay her hand on her chest—“that’s the only thing I think about these days.”

He said, “I don’t care about a house. I don’t care about material things. . . . But I want you... And I want a family, too.”

She pressed her lips together to prevent a broader smile from spreading across her face, the broad smile likely leading to a bubbly divulgence of what lay within her belly. The life that grew inside her was Josh’s.

She said, “But, Josh, nothing has changed. Nothing will have changed. I told you you had to trust me. I told you you had to let me figure this out.”

“Figure what out, though, Kimmy?”

“I’m talking about me and you.”

“You can’t figure us out only by yourself. You’re not going to consider me? That’s not fair. You know I consider you. If you consider me, then you have to listen.”

She tried to reason with him. “But when I listen, you say things like sin is penitence. Zero times anything is zero.”

“That’s it exactly. Zeroed. I’m offering a zeroing to you. But while I’m offering it, you need to know that I need it. I can’t go on without it.”

They stared at each other a foot apart. She reached for his hands and took them.

He said, “If I said you knew I wanted it before I did, would you understand?”

Her lips pursed into a dimpled, disbelieving line. “And the sin is the penitence.”

Josh said, “Zero times anything is zero.”

She dropped his hands and staggered away, putting her wrist to her brow like a Victorian lady seeking a fainting couch before imminent collapse. She laughed at herself then and went to the same window from where Josh had peered down onto the street below. Idle shoppers with idle lives walked the streets in busy fashion, upscale Torontonians darting from storefront to storefront, shopping bags packed with luxury goods. She chewed her cheek, then turned to face him again.

He was ready for her, saying, “If Devlin walked through that door, would you do it?”

“Take absolution.”

“Get absolution.”

Josh had defused so many of her arguments. There was no more she could say. No more schemes or lies to be spun from her devilish mouth. It hung agape and her eyes darted like they looked for an exit. But the exit was right before her, rolled out red-carpet style by the very man she wanted preserved. She said, “You know I only ever want the best for you.”

“Even when you sinned.”

She didn’t know how to respond. Josh didn’t want the truth. She would deliver it to him now, as hard as it might be, but his ears didn’t want to reconcile such heresy.

She said, “Is Devlin coming through that door?”

“If he does, what will you do?”

“Did you go to him last night?”

“I wouldn’t go to Devlin for the antidote to any poison. I’d rather die.”

Her shoulders relaxed and her posture slumped. She sagged, her knees supporting her weight, one hip shooting out. “You’re crazy, Josh. You’re so crazy.”

“And you drove me to it.”

“Don’t try to wound me,” she whispered.

Josh put up his hands, waist high, showing his palms. “I’m not trying to. Listen, Kimmy, I can’t go on the way it’s been. I can’t go on knowing unconfirmed truths. I want them wiped away. I want them wiped from my mind. Erased from the books. I want them to exist like they were mine—like they were always mine. That the things you did, you did for me and not for yourself.”

“I said don’t wound me. I would never in my life want to hurt you.”

Josh put up his hands again, left them there, speaking softly. “Sometimes I feel like I can’t breathe. I can’t think. You have me twisted in knots. And I know I like it. Or at least I think I like it. Or at least you think I like it.” His hands dropped to his sides.

“You do like it, Josh,” she said. “I wouldn’t do it if you didn’t like it.”

He turned away, but then turned back and stepped toward her. “That’s it. That’s what I want to hear. That’s what I need to hear—”

“But, Josh—”

“Kimmy, please.” He held her upper arms, adamant eyes on hers, firm but not strong, wavering, on the edge of defeat. “You don’t know how it’s been. The pain I’ve hidden from you.” He bit his lips, and she got the sense he was ready to cross a line he’d feared to cross, knowing he couldn’t go back to the other side once over it. “I followed you downtown. I followed you downtown to The Royal York one night and lurked and suffered and wondered what could be happening up in those luxury suites behind my back. You alone with Devlin up there.”

Her heart began thudding, imagining the ensuing pages of Josh’s surprising new story, one revealing a tale where he’d known her sins this whole time. “You did?”

His eyes dipped. “I felt small and like I didn’t matter and...”

When she squeezed her eyes shut, they leaked. Tears went down her face in quick rivers. “You matter more than anything.”

Josh could barely speak, his throat pinching his voice tight. “I always knew what you were doing, but I told myself it wasn’t true.”

She bit her own lips, preventing them from blubbering as more tears streamed. She touched his cheek, stroked it. Then she offered him his own escape. “That was part of our game.”

Josh answered in a rush. “It was, right?” His voice had cracked, his eyes bleary and pink. He was crying but keeping it together, his cheeks blooming red swatches.

She nodded, then opened her mouth to speak, but only a quiet, pained cry escaped, one she cut off, embarrassed by what it revealed.

Josh’s kiss came with sudden surprise, more welcome than any gesture she could remember. They kissed, and the more they kissed, the more she needed. Their abrupt connection, one that arrived in a moment where she felt lost with him, close but drifting apart, raced her heart. It came on a tender reed, the delicate and caring touch of his lips like an innocent but urgent request.

The request grew more heated when Josh sensed her desperate kisses in return. Her hands went to his neck, and Josh’s went to her waist. They staggered until her back touched the partition wall next to the archway between lounge and bedroom. She rubbed his warm neck, stroked his chest, grabbed the lapels of the tailored suit jacket she’d bought him. Their kissing didn’t stop. It grew more heated, their breaths scoring through their nostrils. Josh pressed his body against hers, pinning her to the wall. It was masculine and resolute, but still unassertive. His hard bulge pressed into her stomach, and it surprised her. But how would it surprise her? Shouldn’t she expect it? This was who Josh was. And it was proof of Josh’s determination. This was no longer some timid ruse where he cajoled her into playing along with the things that lurked in his shadows. He was done playing around the edges of

the fire, and now he was sure he could walk barefoot through it, his hardened soles ready to brave the coals.

New love blossomed in her heart, bright green buds flowering in pale pink. With it came a soaring desire to please him. To reward him. To grant to him the things he feared he wanted.

And to do it would make him whole.

She grabbed his erection through his pants, and he tightened and groaned. She kissed him harder and Josh's lips grew mushy as she controlled him with the grip she held on his stony member.

"I hate him, you know that," she whispered, stroking her hand up and down, turned at an awkward angle. "I always have."

"I want you to release me. Can you do that?"

"I'd do anything you asked, Josh." The flat of her forehead rested against his, the tips of their noses eclipsing. "Do you love me?"

"I wouldn't be here if I didn't love you."

Josh could be here if he hated her. He could be here to do her harm. Here for revenge. Here to humiliate her in return. But Josh didn't have malevolence in him. Josh didn't think the way she thought. And that was why they were both here. She'd brought him here, hungry and wheedling for the dark things he craved. And offering salvation in exchange. It was the very same thing she'd sought all these last days and worried how she'd get it.

She saw him in a whole new way. Still the same man, but one buoyant with a strange honor, a strange perseverance. A true dedication to her. And she felt the same way for him, despite the bad she'd done. She'd never wanted her man to hurt. The moment Devlin shone his devilry Josh's way, the game had changed.

So much wickedness arrived through her own hand, but Josh had imbibed it with a dark thirst. Had her badness come first, and Josh's acceptance spoiled to some sort of rotten enjoyment just for the sake of survival?

She was sure that wasn't it. Josh hadn't adapted to her. She'd adapted to him.

In his eyes right now, she saw hope. And in those churning, hopeful waters swam murky shapes of the hurt she'd caused him. Josh never deserved any of it. Her hands went to his cheeks, and she kissed him once more, this time slow and tender.

When he spoke again, his voice was quiet. "Do it now, and it won't matter if you've done it before. And I won't ask you. The sin is penitence."

She closed her eyes and touched her forehead to his again.

The sound of the room's electronic door lock clacking was like a gunshot, and at once her stomach flinched and her chest tightened with dread. These were the sane responses.

A raunchy greed slithered down low, lusty snakes in concertinaed twists and coils. Familiar yet so unexpected. Welcome, but repudiated.

If this was Josh's thirst, she would slake it.

They both turned to the opening door.

NINE

TERZA RIMA

Devlin entered with casual flair, as if he were stepping into a work meeting and not the pressure-cooker heart of a marriage primed with an awaiting wired burner phone. Though he didn't hum or whistle, he held the smug expression of a man who would. He closed the door behind him, waiting for the latch to click before speaking. Then: "Oh, you made it, Josh. Good. I was hoping you would."

Josh uttered no reply, merely regarded Devlin with an unreadable mask. Devlin smiled like the used-car salesman he was, putting one hand on hip, muscular shoulder planted on the hallway wall. His unbuttoned suit jacket opened to reveal his pants held up with blue-striped braces. He was the visage of pure, unadulterated male arrogance. Wealth, privilege, cultured attitudes of contempt for those unlike him; those beneath him.

Josh spoke at last—with surprising calm baritone. "I'm here."

Devlin's smile grew wider, his face oscillating the room, taking her in, taking Josh in. "Looks like we're all here. Together again at last."

Quips formed on her tongue; sharp words cutting his presence, the smell of brimstone, and worse words, too, ones she would save for another time. She said nothing and showed as little as Josh. Nothing for this man to hold on to, to slip his shim underneath and to pry and pry and pry.

A slight look of wounding passed Devlin's rugged, handsome face. "I was hoping for a fonder reception, really. It took so much work to get us in this room together, and I wouldn't mind some appreciation. You don't have to thank me, but..."

She said, "What time is Benny arriving?"

Devlin laughed and flashed her a warm and ingratiating look; like he enjoyed her barbs. “I sent your work to Kingston. They’ll deal with Benny Chan. He’s not that big a fish. Hardly worth my time.” He looked up and around at the luxurious suite in its stark color scheme. “Benny didn’t even deserve this suite. We deserve this suite. Don’t you think so?”

She said, “Did you practice this melodrama in the mirror?”

“Yes, Kimmy. You know me so well. Would you like to hear some more of the gems I crafted standing naked before my mirror wall?”

Josh looked from her back to Devlin. He was categorizing the exchanges and gleaning their relationship. But how would she want Josh to comprehend how she felt about Devlin fucking Stone, the man who’d tormented her husband in high school?

“Something about the moons and the stars,” she said, “maybe samurai philosophy, perhaps some hackneyed Nietzsche you gleaned from Twitter. Enlighten us with what you’ve prepared.”

A crack formed in Devlin’s slick veneer, and it got her smiling as smugly as he had been. Devlin’s eyes didn’t show the same glee he’d beamed when he’d entered.

But he recovered quickly. “How about this: This moment”—he used two fingers to draw a square in the air, meaning the room that would abet their sin—“was formed in time long ago, before you even worked for me. This moment existed before we went to Cayman, before you showed off those beautiful little tits and that absolutely perfect ass.”

Josh bristled at the lewd talk about her body, and she said, “Gosh, it’s even better than I’d hoped. How wonderful.”

Josh turned away and went to the window again, showing them his back, hands in pockets, morose but charged by the spectacle beginning. Devlin took it as subjugation, nodding, smirking.

She said, “You don’t get what you want from me, so you target my husband?”

Devlin sneered. “Who says I didn’t get what I want from you?”

She let it soak in, locking eyes with Devlin. There would be much he could say that would destroy the only things that mattered: Josh, her marriage, and their potential family. She would have to submit as well. The revolt she’d showed Devlin so far was enough to set the tone. She crossed her arms, narrowing her eyes now.

“Just remember, Josh, this man is a liar.”

Devlin said, “Look who’s talking.”

They stayed eyes locked, grinning at each other, measuring each other. She said, “I love him, you want to hurt him.”

Devlin put out his hands, palms up, swaying up and down like the two dishes of a balance scale; Lady Justice weighing two differing viewpoints. “Either way,” he said, “we’re just two mean kids pushing him around, having the time of our lives doing it.”

Josh turned and faced them, hands still in his pockets, showing the same unbothered countenance he’d worn since Devlin arrived. “You two are unbelievable,” he said. “You both need someone to bump up against.”

“Don’t equate me with him,” she said, nodding her chin toward Devlin and taking her turn to face away from the awful troika. “We’re not the same,” she said, looking at the bed.

Devlin said, “I’m not here to hurt Josh. Josh and I have been in touch. We’ve been talking.”

She shivered, a wicked wet chill racing up her spine. When she turned, Devlin and Josh were regarding each other, Josh unsure, Devlin confident.

If they’d talked, what was said? Josh knew not to trust Devlin. There was nothing Devlin could accomplish with Josh. Other than getting him into this

hotel suite for an impromptu get-together. She said, “That’s how you knew to be here?”

Josh faced her, nodding slowly. He looked guilty. Enough she didn’t condemn him for it. Not in front of Devlin.

“And how did this come together so fast? I guess you”—she looked to Devlin—“set it in motion.”

Devlin smiled too broadly.

She regarded both of them in turn, and they stared back in silence. Two men with a plan, and her with none. Were Josh and Devlin in this together? Was that possible? Were they secretly mocking her? Were they trying to back her into a corner, get her telling lie after lie, encouraging an indexed catalog of spun stories and false confessions to slip from her tongue? Make her lay all her cards face up on the green felt? They could pick through her lies and compare all the contradictions.

Josh’s heartfelt offer to her—for his own reprieve—told her otherwise.

The request he’d made was an honest need. One she understood. The sin is the penitence. She’d been reluctant, hesitant—but now with Devlin here, she knew whose side she was on, and Devlin’s malevolent energy was a force she would shield her husband from. If Josh went to Devlin, it must have been a dark and awful time for him.

She looked only at Josh now, and she nodded, her head inclining with love and sympathy for the man she’d hurt for no reason at all. Fighting with Devlin wouldn’t produce anything beneficial. And it was, in fact, risky. She crossed the room to join Josh, standing before him, handling his jacket lapels.

She spoke to both men but only looked at Josh. “What did you two have in mind for this sudden meeting?”

Josh didn’t speak, only lay those hurting eyes on her, tired and hooded. She cupped his cheek again and kissed him. He was receptive.

Devlin closed their distance, coming behind her. She flinched at his hand touching her hair. He worked open her bun, and she fought the urge to express the great displeasure of him handling her hair. But she let Josh know through various facial responses.

“First,” Devlin said, “this meeting isn’t so formal. It’s casual. We all know each other.” He tried to fan out her hair, and she grunted and worked away from him, taking her hair in two hands over a shoulder and doing it herself.

She stood beside Josh, both facing Devlin, who now smiled and walked backward until his back touched the wall. The sunlight filtered from the street-side window, casting him in flattering light, painting all the hard edges of his face and neck but leaving his black eyes shaded. He raised his chin, and like he took great pleasure performing this in front of her husband, he said, “You’re an incredibly beautiful woman.”

Josh looked at her, but she didn’t face him, didn’t want to meet his eyes. The moment was charged and dangerous. Devlin could tell lies about her right now that would destroy her. He could tell the truth and do even worse. Everything Devlin said must be seen as some sort of purposeful taunting meant to rile Josh.

Her arm slithered underneath Josh’s, Josh with a hand in his pocket, and now they were close and touching, standing as one. Devlin smirked at the sight of her, and she knew if she and Devlin were still together, he would make fun of her later when they were alone and in bed.

You play him like a fiddle and he sits at your feet listening to the music.

But those days were gone and they never should have existed. She never should have trusted Devlin Stone, and now she might pay the price.

She said, “Since you two have been talking, why don’t you tell me what you’ve planned.”

Josh muttered, “It’s not like that.”

“But it is kind of like that,” Devlin said, lifting off the wall and coming closer. “Tell your wife what you want.”

In her periphery, she could see Josh roll his eyes up, disgruntled, shaking his head. She said, “Tell me, Josh.”

Josh closed his eyes, lips parted, looking for how he might phrase it. “I want to see. I want you to show me.”

“What would you like to see, Josh?”

His face quarter-turned her way, eyes dipped low. “Don’t make this harder. Don’t make me lie, please.”

Her compassion faded and guilt weighed on her shoulders. Her chin dipped. Josh didn’t want to play games where she coaxed him to state what he wanted. He wouldn’t be able to phrase it without saying the truth. Show me what you do with Devlin behind my back.

With only her eyes, she tried telling him in any way she could how she was sorry and how she wanted his love and how she wanted to make it up to him. He could barely look at her.

She’d told him she would do anything.

She said, “You know I don’t want him.”

He nodded, looked her way now. “Then pretend.”

His answer was cold and unemotional. A directive uttered without care. The wound it delivered to her heart surprised her. Her brow lowered, her chin dimpled; she wanted to plant her feet before him and make him see her the way he used to.

But that was impossible.

Her arm retreated from under his and then she adjusted her suit jacket. She steeled herself, looking away from Josh, determined now and bound by some strange duty, crossing the half-dozen steps in her heels to stand by

Devlin. Devlin watched every move she made on the way, eyes lazy and amused, mouth corner tugged in a sly smile. As she approached, he raised his chin, looking down his nose at her, reaching for her neck. She stopped and as he nudged a hooked finger under her chin—an enticing action he would use to lure her kiss—she turned her face away. She said, “No kissing.”

This made Devlin’s smile even slyer. He would get off on her reluctance.

Devlin said, “Take off your jacket.”

She slipped it off her shoulders and tossed it to the nearby chair. Devlin admired her, eyes roaming, her standing in heels, high-waisted pants and a pure white dress shirt. Her nipples had pushed out the tight fabric.

TEN

SWEET COMPLIANCE

Josh's heart pounded so hard he swore all his rivets would shake loose. The damn four-chamber thing shook his vision, and a steady boom-boom-boom thudded in his ears.

He'd flirted, teased, fantasized about this dreadful moment, and now it would happen before him. The closer it came to being, the more inexorable the moment felt. Like this thing had always been out of his hands; that he'd been misled, cajoled, brow-beaten, gaslit into this moment's manifestation, and all at his own request.

But there was a beautiful, gold-edged frame around the picture; a submission-wrestled truth glimmering in the fog.

He could picture the scenario like the analogy of a pool hall trick shot from a rookie player: much glory could be memorialized if the right ball fell into a pocket, but if it failed, one could shrug off the endeavor as producing the anticipated result, setting the world and the player back in their rightful place. If he struggled and endured, he could be king. If he crashed and burned, well, what did you expect?

For now, he enjoyed the change in Kimmy's demeanor. The trepidation, the unsureness, the guilt... And hopefully at some point, an expression of boundless shame would appear. For now, he savored Kimmy's apprehension. A stark look in comparison to the haughty dominance that had swelled since the summer, and had come to define his wife's character.

Kimmy didn't know how to behave with Devlin. Didn't know how familiar she was with him—at least from her watching husband's perspective. So her movements were stiff, and her eyes on Devlin flickered between commanding and baleful. Seeing Kimmy this way drove down the pedal on

his lust's accelerator. As Devlin's hands undid her shirt buttons, each passing second, Josh's heart beat harder and harder. The thudding in his ears roared and whooshed.

He watched the smooth plain of Kimmy's collar revealed. The room's light shimmered on her flawless skin. Her nipples had hardened at this terrible proposition, and he loved it. She could fight this arrangement all she wanted, but he knew she'd been here before and her body betrayed her right now. Her terrific mind could turn him into knots, make him believe anything. But her body responded the only way it knew how. Her body wasn't deceitful, wasn't duplicitous.

Devlin turned her on. Devlin made her wet. He was sure of it. If he slipped his hands in her panties, they would come out with a gloss.

A tragic inertia sealed him to where he stood; the enormity of his lust for such depravity materialized before him. He was the spark that began this fire. If he were another man, this situation would not play out before his eyes and his throbbing cock.

Devlin's movements came in short travels, tentative, as if awaiting an objection, his smile creeping wider as no admonishment came and his sensual act with Kimmy increased. Still, no one stopped him. This was Josh's own doing. An inevitable destination.

As if now resigned, expecting no protestation, Devlin continued. He pushed Kimmy's shirt open wider, exposing one breast in her bra, slipping a thumb under the strap and pulling it taut. The tautness highlighted the hardness of her nipple showing through the fabric. Kimmy showed defiance, mouth closed, chin up and jutting, allowing this other man to handle her sexually. Then Devlin's thumb descended along the strap toward the cup, and when it met the point where cup and strap connected, he pushed out and down, revealing Kimmy's brown nipple. It was thick and rubbery and aroused. He let the bra strap go, and the cup cinched under her small bosom, pushing the flesh upward. Devlin's thumb caressed Kimmy's nipple, and Kimmy's eyes narrowed, that steely look she showed beginning to wane.

But now her eyes had averted, steering away from Devlin and looking his way. Looking at her husband. Her husband standing watching. Her husband standing and watching something so awful, and yet this strange man in the seven-thousand dollar suit his wife bought him believed the sin would be the penitence. He wanted her freed from what she'd done. It would free him, wouldn't it? Kimmy would have to endure. He would have to endure. They both would, together—and then hope once it was all over, there was enough remaining to sweep up and rebuild.

He also raised his chin—and he figured the gesture could be as paper thin as hers. Kimmy hated losing control. Hated the way her body betrayed her. Her defiance would soon melt away—her mask as resilient as if made of sugar.

Trouble swirled in her eyes, and for a moment he could picture himself calling the whole thing off. That one moment of Kimmy's unsureness would halt these proceedings. He didn't want to punish Kimmy, not the real Kimmy, not the one he knew and loved before the summer, he wanted to punish the other Kimmy, the one she'd created out of thin air. Maybe the one she'd created as some sort of histamine response to her own infidelity, the one who would take advantage of her husband's erotic drive, hijack it to explain away all the bad she'd done. Neither of those women hated him. They both loved him. But each did it in an entirely different way.

Kimmy bit her lips, her brows tenting to the angle of worry. She lay a hand over Devlin's, pausing his nipple teasing for a moment, saying now, "You want this, Josh, don't you?"

Her sibilant voice, though whisper quiet, surprised him, shaking him from the reverie he'd sunk into like warm swamp water. And again, the urge to cancel the plan. To take her home and...

And do what?

Stick his head in the sand and pretend she'd always been faithful? Pretend that the guy who'd tormented his youth hadn't shamed him, hadn't got the better of him yet again? That his wife and his bully hadn't worked in tandem to demean him more than anyone could ever do? That she'd helped

his nemesis into an unfathomable victory, an impossibly complex and truly thorough humiliation?

He approached them, head cocked, calm expression, one meant to convey to Kimmy the reminder that they'd discussed this. There was no time for deeper vacillation. He said, "Do it or don't."

Devlin interjected, talking to Kimmy with his thumb pad rubbing her aroused and bursting nipple. "Give him what he wants, Kimmy. How many times does he have to ask you?"

Kimmy gave Devlin a fleeting glance, then returned her unsure gaze to Josh. He loved the conundrum she'd found herself in. Kimmy had woken this morning and could never have expected what he'd ask of her by lunch time. He showed her a weak but encouraging smile.

The words she wanted from him he would not utter before Devlin.

The moment bloomed large and expectant, the only motion was Devlin's big thumb rolling Kimmy's hardened nipple in circles, torturing that swollen part of her.

Josh closed his eyes, then opened them again, filling with the wisdom of Solomon. A test. A test would decide. Kimmy would abide by the test.

He said to her, "Are you wet? Are you wet for him?"

Kimmy scowled a look of indignity, disbelieving her loving and timid husband would speak such crassness. But her expression eased with the steady time-ticking realization of her place in this room, her lace in the marriage, her trail of indiscretion. As the furrows in her brow eased away, Devlin chuckled, staring at the side of Kimmy's face. "That's a great question. That is a great question, Josh."

He steadied his amused gaze on Kimmy still and she rotated her face to regard him with a thinly veiled sneer.

Devlin said, "Are you wet, Miss Chang?"

Kimmy scoffed with disgust and rolled her eyes.

Devlin looked at Josh now. “Why don’t you come closer and find out, Josh? Put your hand down Kimmy’s panties.”

Josh stood immobile, frozen from action by racing thoughts. Bad thoughts, dirty thoughts. Lusty ones. They occluded the shame, though, and for that he welcomed them. Kimmy was dirty. Nasty. A sexual being in the way he could have never comprehended before this summer. She was wet. He knew it without even checking. Devlin made her pussy weep with urgent need. His cock throbbed between his legs. He stepped closer, and Devlin nodded encouragement.

“That’s it, Josh. Come closer, come and check for yourself. You wouldn’t take my word for it, anyway.”

Kimmy scoffed again, and Devlin added, “Or hers.” Kimmy shook her head with grave disdain.

Josh stepped closer, right next to them, Kimmy’s narrowed eyes on him, watching him with a comforting look of concern. She was breathing heavy. Her eyes were glossy. Her nipple looked rubbed raw; rosy and plump.

Then Devlin’s thumb-rubbing hand let her abused nipple alone, drifting lower to Kimmy’s waist. He unbuttoned the top of her high-waisted pants. “Check her for me, Josh.”

With his eyes on Kimmy’s face, he touched the waist of her pants, traced sensitive finger pads across the expensive fabric and located the tiny zipper pull, dragging it downward until her fly was open.

Kimmy seduced him with her eyes. Each passing second, his wife got closer to submitting to his insane request. Each passing moment, she gave herself greater permission to show her husband the nasty things she’d done behind his back.

Since he took too long, Devlin added commentary. “She wears satin panties with her suits because she likes the way the fabric slips against the wool.

Isn't that right, Kimmy?"

The intimate knowledge, and its uncomfortable implication, distracted her, but she managed to keep looking at Josh, even though the corners of her mouth tugged downward in anger.

Josh untucked her crisp white dress shirt and slipped his hand underneath. At the warmth of her smooth flat tummy, he had a surge of love for her; with the familiar touch came so many fond feelings for the woman he married. And sure enough, when he touched her panties, he found that Devlin was correct: they were satin. The acknowledgment passed in their gazes; yes, Devlin knew what panties she wore with what clothing.

His hand was shaking by the time he'd pulled forward the waist of her panties. A tidal wave of hot desire washed over him, and instead of watching her with Devlin right now, he wanted to get her on the bed, pull the pants and panties off and bury his face in her hot muff, run his tongue through her until she choked off his air supply with a trembling leg lock. Resolve seized his muscles, and he shoved his hand down the front of his wife's panties. All Devlin had done was rub her nipple, but his wife was teeming with sexual lubrication. His fingers squelched through her slick and swollen folds. She closed her eyes and moaned a sound of sexual regret.

As he pleased her wet pussy with his fingers, he asked her, "Aren't you ashamed?"

Her eyes opened and scared away any confidence he'd felt when they were closed. His fingers stopped teasing.

Those hot black eyes of Kimmy's drove into him and scoured his shadowy thoughts, striking like a feathered raptor through a mouse nest. His thoughts scattered. And he knew what she would say before she said it. Knew that her razor-like beak had snatched one particular furry little morsel out of the scattering mischief.

Her eyes narrowed, and she said in return, "Aren't you? Aren't you ashamed? Another man gets your wife wet, and your wife should be ashamed?"

Devlin chuckled, a long, low rumble. “That’s it, Kimmy, let him have his humiliation. Don’t hold it back from him.”

Josh’s hand slipped away from her pussy, withdrew from the warmth of her panties, and he stepped back. His heart pounded hard. But he loved it.

He said, “I never should have let you work for him.”

Kimmy reached between his legs and grabbed a rough handful of his genitals, injuring his tender balls for a brief second before finding the distinct shape of his iron shaft and squeezing it. She said to him now, “You’re not ashamed?”

ELEVEN

OF OPTIC GLASS & TUSCAN ARTISTS

Devlin's low animal voice grumbled near her ear. "He wants you to show him. He knows you're wicked, and he wants you to show him." He thumbed her bursting nipple again, sending off sweet fireworks. Her breaths were quick and shallow, and her heart raced at the rhythm of lust and need. Though it was Devlin talking, he wasn't wrong. Josh wanted what Devlin said. That's all Josh wanted right now. That was why he was here. To see. To know.

She nodded, still struggling against the chains of virtue and modesty. Her body was far ahead of her mind. Her body was all in; chambered and ready to fire. She was turned on, and though it had been stiff and draggy at first, the arousal was hot now and growing hotter.

But her mind still struggled. This act of stark betrayal performed before the man she loved weighed down the passage like a heavy anchor. Her body urged her to charge ahead, show off, give the performance Josh craved, but her mind never trusted anyone or what they said. And she knew she couldn't trust Devlin Stone. He'd showed her; he'd earned her wrath.

Her pants stayed unzipped, her panties askew from Josh's hand, the crotch snugged against her sex, which throbbed with need right now. She felt the spate of her desire spreading, soaking her panties, preparing for penetration by an oversized cock. Devlin handled her bared breast, both men watching her, both men under the spell of a sexuality she didn't know existed before this summer. All it had taken was application and look what it got her.

Josh watched her with that hurt look on his face, the one he showed when she pushed him around sexually. One time Devlin had said Josh drew the bullies to him, that Devlin hadn't sought Josh out. Maybe Josh did enjoy

subjugation; she knew it made his dick hard as a rock, and he'd worked hard to outsmart her and bring her into this luxury suite trap.

She said, "Aren't you ashamed? I can't even help it, Josh. My body has needs."

Josh's eyes fluttered with whatever joy he could find in such harsh treatment. It was as though it was him submitting. But it wasn't—he was in control. Josh led the show. She submitted to him.

Submission to Josh seemed right. Submission to her husband—the sin is the penitence—was righteous. Victory was everything, but victory could be measured in different aspects. If she submitted to Devlin, the submission was to a proxy. Devlin was Josh at this moment; Devlin was a man who didn't exist. Josh was her friend and husband and so much more, and she would perform for the man she loved. And that would be the true triumph.

She wanted to smile, wanted to kiss him, but feared she could dull the sharp edge of her instrument. Josh's kink required a steady hand and a sharp blade; precision was key. No smiles. No compassion.

"You certainly have needs," Devlin said.

She stepped rearward to rest her back on the wall, Devlin stepping along with her like they danced. She never let her eyes leave Josh, luring him into a dark performance for his pleasure. Her hips pressed forward, her pelvis tilting, and Devlin wasted no time claiming the real estate of her exposed flat stomach, sweeping his hand across the bare skin above her opened fly and her panties. Her eyes still stayed on Josh, steady and sure (while Josh's trembled). She communicated to him she would allow this man who'd bullied him in his tenderest time to do what he wished to her body. Josh's chest rose and fell at a quicker pace, his cheeks sinking, his jaw dropping.

"I'm going to let him do whatever he wants, Josh. You're going to watch."

Josh's legs twitched. His thighs flexed. She knew if she peeped in his underwear right now, she'd see a steady stream of clear excitement streaming from his rock hard dick.

Devlin's face loomed close to hers, smirking. "Even take her mouth with mine, stick my tongue in her mouth."

She turned her face away in disgust, trying to stay connected to Josh.

Devlin sniggered, his hand running up and down her bare stomach, getting very close to dipping inside her panties.

She said, "I need it. And you want it. We're perfect, aren't we?"

Josh licked his lips, his eyes widening in horrified awe.

Devlin said, "Tell her you want it, Josh. Tell her."

Josh raised his chin, showing defiance and bravery. "Show me," he said.

"He wants it," she said, eyes narrowed on Josh's, showing him confidence.

Devlin came closer again, this time not to attempt to kiss her, but to whisper in her ear. "I told you I'd make him beg you for it."

She scoffed and moved her ear away from him, putting her hand over top of his, pushing it toward her pussy, guiding his fingers to dip under her panties. "I'm so wet," she whispered.

Josh's Adam's apple went up and down in draggy jumps. He couldn't swallow. He was frozen by the sight of her leading another man's hand into her underwear, guiding another man to touch that most private part of her; the most private part of Josh's possession. He nodded, eyes blazing with terror.

She shoved Devlin's hand further, inhaling sharply, feeling his big fingers wriggle through her sopping sex. The pleasure was unexpected; she'd been so focussed on Josh, she'd forgotten how good this would feel. She grunted and mewled, rolling her hips against Devlin's fingers. Knees flexing, up and down, humping Devlin's hand, his two middle fingers spreading her labia. When he slipped a finger inside, she froze and shuddered, held his hand in place there and humped it harder, eyes on Josh the whole time. "His fingers are so big."

Josh almost crumpled, and she couldn't help laughing. She recovered quickly, turning the laugh into moans of pleasure. Josh stepped aside, eyes tugging away from her for a moment to locate a seat, pulling one away from the table where she thought she'd be sitting across from benny Chan this afternoon. He dragged the seat out and sat down, eye-locked and aghast again.

She said, "I hope he doesn't make me come," sly and seductive and definitely hitting some kind of sweet spot in Josh's psyche, given the rise in his spirits, the blush on his cheeks, the new wildness in his eyes.

"That would be terrible," Devlin grumbled, stroking his finger in and out of her pussy. Shallow, not deep; perfect. She was wet and elastic right now.

When Devlin drew his finger out, then ran two combined fingers inside her, she sighed with ecstasy, letting Josh know in a husky whisper, "He has two fingers inside me."

Devlin uttered a growl of appreciation, saying to Josh now, "She has such a tight little snatch."

She grunted disapproval, but Devlin and her own theatrics meant for Josh had her unable to pull from the draw of Devlin's pleasure. She ended up grimacing, squeezing Devlin's wrist, but her hips were undeterred from fucking against Devlin's slow thrusting.

"Don't worry," Devlin said. "Josh already knows how much I love your pussy."

She grimaced again, pulling away from the pleasure for a second, enough to put a hand on Devlin's broad chest and push away. Devlin laughed as his hand slipped out of her underwear. Devlin showed Josh the shine on his fingers, holding them up and wiggling them.

She said, "Did he say something like that to you?"

Josh shook his head. "Don't listen to him, Kimmy. You know better than to listen to him."

Devlin loosened the knot on his tie, then ran the tie out from under his collar, taking its length in one hand and looping it around the palm of the other, like a prize fighter taping his hands before a match. He watched her, smiling a wicked smile, eyes sparkling. She knew what he intended and then was unsure if she should accept it before Josh. Would it look too familiar? Or would it send Josh into orbit with passion?

And did it matter? Josh knew she'd cheated. He would never say it aloud. But he knew.

Why fight it anymore?

Devlin came close till they were face to face, him looking her over, enjoying himself. Without looking over at Josh, he said, "She likes to get tied up. You know that?"

Josh squeezed his thighs together, then let them go. He looked like he was enjoying the worst case of stomach cramps he'd ever had.

But she would stick with denial.

"You have an active imagination." It would almost be enjoyable for Devlin to fuck this up, to state some of her worst crimes. She might welcome it. She dared him to try her with her eyes. Try me.

Devlin unfurled the tie, then roped it around her neck, pulling her to him so their chests touched. "I want that tongue," he said. "Don't deny me, Kimmy."

She didn't turn away this time, just stared at him with a small measure of contempt and a lot of indifference. She eased her face closer, put her lips on his and kissed him, long and slow and seductive, putting her hand on the back of his neck, stroking his hard, angular jaw. Devlin was surprised, but he didn't flinch, getting what he wanted when he thought it would be much harder.

No tongue, though—she pushed away from him.

“I kiss my husband,” she said. “I put my tongue in my husband’s mouth.”

Devlin smiled the whole while, tossing his tie into Josh’s lap. Josh batted it to the floor.

She said, “There’s only one reason you get to be in this room with my husband and I.”

Devlin said, “And what’s that?”

She dipped her chin, looking between his legs. “Pull it out. Let’s see it.”

Devlin cocked a hip. “That’s all I am to you? After all we’ve shared, it comes down to my huge dick?”

“You love it more than I do. You love it more than Josh does. Let’s see it. I know you’re dying to whip it out.”

Devlin sneered. “Josh does love it, doesn’t he?”

She chuckled too. Couldn’t help it. Josh had a certain obsession she couldn’t deny. Couldn’t blame him for either.

Then Devlin said, “You know you love it, Kimmy. You know you can’t get enough of it.”

“It’s really sad when your whole persona revolves around your oversized dick.”

Devlin showed her a mean laugh, amused at her, downplaying how close she’d come to something he probably thought about sometimes when no one was around. She showed him her own smile, a smug, commandeering one.

Devlin slowly drew down his zipper, looked to the right, saying, “Josh, you know she got herself a replica, right? She fucks herself behind your back with a rubber copy of my dick when I’m in Kingston.”

He pulled out his cock, tugged it, dropped it and let it hang; this huge, flaccid pound of brownish flesh swinging left to right between his parted legs.

TWELVE

BEATA BEATRIX

Josh's stomach roiled and churned with the acid of hate and disgust and humiliation. The barbs, the jabs, the sheer arrogance from the most hated man in his history book. The craziest thing: even though Devlin had his dick out, the thing that angered him the most was some sort of barely understood insult launched Kimmy's way. The indignation and offense Kimmy showed on her beautiful face provoked some shining, valorous part of his psyche to urge his protection, his defense of the woman who'd been cheating on him. It was wild and unexpected.

He was sure whatever Devlin said had some sort of spark of truth (the image of Kimmy and Devlin in bed came to him, the two engaged in post-coital pillow talk, Kimmy saying how she wanted a home version of the fleshy implement that delivered such illicit pleasure, eyes turned down to watch her long finger trace a line up its underside), and that Devlin wielded the creative barb now to bash Kimmy, to put Kimmy on her heels, to get her reeling. And that was fucking exciting. He wanted to protect her, yet the desire to see her sullied, for Devlin to diminish her, was electrifying. It aroused him as well.

And that's why he didn't leap to her defense, merely waited to hear her response.

Kimmy's look of disgust changed to perplexity, an expression of incomprehension. Like, what the fuck are you even talking about? It seemed contrived. She did buy a replica of Devlin's cock. Had she masturbated with it in their own bed sometime?

His eyes settled on Devlin's penis hanging out of his fly. It was huge. As huge as ever. It had begun to thicken at the base, and the semi-engorgement

hoisted the still-flaccid end upward, but drooping, the sagging end soft and fleshy, nodding along with Devlin's movements.

Kimmy's eyes down-turned to Devlin's huge penis, bowing out of his fly, stiffening, but gravity urging its heft downward still. The sight of her regarding this thing that struck fear in Josh's own heart riled even more excitement from him. It was hard to bear. His wife's eyes rested on another man's massive endowment and looked unbothered. Of course, she'd seen it before. She'd seen it in Cayman. Devlin had shown it off right in front of Josh—how had he ever imagined nothing had gone further between Devlin and Kimmy behind his back?—but Kimmy's lack of curiosity or surprise or indignation cemented the truth he'd denied for so long: Kimmy had plenty of experience with Devlin's manhood. This display was old-hat for his wife. Last fucking week in this very room, he'd slapped it against her bare thigh. She'd told him that. Told him straight out.

This was why he was here. To play it out. To find something in this sinful betrayal he could hold close to his chest and call his own. To take back something these two had stolen from him.

Kimmy said, "I don't play with toys."

Devlin took off his suit jacket and tossed it on a nearby chair and began undoing his cufflinks. "Depends what you call a toy." His eyes shifted toward Josh and he smiled to one side.

Kimmy's brow lowered. "Can we do what we're here for without your dramatic flair? Do you think anyone appreciates it?"

"I do it for me," Devlin said, dropping the cufflinks into his pocket and unbuttoning his shirt. "It's entertaining."

Josh said, "I don't like the way this is going. Okay? Why do you two have to fight?"

Kimmy rubbed her jaw, wanting to say more but restraining herself. Devlin chuckled to himself, shirt fully unbuttoned now, his muscular torso

displayed between the open curtains of his unbuttoned dress shirt. He faced Kimmy. "I'm not looking for a fight."

Kimmy's expression was plain, stolid. It was the expression of the Kimmy who scared him sometimes. "I'm not either."

Devlin said, "Why are we here?" He looked toward Josh. "Why are we here, Josh?"

He stayed firm. "Because I want you to be."

Devlin smiled and faced Kimmy again, amused, eyebrows high; his eyes were lively and his face depicted the phrase: see, I told you.

How many times had Devlin tempted Kimmy with the notion that her husband had wanted this all along? Devlin was the one who'd planted this seed whose roots choked off his sanity; that ate all the nutrients and minerals his brain needed to maintain healthy, rational thought. Devlin was the one who'd encouraged the seed to grow. Devlin planted his business card in the front hall. Devlin had texted him those taunts.

Now Josh chuckled, disbelieving his own blindness. It was willful. Whatever grew in his mind turned to hot lusty sunlight, turned away from reality's darkness, all to ensure he would witness this event unfolding before him; watch the seed bloom its juicy, sinful fruit.

Kimmy said to Devlin, "And why are you here?"

Devlin handled his growing cock a moment before stuffing it back into the fly and hiding it away. It bulged out his pant leg. He stepped closer to Kimmy.

"I was summoned."

She scoffed, turning to look at Josh.

"I didn't tell him to be here."

Kimmy regarded Devlin. "It was you?"

“I sent Josh a save the date.”

Kimmy wasn't amused. “Why?”

Devlin touched her undone hair, touched her cheek with the backs of his fingers. Kimmy moved her face away but Devlin pursued her, saying, “Strength doesn't exist without weakness. I've told you that. I didn't appear out of a vacuum. Weakness conjures me.”

Kimmy shook her head, mouth quirked to one side, showing her cynicism. Devlin held her neck. “Josh,” he said without looking Josh's way, “ask her again. Tell her what you want from her.”

“She knows.”

Kimmy nodded, turning up her chin. “I know what he wants.”

“Then why are we still talking?”

He pulled her closer by the back of her neck, and Kimmy's hands disappeared inside his unbuttoned shirt. Her hands were on Devlin's bare torso. Feeling his muscle. Feeling his masculine body.

Josh shifted, and though his temples pounded, the desire ballooned inside him, and he wanted to see more and more and more and worse and worse and worse. His palms came together between his knees in the style of prayer, and he put his weight forward, rocking, feeling his hardness squeezed by the cut of his tailored pants. Kimmy had said in front of the tailor she knew on which side Devlin dressed.

Kimmy watched her own hands on Devlin's hard chest, pushing his shirt wider to expose more hard flesh, flecked with manly hair. “Then Josh is in charge,” she said.

Devlin didn't deny it, only laughed a small sound in his throat.

Kimmy knew her husband's game. Was that it? Knew her husband could only find solace by reframing his position; changing himself from victim to

an enabler instead. A facilitator. If he could convince himself he believed it, he might just survive this ordeal.

Devlin held Kimmy's neck still, now thumbing her delicate jawline. "I think we all have our own hand in it. All of us need the other."

Kimmy dragged her nails down Devlin's chest, settling on his waistband. She slipped her long fingers underneath his silk bracers and slid them up to his chest again. "So much philosophizing for something so base."

"I'm offended you don't see the art in all of this," Devlin said, thumb still jaw-stroking.

"Art used to matter when it sought beauty," Kimmy said, slipping the braces over Devlin's broad, muscular shoulders. The straps fell to his thighs.

Devlin's thumb pad stroked higher, to a point just below Kimmy's eye, resting on the point of her cheekbone. "I think we're going to show Josh a lot of beauty. You don't?"

Kimmy shook her head no, lips pursing. "I think it's going to be crass, brutal. Ugly."

"Stop," Devlin said, enjoying it. "You're turning me on."

"That is what you like. Chaos. Destruction. You're a man who pretends to build because that's how you get close enough to set it all on fire."

Devlin cocked his head, looking into Kimmy's eyes. "I think Josh wants us to be nice to each other, and here you are casting aspersions again."

"You're right," Kimmy said, amused by it all, like she knew she could get the better of Devlin if she wanted. And Devlin knew it, too. Josh was convinced of it. Devlin could say things that would embarrass Kimmy in front of Josh, and that worried her, but it was because she'd done things she was ashamed of. Shame showed she cared. But they were things he knew now in his heart that had really happened. And knew that despite all the

betrayal, she would do whatever it took to please him. To really please him. To make things right. To make things better. If he could elaborate on that perspective, it was possible that he could find the art, the beauty in his wife's witchcraft. But nothing came to him now, no rousing crescendo of love, no swelling violins to announce his epiphany; only an understanding that his wife was not the woman he thought he knew. She was capable of things he couldn't imagine, capable of atrocity and meanness, and he wouldn't want her cruelty truly aimed his way. Her cruelty, when she wielded it against him, was done for his affection, for his pleasure; but also to establish a new role in their marriage. What was once a shared road trip had become a toad's wild ride of horror, traveling too fast with the heat cranked and all the windows rolled up; he wasn't a driver, a copilot or a navigator, he was along for the ride, sitting in the back seat holding on for dear life while Kimmy worked the pedals and took the wheel and decided what they would listen to on the stereo.

But his eyes narrowed on a distant glimmer: a very distinct truth materialized on the roadway, something shocking. Devlin held a small measure of fear for his lawyer, who he sometimes fucked behind her husband's back. Like maybe he'd thought he controlled Kimmy at one time, but now he feared she'd slipped her lead.

Kimmy smiled as if to herself and watched Devlin's chest bared as she guided his fine dress shirt over his big shoulders. Devlin worked the dress shirt off his arms behind his back as Kimmy's fingertips explored his chest and ribs. Devlin was a fine masculine specimen; a truly powerful male build with humps of bulging muscle.

When the shirt was off, Devlin guided Kimmy back and eased her shirt off as well. Josh fixated on the swollen knot of her nipple being tested by the edge of her bra trying to close over her breast but stuck on that nipple like it was a doorstop. Both parties were topless, hands touching one another, Kimmy standing tall on her heels, Devlin unclasping her bra behind her back. Once the bra was off, he smoothed his palms over her small breasts, going over both bursting nipples, and Kimmy's expression showed a silent sighing of relief, as if his touch soothed some of the ache in her breasts, the flesh swollen with desire.

Josh sat straighter again, his thighs closing hard and squeezing on his own aching desire, his cock flexing and twitching as he watched the man who sullied his school days enjoying the one most amazing thing in his life he could call his own.

One thing was sure: if he were to ever have fantasized about a scenario like this, he would never have imagined it at lunchtime on a Monday.

THIRTEEN

BY MERIT RAIS'D

Arising but disgusting thought baked in her oven. It was so dark and delirious her pelvic floor throbbed, and she tightened her sexual core in the most exquisite pulsing, undulating pleasure waves that echoed the deep thrusting she would soon receive. All it took was Devlin's hand on her breast. It wasn't the touch; it wasn't his brutish but well-groomed man-hand on her little titty, it was one-hundred percent that Josh was watching it happen. All the reluctance, all the resolve, all the disdain she'd held for this malevolent man who'd somehow engineered this situation crumbled like an iceberg's rampart at the unending challenge of the ever-turbulent sea.

The more she thought of it, the quicker and lustier her breath came. Josh watching Devlin fucking Stone's hand—the big hand of her husband's high school bully—drove her wild. It took conscious effort to stop from kissing him. She'd said no kissing, but right now, and all of an unexpected sudden, what she most wanted was to suck Devlin's tongue in front of her husband.

Her pathetic, wormy husband.

That wasn't even how she felt about Josh at all—how did this spot bubble up from her effervescent spring?

It was that Josh wanted it, but denied it. It was that her loving husband craved something so dark and awful he could never conjure it into existence. All he could have ever done was playfully bat at the idea like a timid, uncoordinated kitten. Pat-pat-pat. Josh wasn't lion enough to sink his fangs into the idea's flesh, consume it, make it his own, nourish himself with the forbidden nutrients that made living this awful life so god damned grand.

No, this was her gift to him.

She was the one who brought Josh the things he needed. Made it okay. She was the one who nourished him.

Right now, she craved all Devlin Stone possessed. All he could deliver. She'd been reluctant at first, knowing Josh wanted this—had always wanted it—and wanting it to happen for her husband, but disturbed by the idea of letting Devlin handle her this way again after she'd sworn him off.

His hand stroked over her naked chest, the palm riding over both nipples that thrilled at his touch. Thrilled at the size of his hand, his obvious masculinity.

The cruelty soared her heart. The torment she delivered to her husband lifted a cap off her psyche and her thoughts flitted like fast kingfishers looking for juicy little lake bugs to nip out of the air; fat mosquitoes of humiliation and shame and kink.

Devlin's stroking hand slowed; the pad of a thumb rolled over her nipple and the effect tightened her anus, lifted her onto her toes, bringing her four-inch heels off the lacquered hotel room floor. He pushed it aside till pain blistered from the harsh treatment. She moaned. When she did, he lifted his hand and swatted her breast, right across her nipple, making her breast bounce and shake. He swatted it again, and she yelped, let her head fall back to rest on the wall. Devlin swatted the other, once, twice, then soothed them, coddling and caressing, his eyes on hers, his smile twisting with dark delight.

She lifted her chin, her eyes lazy and narrow. "Is your cock dripping yet?"

Devlin's jaw flexed and his eyes narrowed with an insatiable hunger. "You're so fucking hot. You're too hot for him."

She said, "You're just mad because he's got me and you've got no one."

Devlin's smile faded, and he took the back of her neck and yanked her closer. "I get every fucking thing I want," he said, and closed his mouth on her throat, running his tongue along her exposed neck. Her hands went to his hard shoulders and caressed them.

Devlin guided her face away, his hand closed on the back of her neck. “I got you in this hotel room.” He looked aside toward Josh. “I got him here. Just like I said I would.”

“How embarrassing if you couldn’t get it up.”

Devlin chuckled, knowing she worked him, but he took her hand and guided it between his legs, pushing her hand over his genitals. Her grip closed around the hanging weight of his half-hard shaft. “Tell him what you feel. He wants to hear it.”

She squeezed and handled his huge cock through his pants. “I told you I know what side he dresses on.” Her gaze was slow to move toward Josh, afraid how she might find him. But Josh was riveted. Eyes widened, but still narrowed, his brow lowered, his cheeks hollowed with fright and passion. “I told him that once,” she said to Devlin, facing him again. “And that I know you don’t wear underwear.”

Devlin released her hand, and she abandoned his growing member to put both hands on his chest. In her heels, he wasn’t much taller than her and she was able to kiss his mouth with ease. It took Devlin by surprise—but he was quick to adapt, his hands sweeping her bare back, pulling her closer, chuckling in his throat with the pure delight of her new cooperation. Devlin did this to please himself; she did it to please Josh.

She pushed her tongue into his mouth and he groaned, his muscles tightening, holding her tighter. Her mouth rolled on his as she moved her head around, pushing her tongue deeper into his mouth.

Connected with a passionate and vulgar kiss, Devlin’s hands closed on her waist and lifted her. She hooked her legs over his hips, hoping Josh would witness how familiar they were together. Josh would delight himself with the worst thoughts he could imagine. They were the truth. They were the truth, and with the confirmation playing out before him, she would earn penitence.

Devlin turned and walked with her riding his hips, still kissing, coming to the foot of the bed, leaning forward and resting her on her back, her legs

still clinging. Their kiss disconnected. As much as she disliked Devlin Stone, she didn't hate lying on his bed and watching him above her with his shirt off, his muscles enlivened, the veins standing out. He dropped over her, hands on either side of her body, hair coming out of its gelled shape to let strands dance over his forehead. He rested one palm on her tummy, right above the waist of her pants, rode her torso from navel to sternum to throat. Admiring her. Assessing her. Desiring her. They'd been so good together once, before he'd crossed her.

Devlin gripped her shoulder and turned her roughly so she was face down on the bed, looking over her shoulder with venom at this treatment. His hand went up the middle of her back and took hold of the back of her neck, squeezing and thumbing. Then he was gathering her hands together, crossing her wrists at the small of her back. She rested her chin point on the bedding, bringing her feet up and crossing them at the ankle. Behind her, Devlin told Josh to come into the bedroom. "The view's not so good from there."

Silky fabric crossed her wrists, and she tried to recoil; Devlin grabbed her arms and brought them back.

She said, "What are you doing?"

Devlin said, "Sometimes she likes to be tied."

She rolled her head to the right to see Josh sitting himself in a seat above her, at the head of the bed and in the corner of the room, right by a matching window looking out on the street below. Devlin looped the tie around her wrists and closed a loose knot. She watched Josh, neither of them smiling, only regarding each other.

Devlin's fingers hooked into the back of her pants and he guided her up to her knees and chin. She flicked her head to sweep her untied hair over to one side so Josh could see her better. She regarded him again, unsmiling. Devlin's hands went around to her front, gathering at her tummy, working out the clasp on the waistband. He unzipped her pants and hauled them back and down, baring her panty-clad bottom, pushing the pants to gather at her knees planted in the bedding. He snuffled low male sounds as he kissed

the small of her back, fingers tugging at the waistband of her satin underwear, his thumb pressing against her sex, mashing and rolling the padded crotch against her pussy; the pleasure and her own personal measure of humiliation heated her in new ways. Maybe Josh would scrounge empathy, gather compassion, if he saw his wife so abused.

She regarded him again, this time looking more sultry than before. Josh's attention was unalloyed perfection; this was the fieriest incitement he would ever experience in his life, and he was soaking all of it in, recording it with his trembling vision.

Devlin peeled the panties back, exposing the bared top-flesh of her buttocks, dragging the panties downward over the curve of her bent-over ass, exposing her anus—but stopping there, a half inch before stripping her pussy to the room's light. Her heart rate increased in the heartbeat of time where Devlin stopped disrobing her, waiting to see what he would do next. Wondering what horror Josh would now witness.

A warm slithering tongue point danced from her tailbone down between her cheeks, widening to a paddle that melted against her anus. A disgusting, shameful display.

She groaned and tossed her hair, her features pinching in honest revulsion, knowing her husband would see Devlin doing a terrible thing to her. Her heart ached for him; it hurt for the awful things that Josh couldn't escape. They were things that he craved like oxygen.

She rested her forehead on the bed, hiding her face away, moaning, "Oh, god, oh, he's eating my ass, Josh, oh, god, oh..."

Devlin's tongue slithered north again. He grumbled, "I missed your perfume."

She kicked her feet and flexed her thighs, a growing molten orb swirling between her hip bones, a raw need building, gargantuan need for Devlin's massive size to spread her wide and touch her so deep inside.

Devlin lapped his tongue over her anus again, touching, teasing, driving her wild, getting her panting. It was hard to breathe in this awkward position, hard to monitor her husband's delight and shame. And Devlin Stone eating her ass while her husband watched—and she was tied and helpless—was squeezing something wicked out from her damp washcloth of a pussy. Her sex juices were teeming; she could feel the heat, the wet, the prickly tickle in her swelling creases.

Devlin's tongue narrowed again and pressed into her sphincter, seeking hot interior real estate. She squealed, unable to prevent the embarrassing sound, losing control she thought she had over the situation (and the men in her life).

She babbled more sounds of soft feminine disbelief at what this brutish man did in front of her husband, and of the obvious pleasure the act riled in her. Devlin worked his tongue in and out, teasing, driving, dancing over such a private place. The panties slid lower, Devlin working them down as he fucked her ass with his tongue, pushing the panties to join her pants bundled at her knees. The conditioned air of the room brightened all the places she was wet; her pussy was sopping, wandering traces of overflowing juice lit up in trails down the insides of her knees.

Devlin said, "Fucking look at this pussy. She has a such a great one. I fucking missed it."

She slid her cheek on the bedding to regard Josh. Josh scowled and whimpered, bringing his knees together in a sexual, existential struggle she loved to see.

FOURTEEN

LE BAISER

Kimmy's voice sang in Josh's ears, though she spoke no words. This is for you.

He could picture her mushed lips shaping those words, and thus combining them together as man and wife in this moment where she sought the penitence he'd offered.

Only there was something stark and destructive in witnessing the act. The sin was the penitence, and yet now that he witnessed it with his own eyes, there was something sinister in the revelatory theater playing out on the bed before him.

He couldn't trick himself into reasonable denial this hadn't happened before. While Kimmy played the role as subjective sexual object, Devlin played it with his devilish flair; announcing each act in a manner of familiarity in case Josh couldn't see it with his own fucking eyes.

He'd known it all along. He'd been unseeing and dumbstruck. All for what? All to see what he watched right now. Kimmy was wretched. But he was worse. This was his command all along. Wasn't it?

His wife was chin down, ass up on a Yorkville luxury bed with the midday light coming through the windows and painting her in pale and natural shades with little shadow. Her pants and panties were around her knees and Devlin had bathed her ass with his tongue. Now he admired Kimmy's pussy.

Though he couldn't see it from where he sat, he knew what Devlin would see. Knew what it looked like from Devlin's vantage; a tight, brown wiggly thing of great beauty. Compacted folds, generous when aroused but not

extravagant. Devlin touched it with his fingers, and Kimmy's brows raised and her cheek stroked the bedding. Devlin would see her hot pink interior, brightened with her wet.

The power of what he'd set into motion began to weigh on him with mighty force. It was too much to bear; too much to witness. But he was glued to the chair and hungry for more.. Much more.

Devlin knee-walked backward off the bed, standing at the foot, grabbing Kimmy's ankles above her expensive shoes and below the hem of her dress pants, pulling her feet toward him and returning her to lay face down, hands still gathered at the small of her back. He guided her to roll over. Her chest showed the blush of arousal; her nipples were bloated rubbery buds, full-fleshed blossoms of her desire for a man like Devlin Stone. With her hands behind her, her back bowed and thrust her meager bosom toward her secret lover, aroused by the scenario and the foreknowledge of the pleasure he would provide. Her chin touched her chest, her eyes only on Devlin as he stood proud and muscled, undoing his fly, the silk braces swinging against his thighs. He withdrew his heavy weapon and presented it, letting it dangle in front of them all. It was bloated but not yet erect, a truly grotesque implement, but one that would enthrall most women—and Kimmy. The head of his cock was enormous, a monstrous dropsical plum leaking the seminal lubrication that would provide easier passage inside Kimmy's tight interior. And from where he sat, now with Kimmy on her back, he could see her scratchy pelt sparkling with her copious dew; his wife's interior preparing as well, greasing itself for maximum allowed pleasure. Devlin's perverted tongue up Kimmy's perverted ass had her sexual motor primed and fuel-rich, running warm with the choke ready to clear.

Seeing them lubed up with sexual impulses and immutable lust removed any notion this scene would play out in another way. In short time he would watch his hated nemesis put his big cock inside his wife and make her howl and cry and orgasm all over the bed. His internal pressure—down low, down where his own sex apparatus spewed sympathetic juices—boiled hot. His cap could pop at any second. He wanted that. He hated how badly he wanted it.

But with each heartbeat, stoicism proved harder and harder. His bolts were shaking loose; his hands trembled on the chair's arm rests; his neck was stiff and creaky and tightened; his heart raced, his vision warbled. His thoughts seemed light and ethereal, like they were made nothing in this room where fantasies were made real.

Devlin reached for Kimmy, brought her up sitting before his growing trunk, then putting out his hand toward Josh, not looking, but saying, "Take your tie off."

"My tie?"

Devlin wagged his fingers. "I want your tie."

Kimmy's head lolled above Devlin's large hand, eyes dazed by lust, hypnotized by the pendulous swinging of his enormous beefy induction.

Josh bit his lower lip, sitting higher, his thighs squeezing together to pressure his own exquisite arousal, loosening the knot on his tie and withdrawing it from his collar. Devlin was aware of the action, wagging his fingers while never removing his gaze from Kimmy's. Josh heaved forward, knees touching, and passed Devlin his tie. The one Kimmy had bought him for a night of humiliation at his bully's hand. Had she sent him into the lion's den? Had she known Devlin would plant evidence of their illicit union? He'd been played every step of the way since the night at Tiffany's cottage party.

Devlin looped the tie around a hand and held Kimmy's face. He took his cock by the base and brought it up to her cheek, batting it, his cock shaking with its boneless heft. His cock against her cheek made a bright, sticky tap. No other man would dare treat her this way.

Though that wasn't true. If he asked her, she would allow her husband this treat. It was just him who couldn't provide; his human-sized penis wouldn't have the same effect. They would both laugh and bust up (back when things were good, and none of this darkness enfolded them). With Devlin, Kimmy fell under a spell. Devlin's masculine prowess and mighty implement did things to his otherwise well-regulated partner.

Kimmy turned her head from side to side, lazy, as if avoiding the meaty batting, but also opening her mouth, expecting Devlin to put that overripe plum into it so she could suck it. Soon, her tongue appeared, curving over her bottom lip, pale pink on the smearing red of her lipstick. Devlin plopped her tongue, once, twice, three times, then at last, he let her pull it past her lips and into her mouth.

How many times had Kimmy sucked Devlin's cock? How many times had she come home to him, kissing him with the same mouth that pleased this villain? His hands cupped his mouth and nose, and he breathed into them, facing the reality that Devlin had come in his wife's mouth at some point. Cruel Kimmy may have kissed her husband with Devlin's semen still swimming in her hot oral pockets. The pure, unbridled shame and humiliation of it aroused him to astounding levels; almost to the point of unexpected bliss. For a brief second, he could see the beautiful perfection of his plan.

It vanished in vulgarity: Devlin's spit-slick cock now running on her cheek and leaving a trail. Josh turned up his nose and looked away for a moment.

The sounds of their movement returned his gaze.

Kimmy's head rolled on her long, swan-like neck as Devlin used the tie Josh wore today to circle her brow and lower into place over her eyes. Devlin tied it at the back, stroked her shoulders, then guided her to lie back again, pushing her higher up the bed. Kimmy lay with her aroused nipples pointing to the ceiling, her arms behind her back, her pants down to her ankles now. Almost entirely naked.

Devlin smiled as he unbuckled the tiny straps at the heels of those black patent shoes, one and two, slipped them off her feet. The pants and underwear were also stripped away, Kimmy now completely naked, hair undone, wearing only two men's ties to bind her and blind her.

Devlin planted the soles of her long, tawny feet against his chest, stroking her legs from ankle to calf, admiring her naked form. Kimmy trembled with excitement. Josh could see it; could see the way Devlin's touch rose the hair on her arms and turned the skin to goosebumps.

With both her thin ankles gathered in his grip, he raised Kimmy's feet to his mouth and kissed the soles. Kimmy's toes curled, and she enjoyed the sensual feel of Devlin's lips. She writhed on the bed.

Devlin put one ankle on either side of his neck, Kimmy's legs up on his shoulders, his face twisted to one side so he could kiss the inside of the leg while he unbuttoned the pants and pushed them down, kicking off his shoes and stepping out of them, his cock beating his own muscular thighs.

Then naked Devlin was kissing his way down the inside of Kimmy's legs. Kissing one, then the other, nibbling her thigh flesh, biting the inside of her skinny knees. And Kimmy loved it; closed off from the horror in which she engaged, laying back and loving sex like how she'd been getting it behind his back; freed of all the burden of guilt and betrayal, open to body pleasure. And he'd like to think, separated from Devlin Stone. Maybe she was honest when she'd said she hated him. She was done with him. Maybe Devlin betrayed her.

A hopeful glimmer appeared on his dread gray horizon. A hope maybe she hated Devlin for some harsh words against her husband. She did love him, though no one would ever believe it, watching in the room at this cosmic moment.

But it was a crazy thing to think, seeing her now, bowing her back, gasping with lust as Devlin's kisses approached her most sensitive flesh. Kissing the area around her pussy, kissing her inner thighs up high. She raised her knees, drawing her feet across the black and white bedding, letting her legs flop wide like wings, the knees coming down to touch the mattress like she would in a hot yoga class. It exposed with no obstruction her pretty pink flower.

Was this how Devlin got the photo of her pussy? Had Devlin eaten her out in some warehouse in some port somewhere, taking his wife on a pallet of fertilizer?

He could picture it: Devlin seducing her, incrementally bringing her into the tangles of his web, and one day she surrenders to the desire, kissing becoming oral sex, Devlin feasting between her legs. Sure, Devlin would

show her he wasn't a brute who only wanted to fuck her. He was offering her a world of extramarital pleasure, a smorgasbord of erotic delights.

A sudden jolt of pre-cum gushed out of him and he squirmed in the seat, his stomach fluttering, his head going light.

Devlin kissed higher, his tongue scratching through Kimmy's patch, long hairs sticking to his pink tongue. Kimmy panted; her head lolled. Devlin kissed higher, up the taut plain of her belly, up to her sternum. Rising, kneeling over her open legs to straddle her waist.

He said, "Turn and face Josh," waiting for her to comply. Kimmy's head rolled his way, her eyes aimed his way but shielded from him by the silk tie he'd put on this morning. Devlin handled her chin, making sure she cocked her head at the right angle. Then he thumbed her lower lip. "Open that mouth, Kimmy. Let me see that slippery tongue."

Kimmy knew what he wanted, and she opened her mouth wide, her tongue sweeping across her lower lip, trembling in anticipation.

Devlin gripped the base of his cock again, the other hand out for support on the bed as he lowered his hips, saying, "I'm going to fuck that beautiful face so Josh can watch."

Kimmy squeaked an affirmative sound in her throat, nodding, and Devlin pushed that cock head into it, both hands on the mattress now, his cock stiff enough he could hump his hips and stroke his cock in and out of Kimmy's stretched lips, poking out her cheek, rolling her head around. And Kimmy worked her mouth, sucked and swirled her tongue until spit streaked her mouth and chin, and Devlin kept fucking her mouth, Josh positive he was about to see her throat bathed in a gallon of seed.

FIFTEEN

THE WAKEFUL BIRD SINGS DARKLING

Sex was the penitence, and her humiliation under Devlin could be her salvation.

Did Devlin offer humiliation as a kindness?

Her jaw remained slack as Devlin's overripe cock head ran in and out of her mouth. Devlin pumped an unending stream of his salty seminal fluid. This act excited her ill-advised lover more than anything she'd witnessed before. Devlin loved Josh's eyes on him in a lurid, homoerotic way. And it was reciprocated. Josh loved watching it. Hated Devlin, but loved the size of his enemy's cock. Coveted it. So much so, he wanted to endure this spectacle of his beloved wife sucking it, riding it, worshiping it. And that's all it was when you got down to it; both of them suppressed some sort of deep-seated size kink. The unreal size of Devlin's manhood—his one redeeming feature—got them both hot and bothered and sent them out of their goddamned minds. Devlin was a tool, and both Josh and she had utilized him in selfish regard; her with wanton betrayal and Josh with passive allowance. Inch by inch, day by day, pacifying and ameliorating and mitigating, swallowing (and suffering) her easy lies until this moment right now of Josh's offered grace, where he bore sweaty, eager witness to the very thing he'd always wanted but hadn't the courage to request, watching with exquisite, excruciating torment as his darkest dread fantasies came to life, his inert wife's mouth getting fucked by the well-hung man who'd probably framed his peripubescent masculinity and set it in an unintended trajectory.

It was Amy who'd done it; set this terrible thing in motion. Whispered in her ear, made fun of Josh's smaller penis when he'd been piss-drunk, literally urinating with his wife's manual aid while Amy persevered, determined to take a peek at Josh's endowment even though she'd struggled

to conceal it. Saying, oh, poor Kimmy, you missed your chance. Meaning the night she'd fled from a prospective threesome with Amy and Devlin. She wasn't that girl. Not then. She'd fled that night like a timid mouse, and cursed herself over it, over the shame, over the humiliation. Not the missing out. She didn't want to do it. Didn't want to find the courage. Her mother was dying of cancer, and the girl she'd thought a friend used her to make herself appear superior in Devlin's eyes. Who would have invited skinny Kim Chang—she of the good grades and multiple extracurriculars—for a threesome? Only a cruel human. Cruel in the way only women can assemble.

And Josh had his own version of Amy. Perhaps a malevolent greater by a magnitude. What did Devlin whisper in her husband's ear when her back was turned?

The room—her reality—was dark to her, the tie she'd bought for Josh blocking her vision. It occurred to her Josh may have left. Devlin wouldn't stop. Devlin would keep fucking her mouth while Josh drove home to Ajax in tears, later Devlin convincing her it was still part of his plan, that Josh fleeing only sunk Josh deeper into their game.

When Devlin guided her shoulder to roll her over, his wet cock fell from her mouth. Now on her back, she licked her lips, sensing Devlin straddling her chest, not yet done putting his cock in her mouth.

She gasped for breath, then, panting, asked Devlin, "Is he still here?" Using the purposeful distancing of the third person to appeal to her husband's dark kink.

Devlin growled an affirmative uh-huh in his throat, then dropped the heavy weight of his engorged organ on her mouth, running it north over her nose, brow, and forehead. His balls rested against the space between the point of her chin and the angle where her throat began.

Devlin's cock ran back and forth over her face a few times, his scrotum batting her chin, then he brought the point to her mouth and pressed its plumpness against her lips. She opened her mouth and ran out her tongue.

Devlin slithered the cloven underside of his cock head over it in delightful slick swirls, saying, “Let her know you’re here, Josh.”

Near her side, Josh repeated the monotone mantra: “I’m here.”

“Don’t worry, Kimmy,” Devlin said. “He likes it. Your hubby is riveted. Are you hard as a rock, Josh? . . . I bet you’re fucking rock hard. Your wife is so fucking sexy.”

She played along, craning her neck to angle his cock right inside her mouth, holding the head against her palate and sucking hard enough to produce a loud, wet flatulence.

Devlin said, “Kimmy sucks cock so good, Josh. So fucking good.”

She popped his cock head out of her mouth and ran her tongue under his shaft. Devlin humped it over her bathing tongue, the strokes becoming protracted until he’d dragged his scrotum over her chin and the significant weight of his balls crossed her lips. She mouthed them, tongued them, moaning, pulling one past her lips.

“Kimmy loves my balls. Suck my balls, Kimmy. Fuck, that feels so good.”

And it felt good to suck them. Felt good to perform. There was enormous liberation in her penitence. She would suck Devlin’s balls. Suck his cock. Do it all the way Josh wanted her to do it. Do it as confession. A wordless avowal of her sins, a supplication before her husband, an amende honorable, a begging of pardon. In the future, their whims would always intertwine; no more betrayal, even when betrayal promised to amplify the arousal.

Devlin’s balls felt so good in her mouth. The man might be shallow and detestable, but in bed there could be no other passion of such measure. His balls were large and sexualized, ovate factories of glorious semen that propelled the massive ropes of his male power. He’d come on her stomach, her chest, her face, her legs; he’d come into the crotch of her panties. He’d come in her grip, he’d shot his loads all over the Toronto apartment. . . .

He'd come inside her so many times. And she would make him come today, and Josh would watch her do it.

"That's it, nose to tail," Devlin said, drawing his hips back and sliding his cock along her tongue. She sucked on his cock head.

Devlin said, "Hey, Josh. Your turn now," and decamped, abandoning her on the bed, his moving weight jostling her, still blindfolded, arms in awkward restraint underneath her. The vulnerability was perfection.

Josh's timid voice: "What do you mean?"

Devlin gripped her ankle and tugged her body so it went widdershins, lying across the bed rather than up and down. Her crotch faced where Josh sat, and her legs were open. She didn't close them.

"Don't you want to eat that pussy? . . . Look at it. Just like the picture. Look at her dripping."

Her pussy throbbed under their inspection and she felt that thunderstorm of sexual need pounding her shore. She wanted Devlin's cock so badly. Needed it.

"I want to watch you lick that up. I want to watch you devour that pussy. Get it soaking wet so I can glide right in."

The vile language, the disrespect, the locker room subjugation, got her writhing, got her squirming. The tie binding her wrists dug in; her breaths came hot and heavy, and she whispered, "Please, Josh, do what he says."

"You hear that?" Josh said yeah, and Devlin said, "Get on your knees and prep your wife for me."

Then came the sound of swishing fabric, her lovely gentle man slipping off the chair, doing what his bully commanded, getting on his knees. Josh's familiar hands swept her thighs, and she flinched as his hands slid northward toward her center of throbbing, aching desire. The thought he would prep her for another man consumed her—and opened another

doorway of perversion: what about after? What about when she'd been stretched and filled and her pussy pounded and filled? Would Devlin command Josh to eat her out again? She moaned, and swayed her hips, knowing and hating the truth that it wouldn't be the first time Josh had Devlin's semen on his tongue. But would Josh do it when he knew it was there?

Josh's breath trembled between her thighs. He was shaky and unsure, and she loved it. Her hips humped upward, trying to find her husband's mouth, wanting it right now, worried he would take too long. At last, Josh's mouth closed on her sex and he worked her in the ways she knew he would. It was Josh. It was her husband. He was now an official participant. He'd been enfolded; his kiss between her thighs was like his signature on a contract. She cried out with a sound of pleasure and joy and release, but it really felt like triumph. This was what she'd craved. Her own fantasies of absolution, ones she'd dreamed but didn't know how to craft, unfolded now, opened up, like the petal of her flower under her husband's tongue. Devlin had done the impossible. It was Devlin who'd brought Josh's proverbial pen to the dotted line.

"Bet you've never had her this wet before, Joshy."

Josh's tongue worked, but he managed a feeble exhaling negative that vibrated on her labia. She thrust her hips into Josh's mouth, her core hot as a reactor.

"Kimmy loves cock."

Now Josh moaned an affirmative, kissing and sucking her sex flesh. And she was wet like never before. It crackled under her husband's oral ministrations. It seeped down below, running through her creases, and she was sure it would stain the bedding.

"Ask her if she loves cock, Josh."

Josh didn't do it, murmuring and suckling still.

"Ask her Josh."

Josh's tongue slowed and soon pulled away. From between her legs, he asked her, "Do you love cock?"

She moaned and gyrated her hips, wanting his mouth's return.

"Answer him, Kimmy."

"Yes-s," she hissed.

Devlin: "You love big cock, don't you, Kimmy?"

She still squirmed, humping her pussy up to her husband. "Josh, don't stop, keep going."

Josh said, "Do you like it? Kimmy? Do you like . . . big cock?"

She nodded, saying, "Yeah, I do, I do, keep going, please, Josh."

But Josh didn't continue, and she frowned and whimpered, hating that she couldn't see him, see his reaction, know what he was thinking. While it gave her license, gave her freedom, it removed so much of her ability to assess.

Devlin said, "You like big cock too, Josh. You know you do."

Silence. Josh had moved from between her open thighs, but he was still close.

"You can suck it if you want."

"I don't want to."

"No judgment, Josh. You got Kimmy ready. You could get me ready, too. Get me nice and wet before I fuck her."

She panted and fought her restraints. If Josh wanted to suck Devlin's cock, she would deal with it. But if he did, she wanted to see.

Devlin chuckled. “Look at her. She wants to watch you suck my cock. Should we untie her? Take the blindfold away?”

More silence, and she let her head fall back to the mattress, listening.

Devlin said, “It would be sexy if you did. Don’t you think?”

“No.”

“You don’t? . . . Kimmy, do you want to watch?”

She didn’t answer yet, wondering if she should roll over to her front. If she did, she could get the tie off and then uncover her eyes. She closed her thighs together, shaking her head, wondering why everything with Devlin had to be like this. Why, when everything went so well, Devlin insisted on throwing a stick in the spokes.

Devlin said, “Uh-oh, she’s getting mad. She’s a nasty one when she’s mad.”

She gritted her teeth, flexed her jaw, staring with open eyes into the tie that wrapped them. Was Josh going to do it or not?

But then she frowned, eyelashes fluttering against the tie’s silk.

Look at it. Just like the picture. Look at her dripping.

She said, “What picture?”

SIXTEEN

MORE GOOD THEREOF SHALL SPRING

With one query, Kimmy braked the proceedings and turned his stomach over, sick with guilt. How could he be the one on the defense, given everything that transpired, given every disgusting thing that played out before him on the bed?

His heart hammered and frail explanations shook in his thoughts. Crouched bedside before his naked wife, the lover she'd been fucking behind his back for months, looming close, his grotesque organ dangling so close—asking him if he wanted to suck it. And somehow guilt managed to swell. It was unmanageable. So unmanageable the only circuit left open was one of rage.

How dare you? How dare you ask about the picture? You're wretched.

But the guilt for going in secret to Devlin to see the picture was unshakeable.

Devlin stepped past him, dropping to sit next to Kimmy's body on the bed, running his big veiny hand up her thigh, from knee to hipbone, resting back on one elbow

"What picture?" he repeated, smiling, his enormous engorged tool laying over his thigh. "So curious, Kimmy," he continued. "Like the proverbial cat."

Kimmy scoffed and her head dropped back to the mattress. She'd closed her legs, like her alarm at Devlin's provocative reference to a photograph had turned off today's sexual spigot. Disappointment flashed like a beacon on a troubled car's dashboard. What they were all doing today was terrible, and it was impossible to endure—but it had to be done.

Devlin looked his way, him still on the floor before them both, hard as steel, sweating through his tailored wear, heart hammering. Devlin said, “She hates not knowing.” He smiled and regarded Kimmy for a second. “Look at her struggle, look at her wanting to know, wanting to know it all, wanting to have it all.” His hand drifted from her hipbone back down to her knee again, trying to part them and reveal her pussy once more. “It’s not your time anymore, Kimmy. Today is Josh’s day. Open your legs for him.”

Kimmy allowed Devlin to move her knees apart. Her pussy was puffy, the lips full and ready, cushioned in preparation for a big dick pounding. Her husband had prepared her, though the arousal flowed from Devlin’s sexual prowess. The sexual shine aroused him. His wife was well-greased for entry. Entry by Devlin Stone. His chin dipped down in a pose of shame.

Devlin spoke to Kimmy now, leaning back on the elbow, mouth near Kimmy’s cheek. “I wonder what the picture is? There’ve been so many.”

Kimmy grunted and squirmed, and Josh watched between her legs. Her rump flexed and rolled, her pussy still eager and undeterred, even though she must know there were things hidden from her. She still wanted to go. And seeing that washed away his momentary shame for his heavy predicament. This had to be done. He couldn’t move on without closing the circle, without his own fingers clasping it closed.

“Keep going,” he said, renewed strength elevating his voice from timid to command.

“Hear that? . . . We’re just getting started, Kimmy. When we’re done with you, we’ll have to bring the IV in again to get you on your feet.”

After this cryptic statement, Devlin flashed a smile and a wink his way. The prospect of the statements meaning tightened his guts, screwed them up and wrung out all the poison so it flooded his bloodstream. You could never believe Devlin. Everything he said had meaning or intent unknown to you, meant to fester later like his words were rusty nails in barefoot summer. He hadn’t yet been vaccinated for Devlin’s particular infection, and already his mind was chasing horrors, picturing Kimmy getting pounded by Devlin’s monster cock for an hour or more, this way and that way, on her knees, with

her ankles over her shoulders, and when Devlin was done, she could barely lift her head from the mattress.

Yeah. At the Royal York.

He could picture it all happening while he lurked in the Royal York's lobby, wondering what crime his wife might commit many floors above with a man he hated.

Kimmy grunted and whimpering a muffled sound, twisting her arms behind her back. But he got the distinct impression this was a torment his wife enjoyed. Her own dark desire. Out of control like the way he loved to have control removed. Under Devlin's thumb. Under Devlin's mighty sexual tool. Both of them submitting to Devlin in their own way, sinning, biting into temptation. Tasting selfish sweet juices they knew better than to consume.

Kimmy surrendered to her restraint, going slack, like she'd died. Dead, but shaking her head in what Josh could only assume was some sort of profound regret. She'd trusted the devil, and the devil did devilish things.

"Now bring your heels up onto the bed, Kimmy. Spread wide for Joshy. He's come a long way to be here."

Kimmy complied, unusually obedient, more the way she would allow him to make requests. For someone who disliked Devlin so much, she seemed to obey very well. He could hope the obedience was a function of her husband's offered penitence, that she spread her legs wider not because Devlin asked, but because her husband watched. Did it matter? There had been a time he didn't watch, and she spread her legs for Devlin, regardless.

Her feet slid up to the mattress, and she bowed her knees open, showing off her shining slit in vulgar display. Devlin massaged her mound, his fingertips tugging at the dusky membranes, burrowing in search of her swollen clit. When he found it, Kimmy moaned a high keening sound and humped up her hips. Josh flexed his stomach and felt a pulse of further lubricant tickle the tip of his aching dick.

Devlin manipulated her, rubbing two fingers into her labia, mashing her opening, then up to roll circles over her clitoris until Kimmy was trembling again. Then he slowed, and eased his middle finger inside her, Kimmy stilling, concentrating on the penetration, holding steady while Devlin put the finger all the way inside her.

“You like that, Kimmy? Does that feel like Josh?”

Kimmy gasped and arched her back. Devlin eased the finger out again, then slid in the two middle fingers together. “Is this more like Josh? Is Josh like two fingers?”

Her head rolled side to side, the sunlight shimmering on his tie’s fabric wrapping her eyes. Her lips had parted. The moans she sounded were more troubled.

“That’s it, huh? That’s what Josh gives you? I know you need more than that. Do you want more, Kimmy?”

Kimmy panted, then nodded.

“You want three fingers? You can’t take three fingers, can you?”

Kimmy nodded again and Josh squeezed his knees, a swirling insanity coalescing around him. It was too much to take. Again, he felt like he could either smash the table lamp over Devlin’s head or he could ejaculate in his pants in one of the wildest orgasms he would ever have. Either one could formulate and he had no plans other than to watch. Watch and suffer.

Devlin bunched three fingers and began to plunge them in and out of Kimmy’s pussy. The sound of her wetness was devastating. It was a cruel but beautiful sound. The sound of slick sexual suction. Sounds another man should provoke in another’s wife.

“Mm, Kimmy likes three fingers, a lot. I bet she’d like four. But I think I have something way better. Did you want to watch Josh suck it first?” The fingers still plunged in and out, Kimmy’s juices still streaming from an endless carnal reservoir.

This homoerotic subjugation was a dark alley Devlin lured him into, but one he wouldn't fall for. If he did, he'd be hit with Devlin's blackjack, awake to a hellish realm of Devlin's sexual thuggery. One he would never escape. One that time would provide no release from. He said, "Stop fucking around."

Devlin looked down at him. "What if she wants it?"

"She doesn't."

Kimmy spoke, her voice weak and whimpering but finding enough strength to say, "Just do what you're going to do already."

"Kimmy, you know if you give me commands, I'm just going to do the opposite. I'll tease this little water park between your thighs all afternoon, till the lines have dwindled and the parking lot is empty. I'll do it just to watch you suffer."

Kimmy thrust her hips up again but Devlin withdrew his fingers, only rubbing her pussy, not penetrating. Kimmy mewled with frustration.

Devlin shook his head and looked Josh's way. "I don't know how you got this, but kudos, Josh. She really loves you, you know that?"

His eyes swelled suddenly, a burst of emotion seizing his heart. It was true. It really was. She hated Devlin, and she loved her husband Josh. Kimmy was a victim of her own sexuality and there was no way he could deny how he related to that.

Devlin said, "So you're just going to sit there and watch now?" He handled his own balls, squeezing and stretching his scrotum before gripping the base of his cock and holding it outright, touching the wet tip to Kimmy's thigh. "That doesn't sound like much fun."

Josh swallowed—with difficulty, like something had caught in his throat—and said, "It's what I want." He rose to stand above the bed, his shadow casting across Kimmy's legs and up over her tummy. It looked like a painting. He sat down on the chair again and leaned forward.

Devlin beat his cock on Kimmy's hipbone, then humped it back and forth, the end of it rustling through her matted pelt. Her hair clung to Devlin's sexual flesh. The scratch of Kimmy's pubic hair against Devlin's glistening cock skin tightened Josh's core even more. His whole torso suffered the cramp of extreme tension.

Devlin kneed Kimmy's thigh, and as further proof Kimmy had spent cruel intimate time with Devlin, she responded, knowing what Devlin wanted her to do. She rolled with his direction, swinging one long, gorgeous leg over the other and sticking her behind back toward Devlin, exposing her sex and anus, her legs sandwiching a perfect frame of Kimmy's most personal space. Her arms stayed folded behind her and she arched her back so Devlin could assume a close curve behind her. Her palms rested on Devlin's muscular stomach, her fingers stroking him.

"You got her nice and wet for me, Josh," he said, then to Kimmy, "I'm going to fuck you with your husband's saliva for lube, Kimmy. You like that?" And Kimmy nodded, writhing in a way that told him she was lifted up into an erotic stratosphere. Moments ago he'd thought she might object to his sudden arrival and cryptic request, but now here she was overheated and horny and practically begging for Devlin to put his huge cock inside her.

The end of Devlin's cock slipped over Kimmy's sex and Josh grew lightheaded. Lightheaded with a perfect symphony of disgust and desire and sheer death-defying arousal. No urge came to stop the proceedings—though it should—because he knew in his heart it had happened before. The only way out was through.

"I'm going to go slow," Devlin said to Kimmy in a low, quiet voice. "It's been a while."

With that, he eased the head of his cock into her opening, Kimmy's shining petals parting to accept, swallowing it, rippling over the supple coronal ridge. And then it was official: Devlin Stone was inside her. Devlin Stone had fulfilled his bully's unspoken promise to, those many years ago. You are what you are, and I am better. Better enough he could seduce a man's wife, raise the sexual temperature until he could go deeper and deeper still,

whispering sweet-nothings and offering sweet-somethings until he had that man's wife on a bed, showing that man—in person—what it looked like when your wife got better.

SEVENTEEN

SINS

Kimmy's expression transformed as Devlin's huge size spread her wide. Josh tried to watch two things at once: his wife's soaking and supple membranes parting to accept Devlin's oversized organ, and, at the same time, his wife's face as she endured agonizing sexual pleasure. Her jaw slackened, her neck arched, and her mouth fell agape and her lips puckered while she drew in a long, gasping breath. She couldn't take Devlin in one whole stroke, and Devlin had to draw his cock out and then try again, going a little deeper this time. Josh watched his wife's face again. A transmogrification. From pure beauty to something artfully monstrous. A religious painting capturing the perfect representation of lust; one lurid painting of a polyptych decrying each of the Seven Deadlies. And though Kimmy was guilty of them all, lust was her richest sin.

Devlin teased her with short strokes, his extreme girth challenging Kimmy's pussy, bullying her pink interior. Then Devlin repeated his earlier gloat in Kimmy's ear, loud enough for Josh to hear: "I told you I'd make him beg."

Kimmy moaned, her chin raising higher. "You did. You made him beg for it."

"Release. He wants release, and we're going to give it to him."

Kimmy's head bowed forward and her fingers closed, her hands forming loose fists against Devlin's stomach as he pushed deeper inside her. She drew her knees up higher to give him even better access.

Devlin humped in and out of her in slow and steady increments, not even halfway buried in her, only warming Kimmy up, stretching her out and getting her prepared.

Was it always like this? Was it always so slow between them? Devlin said it had been a while. When they were fucking regularly, did they have quickies? Quickies at the office, doing it fast at Kimmy's desk, hoping Tami wouldn't come back to reception and catch them; doing it in the stairwell; a quickie in Devlin's Mercedes; a quickie on some fertilizer bags in some shipping warehouse. . . . The truth was unavoidable, and it sank his heart and furrowed his heavy brow. Of course they had. They'd had sex. They'd had sex more than one time. They'd had it fast, they'd had it slow. Devlin bought an apartment around the corner from the office. He wants to make a stronger establishment in Toronto, Kimmy had said. Bull shit. Devlin Stone wanted a place to fuck Josh Waters' wife behind Josh Waters' back.

He'd been a fool this whole time. He could say he was a reluctant fool, but that was a lie. He could have prevented all the things that occurred with Kimmy and Devlin, but he did the opposite. He permitted it. Permitted it in hopes some day what he witnessed now might transpire.

Pure hatred—he was also a great sinner—burned his timid submission like fuel for a fire, stopping him from choking off, closing up, extinguishing something incredible that he knew now he'd stacked all the driest kindling for. This fiery spectacle was his own making, his own facilitation. So he would enjoy its bitter poison, let it wither his system while sending him off into a sexual orbit; pleasure and destruction; a smoky opium den of rapturous demise. And he would accomplish what he came for. The hate burned hot in his heart, allowed him to bear baleful witness, allowed him the boldness to say, "Show me everything I missed. Don't hide it from me. Show me. Show me it all."

Kimmy's whimper this time was different. One of pleasure, yes, but one of iniquity, too. The sound gave him courage; gave him hope.

The sin was the penitence, but the lies, however, were yet unpunished.

Devlin grumbled a sound of satisfaction, not just a momentary, fleeting thing, but something profound and established. Like Devlin had done much work as well to end up on this bed so Josh Waters could watch Devlin Stone fuck Kimmy. Devlin wanted this, had made it happen with Josh's help.

And it was incredible to witness; a horror show, a complete tragedy, and yet, one so lurid and terrible to arouse Josh in a way nothing else could. Nothing could be worse than what he watched, but his cock ached and throbbed and twitched, and something slick and greasy slithered around his heart. It brought him joy and shame, passion and disgust, euphoria and fear; a razor's edge of sexual destruction and sexual exultation. This was unattainable; the rarest of elements. The cost was astronomical, but so was the value.

Devlin's hand gripped her skinny waist, as if to steady her. He said, "You want me deeper?"

Kimmy nodded, her mouth agape and trembling. Devlin sunk his massive cock deeper into her pussy, and Kimmy's feet bowed, her toes curling.

"Kimmy likes it deep," Devlin said. "Loves it. Don't you, Kimmy?"

Again, she nodded, biting her lip now. Devlin's cock sank deeper still.

"She likes it because it's too much. Too much stimulation. Kimmy loves too much anything."

This one, Kimmy didn't like as much, and Josh saw her brow furrow above his tie-blindfold. A strange and secret smile tugged at the corners of his mouth. Devlin not knowing it all like he assumed. Cocksure. Arrogant. Kimmy let him inside her despite her disdain for the man. Kimmy lay on this bed now because her husband asked her to. Pride swelled in his chest. A million conflicting emotions writhing and wriggling in a nodule over his heart, an existential, anfractuous burrow alive with wrath and war and struggle for dominion. But there were no more regrets.

"No," he said. "No, she doesn't." It didn't even sound defensive. Only contradictory. And knowing. This was another facet of Kimmy revealed, one he only suspected now confirmed, but it afforded a richer picture Devlin could never comprehend.

Devlin ignored him, deciding action was a better plan. He gripped Kimmy's waist tighter and shoved more of his thick cock inside her. Kimmy

squawked with pleasure and pain, arching her long neck, pushing her pussy toward the intrusion; wanting it. Devlin gave her more.

Then he resumed the fucking; back and forth, sawing his beefy member in and out of Kimmy, her pussy clinging to his bulk, the thin membranes rolling in and out with each thrust. Their sexes shone with their mutual excitement, their combined lubrication aided by Josh's own vigorous oral labor. The three were intertwined in this moment, drawn inexorably tighter, like a wet knot.

"It's hard to take, at first, Josh," Devlin said, "but grit produces pearls," as his hand slipped lower from Kimmy's waist and over her tummy, down between her legs. His fingers rolled over her clitoris and her legs shook.

Josh looked at Kimmy and Devlin's pink union, his bully's monstrous cock deep inside his wife and giving her undeniable pleasure. And something else. No condom. Kimmy hadn't even requested one. Hadn't demanded one. Were they exclusive? What were the words used when they'd discussed a contract for exclusivity? Had they begun their affair with caution, using condoms?

Fuck. Was this why Kimmy went back on the pill?

At that thought, some kind of inner trap door dropped opened and his guts and heart and assorted viscera fell out his proverbial asshole. The reality of this horror hit him at last. Kimmy was an organized betrayer. A pragmatic one. Their tryst was not some sort of one-shot, some sort of fall to the power of momentary passion. It was calculated. It involved the complicated levers and gears of calculated betrayal. And somehow, regret still didn't loom out of the mist, try to turn his ship over. Kimmy was showing him her sin, allowing her husband to command the bridge, providing him the facility to steer them through a storm and find safer waters. She didn't want Devlin. She wanted Josh. This was for him because he wanted it, had asked for it. Now he folded, somehow chuckling, tears of pain and, yes, joy blurring his vision for a moment. Maybe the plan was right. Maybe he could restore more order than he'd ever thought. The urge to laugh loud and obnoxious, to bellow manly gales of insane humor, tickled his fancy, wishing he wore a

Hawaiian shirt and smoked a stogie right now. Kimmy's submission granted him sudden armor that made him invincible to his bully's blows.

But still, there was that awful betrayal. That calculated derision she'd bathed him in when she'd planned an affair with the worst person in the world.

From his folded position, he lurched forward, feet still on the ground, his elbows on the bed, his face near Kimmy's, her eyes shielded from his by the blindfold. He said, "Did he seduce you?"

Devlin smiled, looking at Josh over Kimmy's naked shoulder. Kimmy's brow furrowed again and the corners of her mouth turned down.

He asked again: "Did he?"

She shook her head no.

"What was it? Was it greed?"

Devlin still smiled, and he nodded now, picking greed as Kimmy's sin.

Kimmy's brow furrowed further, and he didn't like his plan of action. This was emotion, ugly male ego seized by sick jealousy. Kimmy's greatest sin was sloth; a lack of care, the abandoning of the hard work of their marriage, a failure to struggle for its value.

The teary vision came again, and he palmed his forehead, running it back over the new haircut he'd sported at Kimmy's urging. She'd atoned for that already. Hadn't she? Her begging trip to Rome on his heels, unable to exist in his absence; Kimmy's trip to Mecca. That was her supplication. He'd told her not to speak in Rome. Not to utter the words then he wasn't prepared to hear. And today, getting fucked by Devlin from behind for her husband's enjoyment was an atonement as well. Even her sloth could be forgiven.

An act of grace that powered his heart like fresh batteries: he kissed her smooth brow, right above her forehead. Soft. Gentle. The kiss of a saint.

As he retracted, returning to his front-row seat, Kimmy's chin tucked down to her breastbone in the pose of crying. Submission to forgiveness. Granted reprieve by her noble husband.

His own selfless act wowed him. The tension in his neck released, and the blood flowed faster and harder. The room seemed brighter.

Devlin slowed, his dark brow lowered and furrowed; the unhappiness lifted from the sinner and transferred to the fiend. He pulled his cock all the way out, gripped it, and batted its substantial heft in wet blats on Kimmy's tawny-pink sex. Each meaty slap got her twitching, putting her ass back, wanting the pleasure that thing gave her returned.

The room dimmed again, and his brow lowered like Devlin's.

Devlin said, "Kimmy's got the best pussy. Some girls, they want nothing to do with this"—more sticky cock-smacking—"some like it, some love it, but no woman can take it like your wife, Josh. No woman wants it like she does. Her little pussy was made for my cock."

Horror set again, looming like a speedy autumn dusk, returning the gloom to his heart. Not all of Devlin and Kimmy's intimacies had been revealed. There was more to come. More for Devlin to illuminate. More sins to discover.

Devlin kissed Kimmy's shoulder, humping his hips against her back so the wide dorsal side of his cock ran its wet berth back and forth over Kimmy's anus and sex. Kimmy humped her hips in time with Devlin's thrusts, eager for more and more. This wasn't enough for her husband to see. Kimmy wanted to show him the whole thing. And not because he'd asked for it, not because he'd already bore witness, but because she liked it. Really liked it.

Devlin untied her wrists and freed her hands. Devlin ran his knuckles up her bare back to her neck and rubbed her collar. Kimmy gathered her hands in front of her and smoothed where the tie had sunk into her. But she didn't yet remove the blindfold.

Devlin growled near her ear. “Let’s get you on your back. You’re ready for more. Let’s show him. Let’s show him how you like it best.”

EIGHTEEN

OPPROBRIUM

What she hadn't counted on was the arousal her revealed betrayal would provide. She'd always pictured it differently. Pictured it like how terrified she'd been when Josh had jetted away to Rome and had left her wallowing in a morass of conjured thoughts that slashed at her with sharp blades of her own horrific imagination. Guilt. Dishonor. Shame. Betrayal. And the worst: abandonment. But now Josh bore witness, and his witness bore submission. Submission to her ills, to her desires, to darkling gifts that only the anointed could endure. This was theirs, and she was in command. Submission to Devlin granted her command. In this role, she could proffer to her husband the things he would return for, again and again, like the incessant lure of crocodile-infested drinking water to thirsty gazelles. Water was life; but illicit pleasure was a benefaction that no one else had the ascendancy to provide to Josh.

So she whimpered and moaned and obeyed Devlin's demands, leaving the blindfold on, rolling to her back, letting Devlin guide her into a comfortable position, resting a pillow under her head. Then one under her lower back. Devlin sought to reveal to Josh her deepest of secrets.

She would perform for Josh during this ceremony. Provide a show like no other, perform an unholy theater he would never forget, that he would hide in his deepest, darkest file folder where no one would think to look. And on those horny, sleepless nights when he needed something to send him into a sexual stratosphere, he could open this file, replay it, and hit an ecstasy like nothing else. And he would equate the power of that experience to her. Done at his request. The two of them working together.

She lay with the soles of her feet on the bed, knees up, legs spread to allow Devlin into the space between her thighs. Devlin's hands crested the points

of her knees, caressed them. He got into place, and she waited, feeling his warmth, feeling the weight of his body on the bed with her. He tweaked her nipples, and she mewled the most girlish sound she could muster. Writhing and moaning now, eager for him to keep doing what he was doing. Then the weight of his cock fell on her tummy, and what had been an act began to turn, became no more a performance than an actual reaction. She craved his cock. Wanted it. Wanted to feel the amazing sex he gave her—and couldn't wait for Josh to watch something he could never do to her.

And her hands were free now. Free to roam and explore. Her eyes were shielded, hiding in the dark, but her hands communicated, read the world around her, translated touch to thought. Devlin was muscular. Bulky, powerful. Yet trim and toned, too. Wide, hard shoulders, narrow waist. Her hands roamed his arms and shoulders, caressed them; played the act of timidity, too. Because while her hands read Devlin's body, Josh would be reading them as well. They should tell a story. Tell a story of familiarity but regret; a story of apology and of helpless feminine lust. Which was true. She'd been somehow helpless in all of this at the beginning. It didn't even seem like she was the same woman who'd gone after Devlin at Tiffany's party. Who'd rolled around on the ground with him—knowing it wasn't a fight, knowing she didn't want combat with him. What had she even wanted? Amy had sparked it. That snide reminder of her worst night's humiliation. Of the sorrow she'd felt afterward, at the emotional wounding of it all. Devlin and Amy. Amy, her friend. Devlin the hottest, richest guy at Dalton High. And she hated Devlin. Hated him, but wanted him. Wanted his dominance. Wanted his assurance. Wanted Devlin to want her, rolling in the grass with him, a married woman. That was really it. Grant me worthiness. Set my shame upright. Remove the burden of my teenage indignity.

Devlin's huge hand spread on her naked chest, thumb pad and pinky tip abusing her nipples. He got into place, the front of his strong thighs bracing against the backs of her thighs. She put her feet over the other side, getting them nice and close. The weight of his cock rested on her belly and over her mound. And she really couldn't wait for his return. Her pussy throbbed in his massive absence.

With her hands free, she was able to explore, show Josh her familiarity with the totem between Devlin's legs; the one thing that frightened her husband most in this world. She ran finger pads up and down the topside, feeling the bulky swollen ripple of the flared lip of his enormous cock head. Lifted it from her stomach, stroked it upright, holding it out where she knew Josh would see it. Josh would forever remember the sight of his wife's hand on his bully's huge cock. Every time he would see her hands in the future, he would remember this day. She stroked Devlin now, her fingers curling his enormous girth, her thumb riding upright, the cushion slipping up and down, easing in and out of the channel of his frenulum, swirling the cup of Devlin's urethra. Then she used two hands. And found something surprising. "Oh, you're so fucking hard," she whispered. "You've never been harder." Devlin loved Josh watching. Devlin loved how Josh witnessed his supreme sexual power over his wife, how Josh's wife worshipped his much bigger cock. "You're so big. You're so thick," she said, one hand dropping to cup his scrotum. Devlin was so large, so aroused to extreme hardness today, it was like his scrotum had pulled up tight to offer his shaft the extra skin needed to support this increased size. The curve in his shaft was more pronounced at this hardness. She even suspected he might not last very long with Josh watching. There were the soft plops of excess seminal fluid spilling from Devlin's slit onto her pubic pad. Her grip went slipperier with his added lubrication. Their connection was as wet as if they'd used half a jar of lube. Both of them loved Josh watching.

But it was she who was in control. Without her, these two men would be alone and wanting. Empty, their desires unfulfilled. She was the conduit that afforded them each their kinkiest, most forbidden desires. She'd used both of them to shape the other, and was the one who reaped the rewards in the end. As did they. They were a strange symbiotic identity that fed and ate from one another; but without her, they were both nothing.

She top-handed Devlin's massive cock and guided him lower, easing him between her thighs and nestling the huge end into her opening. He pushed inside her, and she aided his entry, then let his cock go, biting her own lip and putting her hands up onto the pillow on either side of her face; another act of submission; a guileful portrayal of innocence.

Devlin pushed in with a grunt, spreading her in a delicious swell that tickled the top of her brain. They were slippery, and the stretch was amazing. So much better than laying on her side. On her back she was open and passive, and his weapon did the work it was intended for without mercy. He was so fucking big. So fucking hard.

She gasped and sighed and rose her eyebrows high above the blindfold; honest but amplified. Whispering oh-my-god and moaning and whimpering. Could Josh even stand this?



Kimmy was tall but petite. Skinny, flat bellied, a tiny waist. Josh's eyes remained glued to a ripple in his wife's stomach, like the crown of a beaver's skull sliding silently above a pond's smooth and still surface. Kimmy had told him once Devlin's cock was two-toned, like a horse's. Told him it had a crook. No lies. She'd been honest with him, but had withheld so much.

The beaver's skull was the oscillating node of Devlin's cock head inside his wife. Devlin was rock hard. Kimmy had even sounded wowed and impressed handling that massive pipe. Like Devlin had never been this hard before. His brow furrowed deeper, thinking of Kimmy with Devlin, maybe in Cayman, while her dopey husband waited for her return, and Devlin was fucking her, and Kimmy was in awe, watching the effect his outsized organ had on her body. She was too small to take him. Devlin was too big. His cock pushed her body to obvious limits. The beaver swam back, then forward; back a little again, then forward. Getting deeper. Maybe ten inches inside his wife. Into parts of Kimmy's body he could never touch. And if those spots could promote pleasure, then he would never satisfy her that way. Never give her the contact of his glans against her furthest interior.

Devlin saw it, too. Devlin watched Kimmy's taut tummy ripple with his passage. He even growled a sound of masculine appreciation. Loving that

he could do this to another man's wife. Do it while her meek husband watched.

"Fuck, you're so tight," he groaned. "Look at that tummy. You're so fucking sexy."

Kimmy barely responded, her body still and accepting, afraid to move like she was receiving an administration in the hospital. Subjected and submitted; accommodating despite the discomfort.

"Look how deep she takes it, Josh. And she grips it the whole way like it's her hand. And she loves it deep. She gets off on it. Watch..."

Josh waited, his breath short on the inhale, hot and heavy on the exhale. Eyes glued. Heart hammering. Stomach slithering with erotic disgust.

"Kimmy, your body is so fucking incredible," Devlin said now, putting his hand down on her stomach, resting his fingertips on her waist and caressing the raised hump of his cock head as it pushed up her tummy. "Fucking balls deep, Josh. Balls deep. Mm, Kimmy. Holy fuck."

But now he withdrew a few inches, the cock head disappearing, Devlin's hand moving to Kimmy's neck, cupping the nape. "Come up a little," he said to her, guiding her chin down, making her tummy wrinkle in lines as she performed an abbreviated stomach crunch, rocking his hips and pushing Kimmy's rump against the pillow bunched under the small of her back. He pushed in again and Kimmy cried out a sound Josh would never forget. It was incredible. She sounded like she'd orgasmed. Her head thrust back and broke free from Devlin's grip. The end of Devlin's cock couldn't be detected anymore in the flat of her stomach. But Kimmy whimpered and whined and brought both her hands to cover her face. Her breath snorted against her palms.

"Deep secrets, Kimmy," Devlin said, smiling. "That's it. Fuck, you feel good. Rock with me..."

Devlin rolled his hips, his cock buried balls-deep inside Kimmy. And Kimmy trembled and shook, her breath roaring through her palms,

shuddering every other heartbeat. Then she panted, “Oh, god, oh, fuck,” over and over, pausing, holding her breath, letting it all out. After an endless heart shattering moment, she began to undulate her hips too, humping against Devlin’s deep burial. Her hands came away and Josh watched her beautiful mouth hang open, her white teeth showing. She would pant and then she would hiss with clenched teeth.

“Kimmy’s got a G-spot up here, Joshy. You ever hit it?”

Of all Devlin’s taunts, none hit him harder. No, he hadn’t. Was this what they did together? Every lunch, did Kimmy need this big dick treatment like some sort of sexual therapy? Did she start to sweat when it was eleven-thirty and she’d be hitting the sexual lunch room in half an hour and a man with the biggest dick she’d ever seen was going to do things her husband couldn’t? Was this the release of hysterics? Devlin was like some big dick doctor with Kimmy’s cure at the end of his massive cock, that engorged head nestled in her deepest cavity and stretching it out.

“She’s going to come, Joshy. You ever seen your wife squirt? I bet you didn’t know Kimmy’s a squirter.”

NINETEEN

PALE, IRE, ENVIE AND DESPAIR

Devlin's noose tightened further, and Josh could barely breathe or swallow. Yes, Kimmy was a squirter. She began reacting to sex that way shortly after she began working at Stone Brokerage LLC. The barb was sharp and rusty and lashed him with precision. Watching Devlin's massive endowment balls deep inside his wife, his wife on the verge of an orgasm right in front of her husband. This was what he'd missed. What he witnessed right now was what had happened all those times behind his back. He could picture it like some sort of hot-blooded tryst, some slick blue movie with good lighting, but here it was in reality: bright daylight, no camera tricks, no shadows to let the imagination fill in the details. This was high definition reality, a gross display of biological reaction, like a doctor's permission to sit in on a surgery from the operating theater. Kimmy had a spot she liked touched, and Devlin showed her where to find it with the head of his cock. Up deep inside her where her husband couldn't ever find it. You needed the right body position; you needed the right angle; you needed a pillow under her back. You needed a big manly cock, long and thick, and with a plum-sized fist at the end.

He could tell Devlin he knew Kimmy squirted—had witnessed it himself through his own meager provocation—but how would that sound to Kimmy now? Kimmy knew when this particular extreme bodily response had begun, when her ability had been unlocked, and knew it as well as Josh. His response would sound lame and empty, defiant to Devlin, but watery to his wife. His fucking wife, who'd learned to squirt through another man's deep and skillful harpooning.

His purpose here today had been to swipe power from Devlin. To show Devlin what Devlin thought was power over Josh Waters was imaginary.

But it wasn't imaginary. He'd fooled himself. It was real. It was palpable. This display was worse than he could have conjured in his own mind.

And yet the arousal remained.

It remained because, while destructive and debasing, the act he watched was erotic. Taboo. Forbidden. Earned through grift and bold betrayal. But now Kimmy showed him why. If he'd ever wondered why Kimmy would do this to him, this display should explain it all. Kimmy quivered and moaned and gasped. Her head rocked, her hands beat on the bedding, clutched her hair, grabbed at Devlin's thighs. And she was in command. All Devlin provided was his big cock and some hip-grinding, and Kimmy did the work needed to get off. She shimmied her hips, rolled them, humped against the intrusion. A sheen had risen on her skin, an overall silky frost of pre-orgasmic sweat. The sounds she mewled and cried were incredible; they were music. He would never forget them. He couldn't even if he tried. They were like a siren's wail to a helpless sailor; a sailor who knew the song would bring him ruin but was gulled, nevertheless. Maybe those sailors craved their ruin. Because he craved his own ruin right now. He listened with intent, watched her sins with fervor. Kimmy only showed him what he'd requested.

So he sat still in stiff and silent composure, dying, living, all at once, crumbling and forging a stony armor to resist the worst of Devlin's brutal cudgeling.

But this was the challenge. This was why he'd come. To face his fears. To stand tall in the face of superior might. A Davy to a Goliath, using wit and guile to forge a makeshift courage, a shoddy boat to sail a stormy sea. But he wouldn't abandon his tiny ship. He wouldn't scream, yell, or throw a single lamp. He wouldn't spit in their faces. He would take it. He would take it like it was nothing. His interior—the roasting meat inside the armor—may rot and leak out the seams, but with any strength he could muster, he would show them no response. He would never show Devlin the Josh Devlin wanted to see.

Now Devlin cupped his hands on Kimmy's knees, drawing them down to grip her ankles, then guiding them up so the soles of her feet rested on his

hips. It exposed her further to his penetration. Kimmy responded. She loved the way the new angle allowed Devlin greater access. It changed the pitch of her cries. They were already bright, ecstatic chirps, but now they became long, keening notes full of breath and desperation. Devlin held her feet, pushed on them till Kimmy's knees went up to her chest. This had Kimmy slapping her hands down on the bed and gripping the cover. Devlin began thrusting; staccato bursts of hip-driving that shook the bed and warbled Kimmy's cries.

Devlin said, "Come closer, Josh. Come up on the bed. Use your fingers and play with her clit. We'll make her crazy today."

But Josh stayed where he was, turned to stone by his Medusa wife. He could only watch as Devlin jack-hammered his hips into Kimmy, her thighs shaking with each quick salvo, her toes curling and flexing, her keening note becoming constrained as she tightened her whole body against what Josh knew was coming. Her hands left the bedding and gathered at her neck, her fingers scratching at her collarbone, head pushing back into the pillow, her chin pointing up to the ceiling. Her lips pulled back in a fangy snarl and the cords stood out on her neck. She cursed and gasped now, saying the F word, then letting Devlin know she was going to come.

Devlin growled, "Yeah, you're going to come. You know you're going to come. I can feel your guts gripping the head of my cock. Come for me. Show Josh how you come."

Her hands thrashed from her neck to land fists on the bedding, and then she hollered out a sound of dreadful release. Her whole body seized and her feet pointed like a ballet dancer, her knees touching together over her chest. She rocked and bowed her back, her body twitching, her mouth opened and closed. There was a moment of creaky sound in her throat, and then she bucked and wailed and gasped, her hands covering her face. She was coming.

A pattering squirt tinkled up Devlin's stomach. Steady pulses. A second of spray, a pause, a second more, over and over as she came on Devlin's huge cock.

Josh closed his eyes and breathed. Listening to the sounds of his wife after her powerful orgasm. She panted heavily through her mouth, closing her mouth and snorting through her nose. Not catching her breath. He opened his eyes again to see Devlin rubbing her knees, lowering her legs so they draped over his thighs again. Kimmy had gone powerless under Devlin's fucking. Her hands returned to her face, uncoordinated, taking three attempts to get both thumbs under the tie around her eyes before lifting it up from her brow. She didn't open her eyes, but her lashes fluttered. She still panted, heaving for breath, pausing to swallow, then panting harder for a moment. She removed his tie from her head and threw it down beside her on the bed, her eyes now struggling to open. When she opened them, she threw a forearm over them right away to protect them from the bright of the day.

And the shame of her actions.

Things must appear much different when your eyes were open.



The whooshing sound of the ocean's waves roared in her ears with the timing of her racing pulse; the in and out of heavy waves on a sandy shore.

Now Josh had seen. He'd wanted to know, and now he knew. There was no shame, though she knew there should be. There had been at one time. At one time she'd battled the shame a lot. But this time, she'd done it for Josh. That was a show just for her husband. An eroticized performance.

As her breath returned, she managed a few breathy chuckles of disbelief. Yes, it had been a show, but Devlin's sexual prowess was no illusion. The orgasm was real. The effect on her was real. Devlin had left her exhausted with just that brief escapade, heart hammering.

She uncovered her eyes again, her arms at her side, blinking against the brightness. In this light, Josh would have missed nothing. No detail spared.

Devlin rolled his hips and the movement of his cock inside her got her jumping and squawking. Post orgasm, his cock sent silvery thrills through her that were too much to bear. "Careful, careful," she said to him, resting her hands on her ribs. Devlin eased his cock out of her, knowing how sensitive she could be right after coming; pulled it right out with a slick squelch and dropped its weight on her stomach with a wet slap. She moaned and pushed her pussy against his balls, wanting Josh to get a good look at how deep inside her his bully's cock reached. It turned Josh on. No matter how much he fought it, this aroused her husband.

"Oh, god," she sighed, rolling her eyes up to the room's high ceiling. "Oh fuck, that's good."

Devlin said, "You feel better?" Phrasing it to Josh in a way that sounded like Josh's wife needed something her husband couldn't provide. Which was true...

She'd always hated Devlin's taunts about Josh. But didn't hate it when she did it herself. Like she didn't trust Devlin with such a powerful instrument. Wielded the wrong way it could provoke lasting injury. And in the end, now that it was all out in the open and there was nowhere left to hide, she hated the realization that she was no better. In fact, she was worse. She'd tricked herself into thinking Josh wanted it and that gave her license, and then somewhere in this Homeric odyssey, she'd sexualized Josh's torment. Had assumed the role of chief tormentor. And it had turned her on.

So she smoothed a hand over Devlin's cock, struggling to grip its width, lifting it and letting it drop again on the flat of her tummy. It looked gnarly and sexual, the way it shone, the way it looked so otherworldly. He was massive. Harder than she'd ever remembered him. The veins rose out against the skin, that crook showed a sharper curve; the flared lip of his cock was swollen and rubbery. She played with it while Josh watched.

At last she regarded Josh, seated bedside, liking how she would appear to him, come-hazy, eyes half-lidded, holding her lover's big, sexy cock. No

one could ever gift Josh something so delicious. She bit her lower lip, looking into Josh's eyes, trying to read him but finding him unreadable. She told him with her eyes that she was still horny and her lover was still hard and she wanted Josh to watch more. And more.

Fuck, she liked being seen this way.

With three fingers on the broad head of Devlin's cock, she pressed it into her tummy, swirling it against her navel, wowed as Josh must be that this enormous thing fit inside her body. Devlin drew it back and gripped it, teased her pussy with it, placing it back into her aperture and easing it inside. She groaned and closed her eyes, parting her lips, wondering what most would drive Josh wild after he'd just witnessed the most wicked she could be.

There was more wicked, but she wouldn't do that. Not that anymore. Especially not now.

And Devlin would want it. Devlin would demand it.

She moved fingers over her bursting clit, her own touch putting sparks in her vision. She said, "Don't come inside me."

Devlin chuckled, sawing his cock in and out in easy depths, saying now, "What do you say, Josh?"

Josh spoke, voice cracked and broken. "Whatever she wants."

Josh was disengaged, lost. She looked at him, frowning, scrutinizing him. She shook her head no. She carried Josh's baby. Devlin's semen was no longer welcome.

But what if it wasn't Josh's?

She gasped and drew in a long, hissing breath through closed teeth. The wickedest thought of them all.

TWENTY

OF SORROW UNFEIGN'D

The submission to her desires had delivered her pleasure, but the betrayal did, too. The betrayal and the cruelty. As Devlin had told her over drinks at the Royal York: Josh lures his own torment. The meek summons the strong. She'd thought it was bull shit, but there was something about Josh that begged for it. Something in him that wanted the worst; that demanded it. Somehow he'd summoned his own devils, brought out the worst in others. Josh defined himself through the perception of the dominant. Josh found power in resentment; he fed off it.

The arousal that wickedness brought her was only because she loved Josh. That was her and Josh's intertwined life now. Wasn't it? Definitely. It was sacred.

Josh's trembling eyes roamed the scene. His wife post-orgasm, his bully's massive cock back inside her again; and his wife was getting off on it, writhing with Devlin's gentle fucking, readjusting her sensitive and quivering interior to his demanding size. That unreadable expression twitched and turned down, assuming something more surly, his delightful brain at work.

He said, "It's only urine."

She moved her gaze from Josh up to Devlin, looming between her thighs, Devlin regarding Josh. Devlin looked at her, pausing his fucking, and their eyes met. Both of them burst into breathy chuckles. She clamped a hand over her mouth to stifle the laughing, embarrassed, seeing herself as too aligned with Devlin, not wanting to be Josh's bully, but to be his divine benefactor of highly tuned and delightful woe, his High Priestess of Sexual Anguish. But definitely not his bully. Not his Devlin. And not Amy.

Josh's frown deepened, and his cheeks blushed. His mouth trembled. She whispered to Devlin, "Stop, stop, stop," and put up her palms to indicate for him to halt.

Josh said, "I mean, you just, like her bladder gave out, 'cause..."

She slipped away from Devlin and off the bed, suddenly feeling far too naked, her hand covering between her thighs, where Devlin had just been. Even the pressure of her own fingers to where Devlin stretched her brought sexual static and electric aftershocks. The seismic orgasm Devlin delivered hadn't abandoned her yet. Josh watched her coming, not liking it, not wanting her comfort right now. She went to one knee before him. She asked him what he needed.

"Nothing. I'm fine."

She took his hand and held it. "I didn't mean to laugh."

Josh winced in pain, hating her words.

"It was the perfect thing for you to say. That's why I thought it was funny. That was the Josh I know."

Josh's eyes flitted, his mouth working out what to say, his brow a tense line. "I'm not trying to be funny."

She asked him again. "What do you need right now?"

"Nothing, Kimmy," he said, vexed. "Just keep going."

She thumbed his knuckles, chewing her cheek. It was the perfect thing for Josh to say; it had betrayed so much about how his mind worked. He'd just watched his bully fuck his wife so good she'd been turned to useless goo, coming so hard she'd squirted. And Josh had said the expected retort, something that amounted to an Oh, yeah? or a So what, big deal? While it was funny, she didn't like that role for him. He deserved a better position.

She let his hand go and rubbed both his forearms. "Why don't you take that jacket off?"

His lip curled, saying, “Why?”

“Because I want you to.”

Behind her, Devlin said, “Do what she says, Josh.”

She didn’t look at Devlin, but answered, “I don’t need your help.” Then to Josh: “Come on. If the sin is the penitence, it’s because you want the sin. It’s why I’m doing it.”

Josh said nothing, but she could hear his answer in her own head: You don’t have to like it so much.

She answered as if he’d stated it out loud. “I liked it because you were watching, Josh. That’s why you’re here. . . . Take off your jacket, please.”

Josh sat forward and pulled the jacket off. She wanted to run her hands up his leg and test his hardness, but the effect of seeing his bully pleasure his wife like no one else could had put a bad spin on Josh’s experience. She didn’t want to push him too far, didn’t want to touch his dick and have him push her hand away. Or worse, have it go off in his pants and ruin the progress. The act with Devlin today was for Josh; was to grant her atonement. Josh wasn’t there yet, but he could be pushed or pulled to that place if she worked with him.

“Tell me what you want, Josh. I’ll do it. I’ll do anything for you.”

Behind her again: “How about what I want?”

She looked over her shoulder to regard Devlin on his knees still, awaiting her return, his cock in his hand and working to maintain his hardness.

Josh said to Devlin, “What do you want?”

There was strength in Josh’s voice, the statement like a challenge. He sounded unafraid again. The secret was to keep Josh in contrast with Devlin, remove herself from Devlin as much as she could and still keep Josh entertained.

Devlin flashed a smile, regarding Josh with sly approval. “Why stop at your jacket? Let’s get those pants off you.”

Kimmy looked back to Josh, and Josh watched Devlin over her shoulder with a cold stare. She asked him if he wanted that. He said, “I want you to be yourself. I want you to show me what you are.”

“What do you mean, what I am?”

Josh steadied his eyes on hers and spoke clearly. “I want you to show me how wicked you are,” he said, slowly, taking his time with each word.

“Josh likes a bad girl,” Devlin said.

Josh kept his eyes on hers, saying, “I guess I do.”

Devlin said, “If you like a wicked woman, Josh, you hit the fucking jackpot. Kimmy Chang is the devil.”

She scoffed and rolled her eyes, retreating from Josh, but he held her wrist to stop her.

“Is this what it’s like with him? What I watched, was this how it was all the times you were with him?”

Her lips slimmed, but she didn’t shy away. “Yeah,” she said. “Pretty much.” Then she grooved from the sickly look on Josh’s face, her husband hating that answer but loving it just the same, probably coming in his pants from hearing it. “Why else would I do it?”

Josh nodded, grim, eyes blazing with a dark sexual fire she loved.

“Do you want to see more?”

Josh’s nod was almost unnoticeable (still struggling to hide the truth from her). But, yes, he did want to see more. “I told you what I want.”

Devlin said, “He wants to watch you misbehave.”

“You’re wicked,” Josh said. “Show me how wicked you are.”

But she didn’t like the assessment, the bullying demand and castigation. She furrowed her brow in a play on wounding, saying, “That’s all I am to you?”

Josh showed the slightest amount of amusement, but then it twisted into something more shocked, more disbelieving—the look of an apostate, his faith diminished at the sight of her weakness. He narrowed his eyes, shaking his head, lost in skepticism. “That’s the stupidest thing I’ve heard you say, and you’re not stupid.”

Josh saw through the theatric offense, and she did feel stupid for trying something so lame when he’d been treated to her worst. That must have seemed juvenile to him. She’d shown him stark betrayal; too much, too close, and he wouldn’t trust her again. That truth disheartened her for a moment. And, somehow, this time, she really was wounded. She said, “I’m everything to you. At least I hope I am. I want to be everything.”

Josh’s lips slimmed, and he studied her further, that momentary shaken faith dissipating, his eyes seeking truth in her words. She did her best to convince him with her eyes, wanting him to trust her, to put his most valuable vulnerabilities in her hands. She would tease him with them, make them huge until his cock exploded in his pants. Soon, those huge things would become small, and maybe they wouldn’t scare him so much.

“I want to be everything to you,” she said again. “I want to be the one who gives you everything you’ve dreamed of. And everything we both dreamed of.”

Devlin sighed, impatient.

The power of her temptation showed in Josh’s eyes. He wanted it to be true. And it was—it was her betrayal that had shaken his faith. She said, “Tell me what you want. Tell me what you want right now. Please, baby.”

Josh exhaled and closed his eyes, his head rocking back. The sun played on his troubled features. When he opened his eyes again, the sun filled them

with color. He said, “Don’t hold back.”

“Don’t hold back? That’s what you want?” She cupped a hand to his cheek, delighted he didn’t pull away.

“Show me your worst. I want to see it.”

She said, “I will. I will, for you.”

So, she rose, for some reason still with a hand between her thighs and covering his closeup view of her swollen and punished sex, and turned to Devlin. “And what do you want?”

Devlin smiled and pulled her onto the bed, manhandling her and getting her to lie face down on the bed, legs spread on either side of his knees. “Stay down like that, stay flat on your stomach,” he said, and she obeyed him, turning her head to the left to look at Josh.

Josh watched as Devlin lowered his body over hers, his cock coming down on one butt cheek and then hoisted into position between her cheeks, dangling down to touch her sex. He grunted as he shoved his cock inside her again, and she groaned and narrowed her eyes, loving his thick return. He fucked her shallow from this angle, bouncing above her, his hands on either side of her shoulders. The bed squeaked with their rocking and Josh watched, cheeks drawn, his expression aghast. Despite the extreme duress, she marveled at how good Josh looked. The suit fit him well, and even stripped down to the dress shirt, no tie, collar open, he looked handsome with the daylight behind him. The new haircut showed him less boyish, more masculine, and her husband wore it well.

Devlin fucked her like that, slowly building up to a deeper penetration, and as he returned his stretch to her depths, she began to moan, narrowing her eyes, the vision of Josh warbling. “Oh, you’re so fucking big,” she whispered in a breathy voice. “You feel so good, mm, keep going, ah, not too deep yet.”

Devlin slowed, rolling his hips on the thrust, the angle changing, swirling, stretching her in incredible ways. Her mouth hung open, and her moans

turned to high cries that whined with each of Devlin's thrusts.

Josh's fervor had returned in a fiery glory, his eyes widened, soaking in every iota of visual information while his bully fucked his wife. He leaned forward with his elbows on his knees. "Do you fuck him every day?"

Devlin was quicker than her, chuckling, saying, "I wish."

"No, Josh," she said. "It wasn't like that."

Josh's brow lowered, and he leaned even closer, his eyes troubled despite the scorn his features showed. "Did you fuck him in Grand Cayman?"

AFTERWORD

I hope you enjoyed this penultimate episode! I know I said there were only going to be 12 books, but please consider 13 the Devil's Dozen. There will be one more book to wrap up all the lingering questions and closing all the loose threads.

The 13th book, The Unity of Opposites, is already under way on my Patreon and on my Ream and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

ktmorrison.com

On my Patreon and on my Ream you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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